

A close-up, low-angle shot of a woman's back and shoulder. She is wearing a black sports bra. Her dark hair is visible on the right side of the frame. The lighting is warm and soft, highlighting the contours of her skin.

KENNY WRIGHT
TRAINING 3
TO LOVE IT

A Wife Watching Romance

ONE

I checked my phone for the hundredth time, its bright screen lighting up to show a photo of me and my wife, Erin, smiling, cheek-to-cheek. But no texts. No emails. Nothing for the last two hours.

I focused on the photo—a moment caught from a time just before AJ entered our lives. Erin's smile reached her eyes, vibrant green with whatever filter I'd applied to it. Her dark hair wasn't quite as long as it was now, just barely reaching her shoulders in loose waves. I was half-turned to look at her, my brown hair flecked with gray, on the cusp of needing a cut. My face was a little softer than it is now, before AJ and his training tips, and I'd carried a bit more weight around my midsection back then. We were a good looking couple. We had a good life, with smart and well-behaved kids and a comfortable existence in the suburbs of DC.

Yet here I was now, sitting on my hands at home while my wife was on a date with another man.

I darkened the phone once again, shoved it into the pocket of my jeans, and went back to pacing the living room. This part—the waiting game—was the hardest. Having witnessed what Erin was capable of doing only made these times more nerve-racking. AJ had introduced her to the craziest things—he spanked her, he tied her up, he dominated her. She'd taken on two guys for him. She'd been DP'ed! Thing was, as wrong as all of that was, I loved that she possessed that naughtier side.

I checked my phone again. No messages. Where was she now? Back at AJ's place, face down on his bed as he fucked her ass? Did he have her in cuffs? Was he making her scream?

“Gah!” I was so hard. I stalked to the window, pulling the curtain aside. It had begun to snow out there, a light dusting just beginning to stick to the roads. Some of the neighbors had already hauled their Christmas trees out onto the curb—and it wasn’t even New Year’s yet.

The snow was just the beginning. A blizzard was rolling in. We’d all hoped it would hit in time for a white Christmas, but nothing in life ever lined up so perfectly.

I watched the flurries turn the street into something out of a Norman Rockwell illustration. The lamps cast pools of fluttering light in regular intervals along the sidewalk. Most of the houses along the street were dark, their inhabitants gone for the holidays. A few were lit up brightly, lights strung up, chimneys puffing the smoke of fireplaces. In each of those homes, normalcy played out. Christmas music played. It smelled like wood-burning hearths and hot chocolate. No one else would be waiting around for their wives to get back from their lovers.

AJ’s apartment was in the city, although ever since he’d signed on as Lamar Williamson’s personal trainer, he spent more time in LA than DC. He’d been up in New Jersey with his family for Christmas, and decided to swing by his home for a few days before the New Year. Erin was the first person he called, looking for a booty call.

He wants to see me tonight, Erin had said, a sly smile on her lips.

I told her to go for it. It has been a few weeks since she’d hooked up with AJ and Lamar at the gym. *Bet you’re looking for your fix*, I’d said.

You know all I need is you.

But I knew that this wasn’t exactly true. She had... something with AJ that she didn’t have with me. Fix wasn’t a bad way to think about it. If Erin had a drug, AJ was it.

Outside, the snow began to pick up. A car drove by, its tracks disappearing quickly. At this rate, Erin would be snowed in at AJ’s. Something uncomfortable and angry

shifted inside of me at the thought. I watched the snow fall silently and thought about Erin getting fucked out of her mind, oblivious to the inclement weather just outside. Would she come out of her state of euphoria, dripping sweat and filled with A.J.'s come, only to realize there was too much snow on the ground for her Toyota to handle? Would she laugh and say, *Guess I'll just have to spend all night. Want to keep me warm?*

Why was I cripplingly jealous yet hyper-turned-on by that? What the hell was wrong with me?

Another pair of headlights appeared at the end of our street, the car moving slowly. Its light was muted by the churning white of the snow. I recognized the car, but didn't quite believe it until the small sedan pulled into our driveway. Erin was home.

"You're home!" I said. Erin came in, slumping against the front door. She let out a heavy sigh before she began to brush snow off her dark coat.

"Good session?" I asked.

Erin flashed a smile at me. It was funny that we continued to pretend she was going out for workouts. "Yeah, good session. I'm sore everywhere."

Her dark hair was down, dappled with unmelted flakes. She looked up at me and I swear that her face was glowing.

"You're home early," I said.

"Didn't want to get caught out in the snow," she said. She shrugged out of the coat. Beneath was the casual clothing she'd worn when she left—tight jeans, brown boots, a light brown sweater. It wasn't an outfit to seduce. They'd moved beyond that.

"It's getting hairy out there."

"Yeah. I wasn't sure you'd make it back in time." I felt like an idiot as soon as I said it, and my angst melted away. Of course Erin would never let something like that happen.

She floated over to me, her brow furrowed as she studied me. I felt like she was rooting through my mind. She

did that sort of thing all the time. It was a reminder of how close we were. "You thought I'd stay the night?"

"Silly of me, I know."

"Very." She touched my face. Her hand was cold from the weather outside. I felt exposed before her bright green irises. "Did you get all jealous?"

"Maybe."

"Well...you probably should be a *little* jealous...after..." She pressed herself against me. "After what AJ did to me..." Her hand glided down between us, over my hard cock.

"What did he do to you?" My heart raced.

"So many dirty things."

When I found my voice, it was low, husky enough to surprise even me. "I bet you liked that, didn't you?"

"Want to reclaim me as your wife?"

I took her hand and led her toward the stairs. She slipped past me, wiggling her hips as she took to the stairs. I couldn't help it. Even after ten years together, I checked her out. She had such a fantastic ass, heart-shaped and ripe beneath the hourglass curves of her gym-honed body. AJ loved it, too, and I wondered if her former personal trainer had taken her there tonight. It made my already erect cock twitch.

I touched her butt, feeling how cold it was through the denim. Erin shot me a wicked smile over her shoulder, but didn't slow until we were safely in our bedroom and the door was locked behind us.

I moved up behind her, running my hands over her chest. She wasn't wearing a bra through her sweater, I realized, her warm tits filling my hands. I leaned in, my lips brushing her ear as she tipped her head to the side. "Tell me what he did to you."

"I knew we didn't have much time, with the snow and all," she said, her voice low. I grasped the bottom of her sweater and pulled it up. She took over for me to lift it over

her head, then continued. "So I was hoping he'd just fuck me. But you know AJ. He had other plans."

I didn't know AJ. Not that well. I mean, I knew him through Erin's stories, and for a while, I'd acted as her double agent, going so far as to hire him as my own trainer without his knowing I was her husband. But my impression of him was mostly just an ego-driven, brash, young bachelor. I didn't know him like Erin did.

I kissed her neck as I moved my hands down her warm body, caressing her soft skin. When they arrived at the top of her jeans, I went to work on the snap. "Did he make you suck his cock?"

"He always does."

I worked open her jeans, and she shimmied out of them, making sure to wiggle her ass against my crotch as she did so. Beneath, she still wore her thong—simple, white, and incredibly sexy. I ran my hands down the front, sliding my fingers across her smooth mound. She'd shaved recently, not a single curl present. She'd done that for AJ—initially, anyway. She'd done a lot of things for AJ. At first, it had troubled me. Now, I had to thank the man.

She was wet, and I easily pressed a finger inside of her. "Did he push you to your knees?"

"Yes," she groaned.

"Did that turn you on?"

"Uh huh." She reached behind me, seeking my cock. I made room for her. I'd changed into my pajamas, and she easily slipped her hand into my boxers. "It turns you on, too, doesn't it?"

"You know it does." I kissed her throat. "What else did he do?"

Her grip tightened around my cock and she pulled me toward the bed. I withdrew my finger, swirling it across her clit before releasing her. She shivered, shucking the thong as she crawled onto her hands and knees at the edge of our bed.

My eyes moved from her pussy, swollen and ready for me between her thighs, to the iron man tattoo she had on her shoulder. It was discreet, a small dot perched above a blocky M. She'd gotten it with her training group as a sign of solidarity—at least that was the story we told everyone. But whether it was intended or not, to me that tattoo signified the moment that she'd crossed the line with AJ. It was his mark on her, his cuckold claim. It was a symbol of my darkest fantasy made permanent. I hated it as much as I loved it.

I pulled off my shirt and stepped out of my boxers and pants. My cock sprang free, as stiff as it always was on the nights that she'd come home after AJ. She pushed her ass higher, arching her back as she stretched along the bed.

I ran my hand along her ass. It didn't look like he'd taken her back there—not tonight. Heat flashed through me as I considered taking her anally myself. I knew she'd welcome it. Instead, I pressed into her sweet pussy. We groaned together.

"You're so hard," she whispered.

"You're so wet." I pumped her a couple times before something occurred to me. "Is that all you?"

Erin was on the pill, and AJ and Erin got tested regularly so that they didn't have to worry about condoms. The idea of my wife being fucked bareback was a powerful one. Like so much of this fantasy, it was so wrong yet so fucking hot.

"No," she said, squeezing my shaft with the walls of her pussy.

I groaned, nearly losing it.

She said, "He showed me his tests. Said he had them done just for this trip home."

"He wanted to lay claim to you."

Erin laughed, hearty and reassuring. "He wanted to try."

"So tell me more. Tell me what dirty things he did to you."

"He spanked me," she said.

I looked, and now that I was, I noticed the red marks across her ass. It was something I couldn't bring myself to do, yet clearly she got off on it.

"He tied my wrists behind my back and fucked me...kind of like how you're doing me now."

I looked down at her, trying to visualize that. She'd have no leverage. Her face would be buried in the mattress, her ass up, totally at his mercy.

"You like that, don't you?"

"I like it with him."

"Slut."

"With AJ, I'm his slut, yes."

I fucked her harder, feeling adrenaline fuel my thrusts.

"Yes, baby. He fucked me...just like that...with his nice... big...cock..."

"Did he make you come?"

Her voice was tight. "So many times."

"And how many times did he come?"

"Twice." She moaned, getting lost in my rigorous fucking.

"Only twice? He losing his touch?"

Erin's laughter fought through her cries. "Like I said, we didn't have much time." She looked over her shoulder at me, right over the tattoo. "Bet you want to know where he came."

I fanned my fingers on the small of her back, working my hand up her spine. She turned away from me again, digging her elbows into the mattress as she met my thrusts with her own.

"Tell me." It sounded like a growl. Felt like a roar.

"Inside of me the first time. Deep inside of me."

I felt the sudden urge to grab her hair and pull on it like the bridle of a horse. I'd never done that before. Never had the desire. But now...

"After that, he made me suck him back to life. He said he wanted me to taste our come. To remember it."

I could imagine it. Could practically see the muscular personal trainer yank his softening cock from her, only to guide her head into his lap.

"He took control of my head. I could barely breathe. All I could do was try not to gag. He had his hands in my hair, fucking my throat..."

I groaned. "Oh, Erin..."

"Fuck me, Tom. You feel so good."

I dug my hands into her hips, once again thinking about pulling her hair. Aj had. Clearly she liked it. "Dirty girl," I growled. "Coming back with such naughty stories."

"They're not just stories."

"No, I've got proof that they're not." I'd seen the Skype liaison she'd had while I was in New Orleans. I'd watched her fuck other men live, right in front of me. And if I had any doubt, I had a video of her getting tag-teamed by Aj and Lamar Williamson. At the thought of all that, I fucked her even harder, even deeper. "I know what a slut you can be."

"You like it."

"I like it," I agreed. My hands crawled up her body, into her hair before I even realized it. I had a fistful of the silky locks. I clenched my teeth as I pulled back.

Erin yelped, and my apology was on the tip of my tongue before I heard the moan in the mix. She pressed her hips back into me. She was into it.

"He came all over my face, that second time. You like hearing that? It turns you on?"

I pulled her hair harder. I slammed into her deeper. "You...fucking...slut..."

I'm not sure who came first, but all of a sudden I was exploding as Erin's pussy clenched around my shaft and she fought to keep her cries down.

I collapsed in a sweat-bathed heap on top of her, and as the animal lust drained from me, I realized that I was still holding her hair. Releasing it, I kissed her back, right between her shoulder blades. "I'm sorry, did I hurt you?"

Erin said, "A little, but I kind of liked it."

I pulled out of her, my cock already soft, and we rearranged ourselves on the bed, facing one another. We hadn't even turned the lights on in here, and the room was bathed in nothing but the soft glow of the street lamps off of the falling snow. Erin's face was cast in hard shadow, her eyes glittering like emeralds. I thought of the first time I ever looked into those eyes, at the dentist so many years ago. She was a different person back then. I was a different person, too.

I never would have grabbed her hair. I never would have called her a slut...even though that's apparently just what she was. When I'd looked up into her eyes, so long ago, was she then?

"So you had fun tonight?" I asked.

"I did, but in all honesty, the best part is right now, with you."

"I'm glad you came back early," I said.

"Of course I did." She squeezed her hand between us and touched my face. "I'd never choose him over you, Tom."

The man who'd first met Erin over ten years ago—and the man I was up until earlier this year—never would have been this insecure. He wouldn't have worried about losing his wife to a muscle-bound hothead. He probably wouldn't have gotten off on sharing her, either. This fantasy had taken its toll, and yet I couldn't help how turned on it made me, every single damn time.

"I know. Rationally, I know. But sometimes...I'm not always thinking rationally."

Erin drew a long breath in through her nose. "Maybe we should stop. The new year is just a few days away. Clean slate. Start over."

She meant it. I saw the determination harden the lines of her face. Those hard shadows deepened.

"I don't think that's going to work. Not anymore."

"It can," she insisted.

"I don't think either of us really want to stop. We just...need to keep things under control. And keep talking through things."

Erin nodded. "Okay, so...the New Year's Eve party is coming up."

"The Hughes will be there," I said.

The last time I'd seen our neighbors, Haley and Lucas Hughes, had been during a wild weekend in which we'd celebrated Erin and Lucas's birthdays. Between all the drinking, flirting, and dancing—not to mention the years of sexual tension between Erin and Lucas—the four of us found ourselves sharing a hotel room...and each other. It was a turning point between me and Erin. She'd crossed a line, and I'd walked out.

"We can stay in. Do something quiet with the kids," she offered.

"No. I'll need to deal with Lucas at some point. He lives just down the street. We need to work this out. We're adults—we're *men*—not children."

"We could always move?" Her smile told me she wasn't serious.

"He can move."

Her smile softened. "You know that no matter what, you can trust me, right?"

I must have hesitated before nodding, because her smile fell a little more.

"And this is exactly why we should stop. Why we *need* to stop. We need to trust one another, and you don't, and frankly..." She hesitated.

"Yes?"

Erin took a deep, meditative breath. "I know what happened between me and Lucas was a giant mistake. I fucked up, and I'll own that. But you've got to give me the benefit of the doubt here, Tom. I've thought this one through, over and over. You were sending me mixed signals there. You were into it."

I started to deny it before her eyes went wide, her brows up, as if to say, *Really?* “I never liked him.”

“Which made the idea of me and him hotter for you.” She raised herself up onto her elbow. She didn’t look angry or defensive or even all that argumentative. She knew she was right, and she had the confidence to voice it. “Ask yourself this: if you don’t fully trust me, why do you want to keep playing?”

“Because I do trust you.”

Erin studied me for the longest moment without saying anything.

“What?” I finally prompted.

“You’re a beautiful man, and I love you to death, but you can be pretty damn stubborn.” Her face softened and she kissed me. “I’m sorry about Lucas. That was a mistake, and we both know that. But we still haven’t dealt with it. Not completely.”

“Then let’s deal with it.”

She shook her head. “Not tonight. These things take time, and it’s late.” She kissed me. “I love you, baby. And I love this new adventure we’re having, with all its ups and downs. If you want to skip this party, I’m fine staying in.”

She snuggled against me. I kissed her goodnight, but didn’t find sleep easily. I had a lot on my mind. In the darkness, I could admit to myself that part of me really had been excited about the idea of the two of them. It was just so wrong. And when it did happen, I couldn’t deal with it. More upsetting, I *should* have dealt with it much earlier, but I’d just sat there, watching the two of them fuck.

Even now, as I lay there, I felt my cock stir. What the hell was wrong with me?

I groaned and turned onto my side, back to Erin. For a solid minute, I fantasized about skipping the party, about selling our home and moving across town. We had the money to make a move if we wanted to. But then, that

would be admitting defeat. To Lucas Hughes. And the hell with that.

OceanofPDF.com

TWO

I hugged my arms around my body and shoved my hands into my armpits for warmth as the cold, winter air pressed around me. I wondered why I'd left my gloves and hat at home, but I was already in a rush to get to the party. Erin had already been there for a couple hours and...

Something moved inside my chest. I ignored it, hugged myself tighter, and struggled up to the house. I wasn't having these thoughts!

The Gillespies' home was lit up, the New Year's Eve party already in full swing. Cars were lined up outside the newly renovated house, spilling out of the driveway and along the street. Seemed silly to drive the block and a half, but with this cold, I could see why others in the neighborhood had chosen to do so.

I could hear the chatter of people socializing as I stepped up to the front door. I rang the bell, rubbed my hands together for warmth, and wondered what I'd discover on the other side.

"Tom! So good to see you!" Elizabeth Gillespie was older than me and Erin, although her kids were the same ages as Martin and Mary. Elizabeth had been a successful lawyer—along with her husband, Randolph—and chose to have kids later in life. Nothing new for this neighborhood, although it did mean that we socialized with them less. She wore a tiara in her ash brown hair that read 2-0-1-6, and held a half-empty glass of wine.

"Sorry I'm a little late. Had to get some things tied up before the new year," I said.

"No worries. I know how that goes." Elizabeth wore the smile lines around her mouth and eyes with beautiful elegance. "Come on, let's get you out of the cold!"

Inside, the party was in full swing, filled with people standing around, chatting over wine and small plates of finger food. I scanned the gathering for Erin, hoping that the sight of her fresh smile would ease the anxiety crawling up inside my chest. When I didn't immediately find her, that anxiety reached my throat.

Elizabeth misread my expression. "Don't worry, the kids are all in the basement, watching a movie. We got a babysitter."

"Ah, good idea," I said, my voice flat. It was only then that I noticed that there were only a few children in the midst of all the adults, both of them in their early teens. "I'm going to grab a drink. Have you seen Erin?"

I winced at how tacked on that sounded. *I'm not suspicious or anything, but I'd like to make sure my wife hasn't snuck off with—*

Before I could stop myself, I sifted through the gathering again, looking for Lucas Hughes. When I didn't find him, either, the anxiety that I thought I could deal with turned to panic.

"I haven't, but she's around here somewhere." Elizabeth's voice snapped me back into myself just as I was about to lose it. "Drinks are on the table in the living room. Help yourself."

"Thanks, Elizabeth."

"Happy New Year!" she said, then vanished into the crowd.

Now that I was inside, I had a better chance to take in my surroundings. While I recognized many of the faces, I *knew* practically no one. These were Erin's friends. This was Erin's turf. She saw these people on the playground. She ran into them at the supermarket, or during drop-off at the preschool.

All of this was to say that she wouldn't risk that reputation for Lucas Hughes, right?

Not that I was worried about that at all.

I found myself pouring a deep glass of Merlot at the bar before I even realized it, my heart beating like a drum. A woman with pretty red hair that I vaguely recognized stepped up beside me and poured her own glass of Chardonnay. She started to say hello when I shot her a crazed look. She thought better of starting a conversation with me and moved on.

I took a deep breath. I needed to get myself under control. This was crazy. I trusted Erin, I reminded myself. She'd given me no reason to question her intentions.

And yet she did have a wild streak—something that had been awoken by AJ, but something that Lucas was intimately aware of now. She *had* taken things too far with him before. And as much as she reassured me that it would never happen again, she hadn't been faking the pleasure she'd felt as he'd driven his thick cock deep into her.

"Slow down, champ," a familiar voice said.

I blinked. There was Haley, standing before me, looking as pretty as ever.

"Oh, hey."

She lowered her head and raised her eyes, looking at me sheepishly. "Happy New Year," she said with a smile.

"Happy New Year to you, too."

"You just get here?" she asked. She brushed her honey-blond bangs from her eyes. Haley had the quiet beauty of a catalog model. There was nothing particularly striking about her. She wasn't exotic, but she wasn't exactly the girl-next-door that Erin was. Tonight, she wore a sleeved black dress that hugged her slender frame, and her lashes were long and seductive.

"Yeah. Got held up at work."

"On New Year's Eve? You should take a break, you know?"

I studied her. Was she saying something? Did Erin tell her that I was working too much? "Says the woman married to a guy who's never home."

“Touche,” Haley said, raising her glass.

And then, as delicately as I could, I said, “So where is Lucas, anyway?”

Haley raised an eyebrow. I was caught. It was no secret that I didn’t like Lucas—even before he’d fucked my wife. “He’s here, somewhere.” She looked wary. “You’re not going to make a scene are you?”

“Only if I have to,” I said before I could stop myself.

“You know he regrets what happened, right? He just would never admit it. He assumed that you two had it all worked out.”

“And you?”

Finally, some red crept into Haley’s pale cheeks. “I did, too. I mean, we knew about...” She looked around, suddenly remembering where we were. “About the triathlon and all.”

As easy as it was to be angry at Lucas, it was the opposite with Haley. I waved it away and raised my glass. “New year, right?”

Haley released a pent-up breath. “New year, yes.”

The toast was as hollow as the clinking of the glasses, but at least it made peace. For now. “Listen, I need to use the bathroom.”

Haley reclined her head. “It’s good to see you, Tom.” And we went our separate ways.

Mine led me past the bathroom on the main floor and up the stairs, to where the bedrooms were. No one paid me any mind. The party kept on going below me as my anxiety once again rose with each uncertain step. My mind bounced between utter certainty that I would not find Erin fucking Lucas up here, to the crushing inevitability that she was.

How did we get here? How did this happen? And what the hell was I going to do if I did catch them?

By the time I reached the top floor, the Merlot had risen back up my throat as my gut churned. My ears felt like they were as big as lampshades. I heard my thundering heartbeat. The hardwood was new, but it felt like I was

stomping across a rickety, old bridge. Did they hear me? Were they hiding in a bedroom, waiting for me to pass by?

All the doors were shut, no light spilling out from under any of them. I advanced on the first, wondering once again what the hell was I going to do if I found her. The scene played itself out. I'd open the door, Erin would turn to me, gasping, covering her naked body. Lucas would meet my eyes and shoot me a grin that would say: *Thanks again for lending me your slut*. This time, I wouldn't just leave. This time, I'd advance on them, yank Erin off of Lucas, drive my fist into his chiseled jaw.

I pulled open the door, adrenaline coursing through my veins. I felt like the hulk. I felt my shoulders loom up behind me. I could already feel my knuckles making contact with Lucas's trimmed beard.

The room was a bathroom. And it was empty.

I moved on to the next one, but when I yanked open the door, it felt less dramatic. It, too, was empty, one of their children's rooms. Systematically, I checked each room, but I knew that I'd find the same—empty and confusingly innocent.

The last room was the master bedroom, and for a second my heart leapt as I saw a heap on the king-sized bed. A moment later, I realized it was just the coats of all the guests, nothing more sinister than that.

I still had a problem, and by the time I was headed back downstairs, I realized that it was probably a bigger one than finding Erin in one of those rooms. My real problem was that I'd expected to find her in one, and that suspicion was going to destroy me.

This was exactly what Erin had been talking about the other night. About trust. About the lack of it. About this need to get my mind right. And only I could do that.

I found Erin in the basement, watching *The Last Unicorn* with the babysitter and children. Even with Mary in her lap, she was stunning. She wore a red sweater-dress that

hugged her body and dipped low enough to hint at some cleavage without actually offering any. Tonight, her hair was down and loosely curled, falling around her shoulders like a model from the '70s. When had it grown so long?

"You made it," Erin said, smiling up at me.

"Daddy!" Mary cheered.

It was hard to stay upset at Erin in a position like that—not that I was even mad, right?

"Sorry I got held up."

She held out her hand for me to join her on the couch. "You're here now."

I immediately felt guilty for suspecting what I had, then angry that I felt guilty. I went to her, putting on a smile. "You look nice."

"Thanks. I feel a little overdressed down here."

I glanced around at the swath of kids, who were all enraptured by the Gillespies' enormous television. Martin was front and center, sitting cross-legged with his elbows on his knees and his neck bent up toward the screen in a posture that only a little kid could stand.

And in that moment, I saw everything that we were risking. Not just my kids and the comfortable domesticity that we enjoyed, but Erin, holding Mary in her evening wear. It should have been totally incongruous, but it wasn't. It made sense, and I loved it all because it did.

"Let's go on up," I said. "The kids'll be fine for a bit."

As if out of nowhere, the babysitter materialized to take Mary into her lap. Our two-year-old happily went with the teen, and I offered my hand to Erin.

She really did look stunning, I noticed as she rose to full height. The red dress fell to her knees, although as she stood, it crept high enough to give me a peek at her toned thighs, made slightly more tempting by the short heels of her ankle boots.

Erin's beauty went beyond just what she was wearing, or the makeup she'd put on. It was in the way she carried

herself. In the subtle way she swung her hips. She tossed her hair as she passed me on the way to the stairs. I glanced along her body. The knit material really did cling to her curves.

When I looked back up at her face, she was smirking. "You coming?"

"Sorry...distracted."

Erin laughed. "I noticed."

Back upstairs, we joined the adults. We ate cheese and miniaturized meat pies off little plates. We drank wine and talked about resolutions for the new year. Someone had turned on the college football playoffs and I found myself watching the teams go at it without really watching.

Lucas and some of the other husbands were outside, smoking cigars and drinking Scotch. I had no desire to join them, so kept by Erin's side as she socialized with her greater circle of mom friends from the neighborhood. I smiled and nodded and answered questions when they were asked, but I couldn't shake the feeling that *something* was going to happen. I kept looking toward the patio door, where I could just make out the edge of Lucas's broad shoulder.

I forced my eyes to the football game. I couldn't tell you who was playing, or who was winning.

"Ready to leave?" Erin asked, catching my eyes on the television.

"It's only 9:30," I said.

"The kids need to go down. At least Mary." She knew that I was bored and was giving me an out.

A dangerous idea crept into my thoughts. I started speaking before I could fully get a grasp of it. "You want to stay? I could take them home and put them to bed..."

I didn't look toward the patio, I was proud to say, although I felt it drawing me there like a bright light.

Erin looked at me, cocking her head to one side, puzzling me out. Was I that transparent? Was it so obvious

that I was playing with fire. "You're acting strange," she said.

"Am I? Just...I have a lot on my mind."

Her lips flattened into a thin, straight line. She turned to Elizabeth, who happened to be passing by with a fresh tray of egg rolls. "Liz, I'm sorry, but I think we're about to head out," she said.

Elizabeth stopped. "Oh, I'm so sorry to hear that," she said.

"We need to get the kids to sleep."

"I totally understand."

The back and forth had the air of formality to it. This was their way of saying goodbye.

"Want to take anything with you?" Elizabeth continued. "We've got enough bottles of champagne. You two are welcome to take one."

"Oh, no, it's alright," Erin said. "But thank you."

"I'll go get the kids," I said.

She nodded. "I'll get the coats."

Wrestling the kids away mid-movie was difficult. Despite the amount of eye-rubbing going on, neither child would acknowledge that they were actually well past their bedtimes. I finally convinced Martin to leave with me by promising that we'd watch *The Last Unicorn* tomorrow at home.

I made it back to the main floor, with Mary in my arms and Martin in front of me, just as Erin descended from upstairs with our coats...and Lucas Hughes trailing just behind.

Lucas Hughes was a good looking man. As much as I hated him, I could admit that much. He was built like a lumberjack—even had the cropped beard of one—with sandy blond hair that he wore in a rugged fashion and the blue eyes of a predator.

He was laughing as he descended the stairs, and Erin was looking back at him with a smile. The whole thing

ripped through me, stirring up the angst that I'd just buried.

I didn't like that she'd made him laugh. I didn't like that they were talking at all. It was jealousy, pure and raw and difficult to deal with, but it was very real.

Of course, then my mind wandered to things that were completely in my head. Like what they were doing upstairs. It had taken some time to get the kids, how long had they been alone together? I thought of the bed, stacked high with coats. I thought of Lucas throwing my wife on top of them, his broad shoulders looming over her as he powered his lips against her mouth. I felt the sting of betrayal, even though I knew it was all imagined. I looked at Erin and all that anger was back in a flash. She shouldn't have been smiling with him—

We're adults, not children, I reminded myself. I put on a smile.

But she still shouldn't have.

"Happy New Year, Lucas," I said.

"Tom. Happy New Year to you...although we're not quite there yet, are we?" His cruel smile was packed with meaning—*so old that you can't even make it to midnight, man?*

I ignored it and turned to Erin, taking the children's coats. Martin, thankfully, cooperated with me as I got him into his. The last thing I needed was to have a battle of wills with a five-year-old in front of my nemesis.

Erin got Mary into hers as Haley came over. "It was so good to see you two," she said sweetly.

"Good to see you, too," Erin said as she hoisted our daughter onto her hip.

Haley set her hand on Lucas's shoulder, her fingers perched like bird feet. "Let's get the kids together next week. A play date."

"Sounds good."

Lucas held his hand out to me. "Have a good one, buddy." He jutted his chin in Erin's direction. "And good luck

with that one. She's a real handful."

It would have been so sweet to punch that cocky grin of his right off his face. He had even, white teeth—the kind of teeth I knew Erin noticed—and it would have been so satisfying to knock one loose.

Instead, I squeezed down on his hand and leaned in. "I'm going to say this only once. She's mine, she'll always be mine, and if I ever catch you sniffing around again, we won't be simply shaking hands."

Lucas's grin slipped for a moment before the mask was back in place. He glanced at Erin, as if to say, *Is he kidding?*

Erin shook her head, looking amused, before turning to me and beaming. "Happy New Year," she said with a coy wave. And we were gone.

OceanofPDF.com

THREE

I was fuming as we left. I'm pretty sure that if I saw a reflection of myself, steam would have been rising from my head. I'd been cold when I arrived, but I could have walked home shirtless.

Erin, beside me, couldn't stop smiling. It had formed when I'd had my outburst with Lucas, and it never faltered. She squeezed my hand as we walked down the block.

I wanted to say what an asshole Lucas was, but with Mary on Erin's hip and Martin skipping ahead of us, I kept my mouth shut.

We split up bedtime duties with each kid with the efficiency of the married couple that we were. I took Martin, Erin took Mary. I got the easier task. Our five-year-old was asleep before I'd gotten through a single book. Mary was punchy and over-tired by the time we'd gotten home, and when I passed her room, Erin was still singing lullabies to her.

It was fine. It gave me time to compose my thoughts. I knew a talk was coming. Not talking things through after running into Lucas Hughes for the first time was a mistake I wasn't going to make. Not again.

I went downstairs and turned the television on to the Dick Clark New Year's celebration. I listened to a couple musical acts and stilted interviews of the freezing party-goers in New York, then turned the volume down low and waited for Erin.

When she joined me, she was still in her dress, and still wore that warm smile, the one that said, *There you are, I've missed you.*

"I like your dress. Is it new?"

"Thanks. Yeah, it's new," she said. Just when things started to feel awkward between us—like we were strangers

feeling one another out—Erin reminded me that we absolutely were not. “It’s like a muumuu compared to the dresses you buy for me, but I like it.”

“I deserve that.” Last year, I’d purchased Erin a tiny—*tiny*—white dress that she eventually wore, ironically, to seduce Lucas Hughes on her birthday. This one was definitely more her style, and way more fitting for a woman in her mid-30s.

She held a bottle of champagne in one hand and two flutes, criss-crossed, in the other. She held them up. “To the New Year?”

I nodded. She placed them on the coffee table, but didn’t start opening the bottle. Not right away. Instead, she walked right up to me and put her hands on my shoulders as I encircled her narrow waist.

“That was pretty hot, watching you deal with Lucas,” she said.

“You thought so?”

“I’ve never had two men fight over me before.” She paused. “That doesn’t make me sound like I’ve got a princess complex or something, does it?”

I thought of all kinds of dirty things she’d done recently. “No, I would never mistake you for a princess.”

“Remember when I said that nothing would ever happen between me and Lucas?”

Suspicion set in like a fever, despite my near certainty that nothing had happened. She must have felt me stiffen because when she pulled back and looked up at me, her eyes were incredulous.

“Wait, you don’t really think that something did,” she said.

“No,” I stumbled, stupidly blurting, “You were upstairs with Lucas for a while.”

She started to open her mouth to speak, then seemed to realize that she had no idea what to say. I prepared for her to get upset at the accusation. Or defensive. To reach

for excuses—*He was just helping me find our coats, or It's not what you think.* Instead, she reached for my face, touching my cheek softly. She said, “You’re very confusing, you know that? When I said that nothing would ever happen with him, I meant it. But a part of you will never believe that.”

“No, I know that—”

She cut me off, touching my temples that were starting to fleck with gray. “This part of you does. Other parts...” She ran her hands down between my legs. “...are conflicted.”

I was hard, unbelievably. I didn’t quite realize it myself until I felt her hand slide along my length.

“I don’t want that,” I said. “I swear, Erin. Not with Lucas.”

“I don’t want it, either. He’s an asshole.”

“But you were talking to him. He was laughing...”

Erin started laughing. It bruised my ego, but I also realized how ridiculous I was being—like the jealous ogre I never wanted to be.

“I’m sorry,” I said.

“Why?” she asked, and I realized that this wasn’t a rhetorical question.

I gathered my thoughts before answering. “Because I’m being a jealous ogre.”

Erin covered her mouth, this laugh more with me than at me. “Okay, why else?”

It was hard to face her and say anything but something from the heart—not with those wide, green eyes staring up at me. “I’m sorry for thinking that you’d do something with Lucas.”

“Ah, now we’re getting somewhere.” She sighed, releasing me both from her stare and her embrace. She took my hand and led me to the sofa. She looked...sad. She pushed on. “Why did you think I was with him?”

“Because...” I thought about those moments of panic, when I hadn’t been able to find her. Or Lucas. When I’d gone

through the empty rooms upstairs ready to walk in on her. "Because I got there and you weren't around. And neither was Lucas."

"And neither were a lot of people," Erin pointed out. "But that's not *why* you thought I was with him. That's what made you think I could be, but in order for you to actually have that thought..."

"Means that I didn't trust you," I finished.

"This was your fantasy, Tom. I did it, and I like it..." Her eyes flickered with embarrassment, but she moved past it swiftly. "But now you don't fully trust me anymore because it didn't go just how you wanted."

"No, that's not it at all," I said. "I told you that I didn't like him. You fucked him anyway."

"And you watched. And you got turned on by it. Come on, Tom. I saw you. You were *there*. You never said to stop, and you could have." She shut her eyes, found herself again, and sighed. "I'm not saying that I did all the right things. I'm not even trying to convince you to trust me. That can't be forced."

"But I should trust you."

"I agree," she said with a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes. "But we have to deal with the fact that you don't..." She stopped as something occurred to her. I watched the epiphany bloom on her face like she'd just woken up. Her eyes went wide and she looked up at me through her lashes. "You wanted me to stay."

Oh, right. I forgot about that. Before I could make something up about wanting her to stay and have a good time with her friends, she preempted me.

"You wanted to tempt me," she said.

"No."

"No? Then you wanted to test me."

So that sounded worse. Luckily, Erin didn't look pissed. Instead, she looked like she was trying to figure me out. "I'd pass. Every time, I'd pass, but..." She kept studying me,

translating me. “Some small part of you gets excited by the possibility that I’d fail.”

“No!”

“You’re right.” She stroked my erection through my pants. “It’s definitely not a small part.”

That wasn’t it. I wasn’t excited about her and Lucas. I didn’t want him anywhere near Erin. And yet...and yet...I was unquestionably hard as Erin sank her teeth into her lower lip and raised her brows. *I’m right, right?*

She wasn’t, but...but I *did* like the idea of her dirty side—the side that liked getting used by a pair of athletes, the side with a guy she hooked up with every time he was in town.

“Maybe I get turned on by the idea that you’ll lose control, and that turns into this thing where while I *know* I can trust you, I’m turned on by the possibility that I can’t, and it’s hard to resist, and ultimately that messes with my head,” I conceded.

“That makes as much sense as any of this,” she replied, and smiled.

“But deep down I know you’ll *always* come back to me.”

“Never doubt it.”

It was the temptation of that dirty side that drew me to her now. I pulled her close, kissing her hard. I could feel her smile into the kiss, delighted to accept me. Her fingers went to work on my pants, working them open deftly as we mashed our lips together like a pair of horny teenagers.

My hands wandered to her ass, feeling the tight curve of it beneath the knit material. I traced the thong she wore beneath. It was small, sexy, barely functional—the perfect juxtaposition to her much more reasonable dress. This was Erin, sweet on the outside, salacious inside.

She groaned as I pulled away from her and twisted her onto her back. I finished what she’d done, freeing my cock and pressing a knee into the sofa between her legs. She looked up at me, her chest rising and falling in shallow

breaths. Her hand idly caressed her left breast, dancing over the spot where her nipple hid beneath the fabric.

"You think he tried something? When we were up there...all alone?"

Jealousy spiked my arousal. This time, it only made it more feverish. "I'm sure he wanted to."

"Oh, I am, too," Erin said, her eyes bright.

I pushed her dress up her hips as I moved back in for another kiss. She was working me up, I knew, making me wonder why she was so sure. *Had* something happened?

"You're so hard," she gasped, taking hold of my cock again. She placed it against her warm sex, with just her damp panties between us. "You're wondering how I knew he wanted me, aren't you?"

"How?"

She pulled her panties to the side, then guided me into her. I sank into her without resistance, her warm, slick cunt stroking me down to the root. Something had her excited. Lucas?

The idea of it churned in my gut and set my hips into furious motion.

"Oh, baby," she moaned, and I heard her moan for Lucas. She dug the heel of her right foot into my lower back. *More*, she encouraged. And *harder*.

"How?" I barked. "Tell me...how...you knew?"

She gasped and sputtered beneath me, fighting for words. "A woman...can always...tell..."

It wasn't a satisfying answer. I wanted more. I wanted something for my jealousy to feast on. A half second later, Erin delivered.

"He also asked me when we could get together again..."

I groaned. My balls tightened with my chest.

She pulled me down to her, her teeth nipping at my ear. Added: "He wanted to get together...without you."

I drove my cock deep, one last time, and exploded inside her. Erin released me, rocking her head back into the

sofa as her body crashed up into mine.

When I collapsed on top of her and the heat of the moment began to leave me, I realized with horror what I was doing. Erin could walk away from this conversation thinking I wanted her to do something with Lucas. I didn't—even if the idea of it plucked at something sexy yet unsettling. I thought about the way they'd been laughing as they came down the stairs. And how wet she was. Part of her liked the idea. Part of her wanted him.

Erin pulled my head off her shoulder so she could look me in the eyes. She seemed to know that I was going somewhere dark. She said, "I will never do anything with Lucas again, whether you're there or not. Want to know why?"

"Why?"

"Because he's an asshole. And he's not worth any of this." A smile passed across her face, there and gone so fast that it could have been my imagination. "Even if it does get you going."

"Erin..."

"Tom?" she replied playfully.

"I don't like him."

"No, you actually hate him," she said.

"Maybe."

Behind me, I heard Ryan Seacrest ask some girls what their resolutions were. It was December 31st, I remembered. We were back in our home. The home I'd built with Erin. The life we'd shared for so long. It was as precious to Erin as it was to me. To think that she would just give it all up was my paranoia talking.

Erin said, "Would it be lame of me if I changed into my PJs?"

"Depends on which PJs you're going for?"

Erin rolled her eyes, smiling the whole time. "Are you going to read too much into it if I choose my flannel ones?"

"If I say yes, will you put on something sexier?"

"Only if you spend the rest of the night in some silk boxers."

I shivered. "Fair enough. Flannel it is."

*

Erin ended up compromising, despite the fact that I told her not to worry about it. She wore a long, satin nightgown and a cardigan. I went with the flannel pants and sweatshirt.

I went to work on the bottle of champagne we had as we watched pop stars that neither of us recognized prance around on television. Half of the bottle in, I finally had to get something out. "You know, I really do want to trust you."

Erin glanced at me. With her makeup scrubbed away and her hair up in a ponytail, she was back to the woman I'd known for so many years. "I know. But you're worried that one of these days, I'm going to lose control. Again."

Incredibly, the spark of arousal ignited something deep inside of me. Erin seemed to see it, too, tilting her head to the side and furrowing her brow.

She added, slowly, "What do you want from me, Tom? Honestly? Every time I think I know, you do something, or say something, and I'm confused again."

It was an honest question, and it deserved an honest answer. "I don't know."

Frustration flickered across her face for a moment before it was gone. I understood. I'd be annoyed too if I was her. Hell, I was annoyed with myself.

I said, "But I promise to work through it with you from now on. I won't keep it all in my head."

Erin smirked. "Are you making a New Year's resolution?"

As if on cue, Ryan Seacrest announced: *We're just ten minutes away from 2016. Everyone with that special someone?*

"Sure, why not."

Erin snuggled into my arms. "Then my resolution is to reassure you that I'm not going to lose control."

I felt loss at the certainty of her statement. "Ever?"

Erin met me with a flat stare. "Here's where you don't keep things in your head. What are you thinking, Tom?"

This was already difficult. "That maybe I like it. When you lose control. Sometimes."

"Oh...kay," she said. Then, "So you want to trust that I'm never going to lose control, but you want me to lose control. Sometimes."

"Look, part of the fantasy is that you unlock some dormant..."

"Whore?" Erin offered, her smile softening the bite.

"I was going to say something like *sexual dynamo*, but that works too." I pulled her close, kissed the top of her head. "And while we're being honest here, you like exploring that side of yourself, too."

Erin shot me the most open, most innocent of smiles. "Me?" she said with faux incredulity.

"Or the woman who looked a lot like you that I watched take on two guys while tied to some gym equipment."

"Or, her." Erin's laugh was heartfelt. "Yeah, she's a total slut. You like her?"

"Sometimes, yeah. She drives me wild."

Erin nodded. "But she drives a part of you crazy with jealousy."

"Yeah."

"And she's crossed a line before," Erin said.

"She has."

"So we need to figure out what that line is, and what I'm hearing you say is that you want me to get as close to it as possible without crossing it."

I guess that's what I was saying? "Sounds risky, but..."

"But you'd still like to try. Okay..." She thought for a moment. "I don't want to repeat my birthday, so we're going to have to establish some ground rules."

"We've got a safe word," I said. *Magnanimous*. The irony of it still made me chuckle.

"That's the nuclear option. When things have already gone too far. I'd rather we never get there."

"Okay. So how about, no Lucas Hughes?"

Erin said, "Well, that's a given. How about you pre-vet any guys I'm with."

"Yes, that's good."

"And I won't do anything with them that I haven't done with you." She reached down between my legs, feeling for my crotch. "For example, things I can do with other men: kiss them..." She kissed me. "Touch them..." She squeezed my cock and leaned close, whispering, "Suck their cocks..."

I groaned as phantom men enveloped her, naked and powerful. Erin freed my cock and climbed into my lap, hiking her nightgown up around her waist. She ran her pussy along my shaft, stroking me with her soft skin.

"You think they'll like my shaved pussy?" she said softly. Shifting, that shaved pussy enveloped me. "I could fuck them. You'd be okay with that, wouldn't you?"

"Oh, Erin." I clutched her ass, helping her bounce slowly on my sore shaft.

"But that's not all I could do, is it? I could get really naughty." She rode me, pulling my head in between her tits. "If I wanted to, I could let them fuck my ass."

I gasped and squeezed down on her cheeks.

"You like that, naughty boy," Erin said. "You like the idea of another man sinking his big, hard cock into my ass?"

"Yes," I hissed.

"It turns you on to think about some guy bending me over and telling me to spread my cheeks for him?"

"Oh, fuck, Erin..."

"Yes, fuck Erin." I could hear her heart beat fast and furious. "I could even fuck two guys at once, couldn't I?"

She could. I shared her like that before. With Lucas.

“One guy behind me. One...uh...in my mouth...” She held her breath—imagining the scenario?—then released it with a loud moan.

I said, “Do you want that?”

“Mmm hmm.”

The image of Erin getting double penetrated by AJ and Lamar sprang to mind. Was that allowed? Was a combination of transgressions against the rules?

“Things I can’t do...” she said. For a second, I wondered if I’d spoken aloud, or if she really could read my mind. “A threesome with another girl.”

My mind went there, the lurid DP replaced by the image of Erin’s lips meeting another woman’s around a thick cock.

“Getting fucked by *more* than two guys.”

It shifted again, to Erin at the center of a gangbang, a scenario that even in my imagination felt like a cheap porn.

“Right now, I couldn’t be at the center of an orgy, either. Men, women, there to please me, there to fuck me.” She swallowed a groan, but she was close. So close. “To use me...”

Are these things she wanted? Were these her darkest fantasies, confessed at last? Or was she just building me up? Was this yet another game?

Vaguely, I heard a count down. I heard cheering. *Ten. Nine. Eight.*

I squeezed Erin’s hips harder, driving her up and down my cock. I met each thrust from below, pushing as deep as I could into her shivering cunt.

Seven. Six. Five.

“You’re thinking about your dirty whore being used, aren’t you?” she hissed into my ear.

Four. Three.

“I’ll always come back to you.”

Two. One.

“Always.”

Happy New Year!

Our mouths met as we came together, my balls emptying for the last time that night. Erin ground her pussy, milking every last drop. The frenzy fell away, but we kept kissing, slower, softer, more loving. What started in lust ended in love. What a beautiful way to start the new year.

"I love you, baby," Erin said.

"I love you, too."

"The future's going to be fun."

I hugged her. "I'm counting on it."

She's a handful, Lucas had said. I thought I could handle her. Now I wasn't so sure, but it was going to be fun to try.

OceanofPDF.com

FOUR

The new year began, and with it, our new resolve. Of course, now that we were ready to move forward, we didn't move anywhere. Not right away, anyway. Based on what I'd read about this lifestyle, that ebb-and-flow was natural. To be fair, we were a normal, married couple most of the time. We had a routine. I went to work, the kids went to school, Erin kept the home and raised the kids when they were back. We looked forward to the next season of *Survivor* in February (a guilty pleasure) and watched the State of the Union speech together over popcorn. We talked about getting a dog.

We did have one fun adventure in late January. I had to fly out to Atlanta for a business meeting. We left the kids with Erin's mom so she could tag along. Nothing happened, although we did take advantage of the distance from home to play a little—Erin going into a bar alone so that I could watch her flirt with strangers. And while nothing happened, it was a nice reminder of all the sexy possibility of the new year.

Sexy possibility arrived one evening in early February. Erin walked into the bedroom with just a towel on, looking like the cat who'd swallowed the canary.

"What?" I said, putting my Kindle down.

Erin paused in the doorway. Her hair was still slightly damp, resting on her bare shoulder. "Well, your birthday's coming up in a couple weeks."

"Yes, it is," I said.

"And we need to find a way to top my birthday."

My blood thickened. "No, not really. Something quiet and low-key would be fine with me."

Erin fixed her eyes on me as she unwrapped her towel. It fell to her side, exposing her in full and glorious frontal

nudity. She was in the best shape of her life, and at 34, she could give most twenty-year-olds a run for their money. She had very little body fat on her, but still maintained the curves that maturity and motherhood had granted her. Her breasts were still firm and high, her stomach flatter than ever, her hips and ass round and sinuous.

Erin let me take her in before detaching herself from the door and moving to the dresser. Her backside—her full ass and the tight lines of her shoulders and spine—were nearly as enticing.

“So should I tell Jo to change her plans?” she said.

“Plans?”

Erin reached into the dresser and pulled out a nightshirt. She flashed a smile over her shoulder—right over the Ironman tattoo—and said, “I invited her to come out. You know...to help us celebrate.”

My heart skipped a beat.

Jo was Erin’s wild friend. She knew all about Erin’s extramarital activities, and shortly before Christmas, we’d talked about involving her more intimately in them. I’d be lying if I said that wasn’t an exciting possibility. Jo was an attractive blonde with a fun personality. I didn’t need to participate to have fun in this game, but when Erin offered, I agreed. She hadn’t brought it up since, and there were times when I figured I’d made that conversation up. Now...

“She’d like to wish you a happy birthday. Personally.” Erin suppressed her laugh as she pulled her nightgown on. “It could be nice and low-key.”

Her satin nightgown was short, a deep maroon fringed in black lace. Normally I would have been all over her legs. Instead, I imagined Jo wearing the same outfit, smiling that same, promising smile.

Then I blinked and she was my wife again, studying me curiously. I said, “You know you don’t need to do this, right?”

She came over to me, sitting on the bed without sliding under the sheets. “I know.”

I reached out, running my fingers along her satin gown. "You don't owe me anything."

"I know. Your fantasy is about me with other men," she said.

"I'm not just talking about my fantasy." I willed her to look at me, and she did. I repeated my statement, this time with weight behind it. "You don't owe me anything."

We stared at one another without saying anything, yet saying everything. "I know," she said softly, a smile hovering just out of sight. "And this isn't just about you."

She'd said this before, back when Jo was first brought up. Back then, I wasn't sure if she'd been saying it in the heat of the moment, or if she'd thought she still needed to make up for the birthday fiasco. She'd had months to think about it, and still we were here.

"Tell me what you're thinking," I said.

Erin considered the question before answering "It's...so strange. Like, the idea of it makes me feel jealous, you know? I feel like I'm standing three feet behind my body, watching myself react, but..." She searched for the words to describe the way I'd been feeling ever since AJ entered our lives. I waited eagerly, hoping she could articulate what I still couldn't. In the end, she just shook her head. "I don't know, it's just so exciting, too. Like, I want to see her face as you enter her. I want to watch her come because of you. It makes me so horny."

She'd been focused on the fantasy, her eyes shifted away. When she looked back at me, I saw understanding there. She said, "That's how you feel all the time?"

"Pretty much."

"How do you not have an ulcer?"

I laughed. "Sometimes I think I do."

"It's pretty intense," she said. Then, more thoughtfully, "I'm really sorry I put you through what I did. It seems insane, in hindsight, that I had any clue what our boundaries are. I'm still learning my own."

I pulled her down to me. We fit together. "You really want to watch me with another woman? I don't want, like, a pity *ménage à trois*."

"Oh, you poor man," Erin laughed. "No, I do." She kissed me. "Feel if you don't believe me." She took my hand and placed it on her chest. Her heart was racing. "Also..." She guided my hand down between her legs and beneath the negligee. Her pussy was drenched.

I said, "If you have any reservations—"

Erin cut me off with a kiss. "I'll show you reservations."

"That doesn't make sense, you know."

"Stop overthinking *everything!*"

She pushed me onto my back and mounted me. I was so hard and glided easily into her warmth. We made love. No more talk of other people and our deviant lifestyle.

*

Of course, nothing's straightforward. The next week, on the morning that Jo was to arrive and a couple days before my birthday weekend, Erin walked in, her phone in hand. It buzzed, and with it, so did my body. She read it, her smile mischievous.

"Aj's in town," she said.

"Oh yeah?"

"Yeah. He's off for the month." She handed me her phone, the texts open for me to read.

Aj: flight gets in this afternoon. you get to my place this evening.

Erin: Can't. Not tonight. Girlfriend is visiting today.

Aj: she hot?

Erin: Of course!

Aj: bring her too

Erin: Uh huh. I don't think you could handle us.

AJ: lol then you don't know me very well

AJ: bring her

I handed it back to her. "You're going to bring her, aren't you?" I said.

"Only if you're okay with it."

Even though Jo had always been the sexually adventurous one and had admitted to doing things like being in a relationship with a man and a woman at the same time, I still felt a similar sensation to the one I had when Erin would meet AJ—arousal with a side of envy.

"I'm okay with it. Think she will?"

"Well, she's already experienced AJ's big cock, remember?"

I hadn't until she'd mentioned it, but she was right. Jo had gone out for some "field research" way back when Erin had only been with AJ once.

Erin got close, looking up at me curiously. "Wait a minute... You aren't jealous of that, are you?"

"No, don't be silly."

Her brows went up. "Really? With Jo?"

"No, it's not like that. I just..." I sighed. She was right, it was pretty silly. "She's Jo, right? I know she's got a life over in LA, but when she's here, she's just..."

"Jo."

"Right."

Erin touched the back of my neck, running her fingers up into my hair. "Well, I know for a fact that she's looking forward to this weekend."

Then I got an idea—a twisted one, one that was probably not a wise one. I blurted it before I lost my nerve. "Why don't you two meet up with him tomorrow night. And then, this weekend, you two can...demonstrate what really happened."

Erin's eyes went wide.

"Too much?" I said.

Erin's surprise resolved itself into a languid smile. "You know, we made a rule against that, right? Like, we *just* made it."

"So you don't want to do it," I said."

"I didn't say that. Just...are you sure?"

"In this case, yes."

Erin kissed me. "You're an exciting man, Tom."

"Then I'm a good match for this exciting woman."

The plan was set. Jo was flying in today. Tomorrow, they'd meet up with Aj. The day after was my birthday.

Work provided a nice distraction from the excitement to come, but I must have spent most of the day in one state of arousal or another, and at the end of the day, I had no idea what I'd actually done.

When I finally did get home, I walked in to Jo's boisterous laugh from the kitchen. "You guys are killing me!" she cried.

"One more time! One more time, Auntie Jo!" Martin cheered.

Jo's laugh came again. "Okay, okay! Here goes."

The shrieking of both kids followed.

I hung my coat in the front closet and walked into a scene. Jo was swinging Martin around by his legs as Mary pressed herself against the wall and clapped wildly. Erin was behind the island counter, stirring something in a bowl as she watched, amused.

"Hello," I said. "Honey, there's a stranger torturing our children."

Erin mouthed a *ha ha* before coming around the island. "I picked her up on the street. She looked fun." She kissed me. "Welcome home."

"I'm totally fun," Jo said.

I looked at her, wondering if the statement was meant to be a double entendres. Didn't seem right with the kids right here, and she looked innocent enough. And even Jo at her most innocent was stunning. Her mane of curly, blond

hair was tamped down by a few barrettes, but it still flowed wild and free around her shoulders. Her skin was more sun-kissed than it had a right to be this deep into winter. She seemed to have dressed like it wasn't winter, either, wearing a short pair of red cheerleader shorts and a t-shirt, her arms covered in nothing but a loose hoodie—the whole outfit carefully crafted to look casual, while showing off her amazing body at the same time.

“Hey, Jo. Good flight?”

“Cross-country flights never are, but I got some good reading in.” She shot a look at Erin. “Sat next to a cute guy, too.”

Erin rolled her eyes, but said nothing.

“Even got his number,” Jo pressed, once again focused on me. “But I told him that I didn't think I'd be able to get away at all.”

I glanced at Erin. I felt the warmth of promise blossom inside of me. “Sounds about right.”

That evening was normal—as normal as they got with a spirited woman like Jo. We had pasta for dinner, put the kids down, and moved into the living room with a fresh bottle of wine.

Jo refilled our glasses, saying, “So thirty-nine. How do you feel?”

“It's just another day in my life,” I said.

“Fair enough. And how do you feel in your life right now?”

It occurred to me that this wasn't just idle chit-chat. I looked at Erin, wondering if she'd put this up to Jo. She was watching me carefully.

Without looking away from my wife, I said, “Honestly, things haven't been better.”

“You two have been pretty...adventurous since I last saw you,” said Jo. “Erin's been filling me in.”

Erin sipped her wine. “For once I get to be the storyteller, and you're the one living vicariously.”

Jo laughed. "I wouldn't say just vicariously. When you told me all about your little gym experience..." She paused, weighed my presence against the appropriateness of what she was about to say, then shrugged and said it anyway. "After I heard that, I just had to try it out myself."

"Of course you did," Erin said.

"It was a Christmas present to myself."

"More like two Christmas presents," Erin snorted.

"Two nice, big presents, too," Jo laughed loudly. "I've never felt so filled up in my life. Mm!" Jo shivered like she was remembering a particularly satisfying meal, not talking about getting fucked by two men at once.

"Did you do everything I did?" Erin asked.

Jo looked slyly at her. "What are you referring to, exactly, Erin?" She didn't let Erin answer. "Did I kneel between them and suck their cocks back and forth? Because yes, I did that."

It was nice to see Erin blush, even if she had done that.

"Or are you asking if I fucked one guy as the other fucked my ass. Because I did that, too."

"You are incorrigible," Erin said, covering her mouth as she laughed.

"Pot calling the kettle a slut, don't you think?!" Jo shot back. She seemed to take pleasure in shocking us.

"I don't think that's how the saying goes," Erin said.

Jo had moved beyond it. She made a flourish with her hand in the air. "Of course, you didn't add a third to the mix to complete the experience."

"No!" Erin said, her eyes going wide above her hand.

"Oh, yes," she said, mirroring Erin's disbelieving expression. "Turned out these guys had a third roommate, and..." She leaned forward. "He. Was. Amazing."

I couldn't look at Jo and not think about her being held between three guys, her body shimmering, her unruly hair tamed by sweat.

“She just can’t take it when I do something that she doesn’t.”

“I...” I had nothing to say.

“His dirty little mind is thinking about it,” Jo said.

“No, I’m not,” I lied.

“Oh no? That’s a shame. Well, in case you’re curious, I was kind of perched on Craig’s cock. He held my hips steady as he pushed in and out of my ass, as Mark, the other guy, fucked me the more conventional way.” She laughed. “And Anthony—he was the amazing guy—stood beside me so I could suck his cock. At one point, he actually straddled my face, and oh my god!”

If someone like Erin had been saying these things, I never would have believed it. Even with Jo, it was almost impossible. Almost.

But not really.

Later that night, after we’d crawled into bed—too late and with too much to drink—I couldn’t let the matter drop. “Is that...is that something you want?” I asked Erin.

“What’s that?”

It had been a couple hours since Jo had mentioned her three-on-one experience, but I can’t remember what we talked about in between. Erin hadn’t said much beyond teasing her best friend about what a tramp she was, and then we’d moved on to talking about her career, my career, and how the kids were doing. But I couldn’t stop thinking about the tale.

Only it wasn’t just me fantasizing about Jo in that situation. No, my fucked up mind immediately cast Erin in the mix, and it sent an uneasy thrill through me. Was she thinking about it, too? That she had to ask me to clarify my question said no, but still, there was that look of...curiosity she’d held all night.

Or was it just me?

It was there now, I swear, and before I could repeat my question, a small smile formed at the edges of her mouth.

“Are you asking me if I want to take on three guys at once?”

There, so she *did* have it on her mind. At least partially. “Do you?”

I felt like some kind of addict. Did I lick my lips? Was I sweating? I was certainly, uncomfortably, aroused by this.

She searched my face carefully before answering. “I’ve thought about it before. Once or twice.”

And that made me think of something AJ had told me last year—*That chick’s got a wild side I can’t wait to tap into*. The other part of the conversation that had stuck with me was AJ’s theory about why she couldn’t tell me about this stuff: *Her life is proper and orderly. She’s one kind of person there: mother, wife. But she’s got a darker side, and it’s not a side she can show her husband*.

She was telling me now, wasn’t she?

Fuck, yes, she was telling me.

“What are you thinking, Tom?” Erin asked, concern wiping away the hint of a smile.

“That I’m kind of crazy.”

“Well, sometimes. But tell me exactly how you think you are now.”

“I...” I ran my hands through my hair. “I’m glad that you feel comfortable telling me that.” I rolled my eyes. “No, not *glad*. It...”

She helped me out, when I struggled. “When I tell you things like that, it turns you on.”

“Yes.”

“But it also confuses you.”

“Right!” I said.

“And part of you wonders who I am?”

I stopped short of immediately agreeing with her, even though I did immediately agree. I said, “It sounds bad, but it’s not a bad thing. It’s an exciting thing. There’s still so much I don’t know about you. This whole other side.”

Erin kissed me. “Ditto, dear. I feel the same way, but for a whole other set of reasons.”

“We’re quite a pair,” I said.

“Mm, but a fun one, don’t you think? And by the end of the weekend, we’ll be more than just a pair, yeah?” She snaked her hand between my legs, finding my perpetually hard cock ready for her. “She can hear us in the guest bedroom, you know.”

“Hear this conversation?”

“Maybe if she presses her ear against the wall.” Erin straddled me. “But she’ll definitely be able to hear us fuck.” Erin fed my cock into her wet pussy. “Let’s give her a preview, shall we?”

OceanofPDF.com

FIVE

The next day, a Friday, dragged. Tonight, Erin was going to have a threesome with her best girlfriend and...AJ. There was a lot to unpack there.

First, that she was having a threesome with another woman at all. She'd done it once, when we were with Haley and Lucas, but that had been a spontaneous thing, with lust and hormones dominating the moment. We were all so keyed up that when Haley crawled between Erin's legs, my wife just went for it. And when she'd returned the favor, she'd still been enthralled by Lucas.

Thinking back on that, I realized how tainted the whole experience had been. Before I realized I had a thing for naughty wives, a MFF threesome was at the top of my list of fantasies. I imagined everything about it, from the nervousness that led up to it, to the tentative kisses and long looks, to the aftermath, when we would snuggle, just the two of us again, and talk about how we felt about it. I realized that we hadn't even had that conversation. We'd been so focused on Lucas and my feelings of betrayal. The man had taken even that!

Tonight was my second chance to recapture the fantasy, which led to the other thing that I needed to wrap my head around: I wasn't part of this threesome. Not the first one. And even crazier, that idea was my own. Why had I suggested it? Why did the idea of my wife getting dirty and crossing a few lines with another man—*first*—appeal to me so much?

Thing was, it did. It was dangerous to put Erin in a situation where she might lose control, and with that danger came deep, profound excitement.

When I got home that evening, I wasn't sure what to expect. Erin and Jo weren't headed out until 9:30, after the

kids went to bed, yet I still half expected to walk in and see them all dolled up for their night of debauchery. Instead, they were casual—designer jeans and a blouse for Jo, black yoga pants and a loose top for Erin.

Jo greeted me at the door with a hug and, remarkably, a gin and tonic. I couldn't tell if this was her ironic attempt at being a housewife. "For the man of the house," she said.

"Such service."

She ran her fingers beneath the lapel of my suit. I knew she was teasing me, yet that didn't make it any less exciting. "No casual Fridays at the office?" she asked.

"Not for the boss."

"Good. I prefer my men all dressed up. Very sexy."

"Get away from him!" Erin said playfully, entering the room. "And get back into the kitchen. The stir fry isn't going to stir itself."

Jo rolled her eyes. "She's such a tyrant. I don't know how you put up with her."

Erin slapped her friend on the butt. "Get!" Then she sidled up to me and kissed me hello. "Welcome home, dear." Her eyes danced between mine, alive. "Ready?"

I nodded.

"Good."

And that was the only mention of what was to come—at least until the kids were in bed. Still, I could feel the current of excitement hum among us, unspoken. We ate dinner. I put the kids to bed as Jo and Erin took showers and got ready. When the children were tucked in, I went down to the living room, where Jo sat waiting.

She still looked casual—same designer jeans from earlier, same blouse. Her makeup was on heavier, though, with kohl around her eyes and red on her lips. It was her hair that was the most striking difference. She'd straightened her curls into an edgy, blond blade of hair that fell across her face like a femme fatale. And straightened, it was very long.

"Wow," I said.

"You approve?"

I blinked, barely recognizing her. "Looks great."

"Took forever," Jo laughed. "But when you're about to have sex with your best friend for the first time ever, I figure it's worth the extra prep."

Her words raced through me like electricity. "So you and Erin are going to..."

"Have sex?" She touched her tongue to her top lip. "You think we should?"

"I..." Had no answer to that.

"Let me rephrase. Would it turn you on if we did?"

Yes. Yes it would. Instead, I asked, "Aren't you worried about your friendship?"

"Not really. Your wife wouldn't be the first friend that I've slept with—although she'd definitely be one of the sexiest."

"But this isn't just about you. It's about Erin, too, and how she'll feel tomorrow."

"Oh, I know," Jo said. "I also know that you're dodging my question. I'm a lawyer, remember?" She leaned in, close enough that I could smell her spicy perfume. "So tell me, Tom, does it get you excited thinking about me going down on your sweet wife's pussy?"

I straightened my back and didn't draw away from her—not even a fraction of an inch. I put on my most confident of smiles and nodded. "It does get me excited. Very excited."

Jo's eyes flared.

"And if you really want to make her scream, make sure you stay away from her clit as long as possible."

At the other end of the room, Erin cleared her throat. "What are you two conspiring about?"

"Nothing," we said in unison, turning to Erin. Like Jo, she was casually dressed—a pair of dark jeans and a loose sweater that hung off one shoulder, exposing the thin, black strap of her bra.

Erin shifted her gaze between us before snapping her clutch shut. “You ready?” she asked Jo.

Jo rose off the sofa, joining Erin’s side, and the weight of what we were doing bore down on me. This wasn’t a dream. This wasn’t a tease. It made me dizzy to look up at the two women—normal women, not women lifted from glossy magazines—and think about what they were about to do.

Erin bent down and kissed me. Her lips were glossy pink and tasted like berries. AJ would taste those lips soon. Jo would, too. I shifted on the sofa.

“I’ll text you later,” she said. “Try to get some sleep. We’ll be up...late.”

“Have fun,” I said.

Jo winked at me. “You lucked out with this one,” she said to Erin.

“I know. And he’ll be rewarded generously for tonight.”

Jo laughed. “Can’t wait. See you tomorrow, Tom.”

And with that, they were gone.

*

The first message arrived about forty-five minutes later. I’d been checking my phone ceaselessly since they’d left—even before I knew it was possible that they’d arrived at AJ’s apartment. I’d even toggled on the sounds, a thing I never did. When it buzzed and chimed, adrenaline spiked through me like something physical. When I checked the phone and saw the photo, though, I recoiled.

The lighting in AJ’s apartment was dramatic, casting everything in contrasts of bright and dark. Still, it was unmistakable that the photo Erin had sent me was of AJ, bound to his own bed with leather cuffs. He was blindfolded. He was completely naked. And he was very erect.

-Look what I have to play with

Now, I'm not into guys, but AJ was irrefutably good looking. The guy was a personal trainer for a professional athlete, so that wasn't a surprise. He looked like a guy off the cover of *Men's Health* or *GQ*. His skin was dark. He had muscles in places that I didn't realize could be muscled. He had a mean looking dragon tattoo scrawled across his shoulder and neck. And his cock—clean shaven—was monumental. Was that spit glistening on the tip?

It was strange seeing him tied up like that. I wondered how Erin had talked him into agreeing to that. AJ was the guy who tied others up, not a man easily restrained.

A follow-up text came in, before I could figure out if I even wanted to respond.

-And he has no idea what's about to happen

A picture followed. The angle had changed. The naked AJ was in the foreground, but the focus was on the door, where Jo was sneaking in, a finger held to her lips. Her casual clothes were gone, and the blonde was clad in nothing but a pink bra and thong.

After that, for the next hour, nothing. I tried to imagine the scene. AJ strapped to the bed, clueless as a pair of lips wrapped around his cock. Then another. Then the realization that Erin wasn't alone. Would he try to pull free? Would the loss of control kill him?

And what about Jo and Erin? Did their mouths brush up against one another as they blew him? Did the kiss lead to more, to something heated, to a moment of passion that had been building their entire lives?

I got ready for sleep, but there was no way that was going to happen. I logged onto our computer and surfed, reading articles without processing them. I caught up on football, on where things stood with the Skins now that the off-season was upon us. I checked my email, even though it was after ten and no one reasonable would be emailing me.

Around eleven, I got another message, this time without captions or text. Just a series of photos. My heart sped up. I moved back to the bed and peeled my pajama pants off before thumbing the first photo, which I could already tell was nuclear.

Erin and Jo were kneeling on his bed, their panties still in place, but their bras long gone. Erin had her arms around Jo's neck while Jo hugged Erin's thong-clad ass. Their lips covered one another, mouths open in a deep kiss.

I stared at it long and hard as it short-circuited my brain. I almost forgot to breath. I stared at it, zooming in on where their mouths met. It was a deep soulful kiss. Their eyes were closed. Erin's fingers clutched her friend to her. She was lost in the moment.

I took a deep breath, held it like smoke off a cigarette, and released it slowly. It didn't help. I swiped to the next image—Jo reclined on the bed, her knees together as Erin peeled Jo's pink thong down her legs.

Dear God.

Next image.

Jo with her legs spread wide as Erin thumbed the dart of light brown pubic hair that Jo kept over her clit. Jo was looking down her body, watching Erin, her face frozen in a state of anticipation that mirrored mine.

One more pic to go. I didn't dare touch my erection. I was so close. I put the phone down, fought for breath, and tried my best to steady my beating heart. Calmer, I thumbed to the final image, knowing what I'd see, but still not believing that I would.

Erin's head was buried between Jo's thighs as Jo tossed her head back, frozen in ecstasy.

For a heavy, uncertain moment, I wondered what had I unleashed. I'd put her in this situation, I'd given her AJ's cock and Jo's sexy body and a night of total debauchery. In the morning, would I be enough? Six months from now, would she still be okay with our mostly normal life?

It was so obvious that this was probably a bad idea, yet one look at the photos on my phone and I knew I didn't want to stop. Not yet.

I didn't receive anything after that. Not for the longest time. But it was enough. I went over and over those images, stroking myself to the brink, then backing down. More was to come—of that I was certain. I was going to hold out as long as possible.

A lukewarm shower later, a new message waited for me on my phone. This one was from Jo, and started with a text.

-these two sure like fucking each other

A video was attached. My breathing went shallow. I dropped my towel and climbed into bed naked before hitting play.

"Ah! Ahh!" My wife's cries filled the room. I hastily dialed the volume back before refocusing on the scene.

Erin was on her hands and knees, hips and ass back as Aj fucked her from behind. Their naked bodies undulated as one, dappled in sweat.

"Come for me, slut," he ordered. He spanked her, drawing another cry. Another moan. "Show your friend how much you love this cock."

Erin buried her face in the bed and reached between her legs. I knew that move. That was her finisher. She was doing as she was told.

Aj took control of her hips, pulling her against him with each thrust. Their wet slapping rose above their cries. "You feel so fucking good, Erin. Fuck!"

Erin's words were an unintelligible jumble of moans and gasps. I could only pick out one word: *come*.

"Yeah? I bet you want my come," Aj barked.

"Yes!"

"You're such...a...slut." Aj punctuated each word with a drive of his hips. "Fuck, I love it. I knew you had it in you the moment you walked into the gym."

Erin just moaned beneath him, taking his words along with the fucking.

"I bet you can't wait for your pretty blonde friend to eat my come out of your pussy, can you?"

Erin moaned something that passed for a yes.

"Then, I'm going to watch you two lesbo it out. If you can get me hard, we'll see about your kinky fantasy."

AJ seemed to let her ponder that a moment before slipping his thumb down the crack of her ass and pressing it against her anus. "Who knew you were such a whore for anal."

"Fuck!" Erin cried, crashing through the roof. Her head was turned to the camera, pressed into the mattress. Her face was red, her teeth clenched, her eyes shut tight. Her orgasm thrashed through her, as intense as any I'd ever seen.

More intense than when she was with me?

The insecurity didn't have time to settle in before AJ joined her. He sat up on his knees, dragging Erin's hips with him. Shoulders back, chest and pelvis forward, he bellowed an orgasm like the primal alpha he fashioned himself to be.

Erin screamed, rolling into yet another climax as she felt her lover join her. AJ pumped two more times. One more. Then pulled free, his cock still hard.

And bare back.

I bet you can't wait for your pretty blonde friend to eat my come out of your pussy...

AJ looked at the camera and grinned. "Ready to clean this slut up?"

And then the video ended.

*

I don't know how much I slept. Not much, that was for sure. I kept waking up to check my phone for something new, but Jo's video was the last thing I got.

Erin came in sometime in the early morning, crawling into bed smelling freshly showered. I had no idea what time it was, but the sun hadn't risen yet and I was still dead tired. I still managed to collect her in my arms and ask, "You have fun?"

Erin turned into me, kissing me softly. Her lips tasted minty. "So much fun."

My cock swelled. "Did you behave?"

"Not even a little." She kissed me again, this time pushing her tongue into my mouth. "Jo's already talking about a second round before she leaves."

I ran my hand down her naked back until I discovered panties. I thought of all the possibilities of later tonight, when it was my turn. "Can't wait until you show me what you did."

Erin kissed me. "Hope you've got an open mind."

I felt the warmth of my smile spread through me. "Do you really have to hope?"

Erin laughed softly. "Let's get some rest before the kids wake up."

OceanofPDF.com

SIX

Erin got up before me. I vaguely remember her crawling from the bed, but was too beat to follow her out. Not that I fell back to sleep, exactly. Not with all the thoughts whirling around in my head. Not when I'd lay back, close my eyes, and see AJ driving his thick cock into my wife. It had been a couple months since the last time I'd witnessed Erin fuck another man—besides the few times I'd rewatched her video. The act still left me reeling, gasping, wondering what in the hell were we doing?

I didn't think I'd ever be able to get comfortable with it, but that was a good thing, right? As soon as this all became comfortable, what would I crave next? Where would we go?

But it was more than her having sex with another man. She hadn't just had sex with AJ, she got *fucked* by AJ. She gave in to him. She let herself get totally possessed by him. He'd made her crave things that she didn't know she wanted.

It didn't make sense, I knew. I was being completely irrational, for sure. And maybe Erin was right. Maybe we shouldn't be doing this at all.

But then I thought about how amazingly exciting I got.

I'm going to watch you two lesbo it out. If you can get me hard, we'll see about your kinky fantasy.

What was her kinky fantasy? And were they able to get AJ hard enough to do it?

I lay in bed long enough to get my head right and my cock down, then rose, pulled on my robe, and headed downstairs.

I'm not sure what I was expecting. Certainly not the picture of Saturday morning domesticity that greeted me, although it made total sense. The kids were in the living

room, watching Saturday morning cartoons—albeit on the iPad—as Erin and Jo cleaned up the remnants of breakfast.

“Looks who’s awake!” Jo said.

If either woman was tired, neither showed it. Both were dressed for the day, as fresh and presentable as ever.

“When he goes to bed, he can be a total teenager,” Erin said, smiling.

Just a few hours ago, these two were exploring each other’s bodies as another man watched. I tried to detect any awkwardness between them, but there was none.

“He’s thinking about...us,” Jo said.

Erin laughed. “Of course he is. He’s a man.” She pulled down a mug and filled it from the pot. It smelled heavenly. “Coffee?”

“Please.”

“He speaks!” Jo said, clapping.

I took a hearty pull at the coffee, letting it warm my chest. I said, “He’s going to do a whole lot more later.”

Jo’s eyes flared. “I’m counting on it.”

Erin watched us with a smile, then turned away. “There are a few eggs left. Toast?”

The day progressed like any other Saturday—albeit one where I’d gotten too little sleep. We bundled up and browsed the farmers’ market. We took the kids to the library for reading time. We had burgers for lunch and then a lazy afternoon. Jo behaved like Auntie Jo throughout, boisterous and fun and too...mature to be natural.

Or maybe that was the new Jo, after all. I’d mostly known her when she was in her early twenties, and then after that, through the crazy stories that Erin related to me. But nearly a decade sat between then and now, and things changed. People changed. She was in her thirties now, with a law career and the respect of her colleagues. I didn’t know whether she wanted children or not, but when I watched her play with ours, I saw the affection there. She was good with them.

In the late afternoon, Erin packed them up and trucked them to her parents' house, leaving me and Jo alone. Jo and I were chopping things to go into a salad, when it occurred to me how mundane this activity was, considering what was going to happen later tonight. I started to laugh.

"What?" Jo asked, although her smile told me she had a pretty good idea.

"Sometimes, I feel like we're just pretending to be adults," I said.

"I know what you mean." Jo paused, going contemplative before answering. I studied her. Her skin was still smooth, although she had the kind of sunny beauty that could manage a few lines and probably look better because of them. I hadn't realized she'd been focused on something far away until she refocused on me. "But you know, it takes an adult to do what you do."

For a second, I thought she was making some joke about sex and adults-only. Then I saw that she wasn't joking at all. "How's that?"

"When I look at you and Erin, I see two people who love each other, having a good time. Even last night, when we were with AJ, you were there with her."

Hearing that, warmth spread through me. I couldn't stop the smile from forming.

"Can I say something else?" Jo asked, then didn't wait for me to answer. "I've never seen Erin like this. She's so...I don't know...confident."

"Sexual?"

"Yes!" Jo's eyes brightened. "She's always been attractive, but now she knows it. Like, really, really knows it."

"That's not just my doing, though. AJ has something to do with the newfound confidence."

Jo nodded. "Sure, of course he does. But you're part of that, too. You let her be with him."

I chewed on that. I hadn't thought of things quite that way, but it made sense, and it made me feel better to think of AJ as more of a device that Erin and I used.

Jo continued. "And last night, Erin knew exactly what she was doing. I'm not sure that I could have played a man like AJ as well as she did."

"Looked to me like it was more the other way around," I said, thinking of how AJ had spoken to her, how he commanded her.

"Maybe to the untrained eye. But trust me, Erin was the one really calling the shots."

I recalled that photo series—of Erin pulling off Jo's panties, of Erin burying her face between Jo's legs. "So are you two...?"

Jo laughed. "I could go one of two ways with that question. Either you're asking if things are awkward between us—which you should know from watching us today that they're not—or if we've already secretly snuck off to make out again."

I hadn't thought of the latter. My brain didn't know how to process it, although jealousy and excitement were both there in high doses. "Um..."

"We're good. It didn't end our friendship, although I must say..." Jo touched her tongue to her upper lip as she thought. "Erin felt really good when she was eating my pussy."

That chased the jealousy away, leaving nothing but hungry excitement. "When she does a thing, she goes all the way," I said.

Jo reached out and touched my chest fleetingly. Her hand dropped before it could be considered a caress. "Oh, you have no idea how true that is," she said. "But tonight, I suspect that you'll get an idea."

She laughed at whatever expression must have registered across my face, twirled away, and headed for the

stairs. “Mind if I use the master shower? Erin clued me in on how...thorough a clean the detachable head gives.”

I groaned at the thought of Jo upstairs, masturbating, before it occurred to me that I’d be seeing a whole lot more later that night. I went back to cutting vegetables for the salad, wondering how I’d ended up with such a charmed life.

And whether any other sane person would think it really charmed.

*

“Can you see?” Erin asked.

I shifted my head from left to right, but all I could see was darkness. “No.”

When she spoke again, her voice was surprisingly close. “You’re not lying, are you?”

I chuckled. “No, I swear.”

“Good.”

I felt her smooth body pass across my own naked skin. With the blindfold secured, my other senses were working extra to compensate. She’d showered, just as Jo had. I could smell her floral shampoo and the soap that we shared.

She took my wrist in her hand and pulled it into something cool. I knew the setup, having seen the pic from last night—*Look what I have to play with*—but it still surprised me when she pulled the wrist restraint closed. Panic fluttered through me as she slowly took away my control. I couldn’t believe that AJ had allowed her to do this.

My other wrist and my two ankles followed suit, and soon enough I was spread eagled on the bed.

“How do you feel?” Erin asked, her voice drifting up from between my legs.

“Helpless.”

I felt her weight ease up the bed. A moment later, the wet, warm sensation of her mouth descended around my cock. “And now?” she asked.

“Still helpless, but in a good way.”

“Mm, I’m sure.”

She bobbed along my length, slow and languid, nursing my cock to full length. With the blindfold on, even this gentle sensation was intense. “Um...are we retelling now?” I asked.

Her mouth left me for a moment. “Are you asking me if I sucked AJ’s cock last night, while he was tied to the bed?”

“Yes—” She cut me off by closing her lips around me again, sucking me more thoroughly.

Her mouth left me again, and I could feel her breath hot along my calls. “Are you asking if I sucked his balls? Like this?”

I felt the flat of Erin’s tongue slither down to my scrotum before she swallowed both balls into her mouth. I groaned, barely withstanding the torment. She wrapped her hand around the shaft, pumping her spit into it as she sucked my sac.

“Uh, Erin.”

She switched back to my shaft, her bobs more aggressive than the warmup. I wasn’t sure how much more of this I could take.

“The answer is yes, Aj was treated to all of this,” Erin said. It took half a second for me to realize that even as she spoke, the lips never left my cock.

I’m not sure how I kept from losing it. Not as the image of what was really happening clicked into place. Not when I suddenly imagined Jo’s lips on me, her curly hair bouncing around her as she sucked my cock in her more forceful way. Whose hand was jerking me off in time with it? Jo’s? Erin’s? Or was I just imagining—

“Oh, fuck!” I groaned as a second mouth—Erin’s mouth—went back to work on my balls. I pulled against the restraints. The bed creaked, but it held.

They switched, one wet mouth sliding away for another. The differences were subtle. Erin used less suction but more

tongue. Erin could take more of me into her mouth, I was proud to notice, but Jo seemed to have perfected the harmony between her stroking hand and her lips.

Not that I could keep track of the differences. After about three switches, I was lost in the sheer pleasure of their soft, wet mouths.

The bed shifted. Someone moved up my body. I felt her hair brush along my shoulder, soft and smooth. "You have a nice cock, Tom." Jo's voice, husky and different. Erin sucked down harder on that nice cock of mine as her best friend teased me. "I'm going to enjoy feeling it inside my pussy."

My breath caught—from her words, from Erin's mouth, from both...

Jo drifted back down between my legs. I felt them switch again. I heard the unmistakable sound of a kiss being delivered onto wet skin, although I didn't feel the touch on me. What were they doing down there? Who had kissed who? And where?

Then the whispering came, punctuated by soft giggles. Their mouths left my cock. I shifted, groaning internally until I felt something else against my cock. Something warmer than a mouth. And a hell of a lot more slippery.

Whoever's pussy it was, it enveloped me with little resistance. I wish I could have told said definitively that it was or it wasn't Erin over me, that I knew her so well that I'd be able to detect any slight difference. I was too amped up to notice anything so subtle. I felt a pussy around my cock, which was so ready to feel one.

Not that she stayed a mystery for long. After a few slow fucks, Jo let out a long moan.

"How does she feel?" Erin asked, her lips right up against my ear. I jumped. "How does Jo feel?"

"I..." I still didn't believe this was really happening.

Erin, sensing my disbelief, took my hand and pulled it down between my legs. "Touch her. See for yourself."

At first, I wasn't sure what she was getting at. She still had her panties on, the soft lace stretched to the side to bare the even softer warmth of a woman's skin. Then I felt it, the brush of pubic hair, cropped and trimmed into a tight landing strip, and incredibly strange. I traced its outline, traced it right down to where my shaft entered her.

I gasped, looking in the direction that Erin had been. She was still there. I felt the warmth of her face, and my nose brushed through her hair. She was looking down the length of me, too, watching me have sex with another woman.

"How do you...?" I began, but the question was absurd. *How do you feel?* When I was the one who was at the center of this?

I felt Erin shift, refocusing on me. She touched my face just beneath the blindfold, tracing my jaw. "It's...weird, but..."

My chest filled with ice. We shouldn't have gone here. We shouldn't be doing this.

She went on. "But it's so sexy, too. Like...I can't describe it. It's wrong, but good. I feel jealous, but that jealousy is exciting, too." She kissed me, pushing her tongue into my mouth with an aggression I wasn't expecting. When she pulled back, she said, "This is how you feel, isn't it?"

"Yes."

"I don't know how you deal with it so much. I'd go insane."

I said, "Sometimes I think I am."

"Well, it's a sexy insanity. And I'm grateful for it." She shifted over me. "Now, let's see. What did we do next with AJ?"

"You sat on his face as I fucked him," Jo said, reminding me that she was still here. "And we had our first kiss."

"Oh, right." A moment later, Erin's thighs eclipsed my head. She lowered her wet sex onto my lips, wiggling her hips in encouragement. I took it, running my tongue across

her smooth folds. Yes, this was my wife. Her taste was familiar. Her moans were recognized.

And then I heard the kissing. The sounds were faint, heard around Erin's taut thighs and the shifting blindfold. But it was unmistakable. The wet, muted smacks, occasionally broken by a slurp, a sigh, a moan. I nearly came as I imagined the two of them, old friends, new lovers. The only thing that stopped me was the realization that AJ probably wouldn't have. Not yet. It's amazing what a little competition could do.

I redoubled my efforts on Erin's pussy, driving my tongue like a little cock into her depths. When I felt Jo's long fingers play across Erin's clit, I was once again fighting back my orgasm.

Erin crested first, clamping her thighs around my head as she ground herself into me. For a moment, I was smothered—blind, deaf, unable to breathe, unable to shout out. Panic swelled through me. I held out, stars blossoming in the darkness.

Then she was off of me, and I sucked in sweet, sex-laden air as Jo rode me wildly. My blindfold had slipped enough that I could see, and the sight was legendary. Jo rose up over me, topless and lean, her full tits bouncing wildly with each undulation. Erin moved into place behind her, filling her hands with Jo's breasts as Jo turned her head back over her shoulder. Their lips met, tongues meeting a moment before their mouths closed on one another in a deep, girl-on-girl kiss. They were not faking it. This was as real as Jo's cunt was wrapped around me.

Jo pulled free of the kiss and turned to me, looking very pleased with herself. "Want to hear what happened next?" she asked.

I glanced at Erin over her shoulder. She watched me with a smile of her own, her thumbs making slow rotations around Jo's nipples. I nodded.

“Well, we fucked some more. Until AJ’s big dick couldn’t take any more and he came deep inside of me.” Jo leaned forward, pulling away from Erin’s embrace. She began to undo the restraints holding me to the bed. “And then, your wife went down on me and ate his come right out of my pussy.”

It was like Jo had found my switch and had given it a hard flip. My orgasm tore through me, sending me back to that place where I couldn’t breath or speak or see. Jo’s words echoed through me, *ate his come right out of my pussy...out of my pussy...my pussy...* I became untethered, vaguely aware of Jo’s driving hips and the way her pussy tightened around my shaft, milking every drop.

I came back to reality when the snug sensation left me. I wondered if this is what it felt like to wake from a coma. Everything felt disorienting. It all felt like some crazy dream that I expected to wake from at any moment.

Then the giggle came—Erin’s—followed by whispers. By kisses. I scooted up to the head of the bed, propping myself on the pillows just in time to watch Erin wrap her hand behind Jo’s neck and pull her in for a French kiss.

Just moments after unleashing one of the most overwhelming orgasms of my life, my cock stirred. Fuck!

We’d arrived at the second set of photos. Erin kissed Jo. Erin walked her lips down her best friend’s incredible body, stopping to kiss and suckle the other woman’s nipples. She hooked her thumbs into Jo’s thong, and together they got naked. Jo glanced over Erin’s shoulder, shooting me a crooked smile.

Erin touched Jo’s pussy, pink and glistening. I got a clearer view of her slit, adorned with a narrow, inverted triangle of hair that pointed the way. My pearly white come leaked from her. Erin scooped it up with her fingers and licked it clean. “Yum.”

“Ready to watch your wife eat pussy?”

My eyes drooped, but there was nothing I could do about it. If it were possible to be drunk on lust, I'd be trashed.

"She's very good at it," Jo said as Erin leaned her back and spread open her thighs. "Such a shame we didn't fool around back in college."

Erin brushed her dark hair from her face, giving me a clear view as she dipped low and kissed Jo right on her hooded button. Erin looked back at me one last time. *Watch*, she seemed to say. *Watch your good little wife be very, very bad*. Then she pushed her tongue into the other woman's sex.

Jo gasped, arching her back. Her hand found mine, linking fingers and squeezing. Erin danced her thumb and fingers across Jo's clit as she slurped my come out of Jo's pussy. Jo writhed under Erin's assault, tweaking her nipples with her free hand.

Erin wasn't hesitant—not the way she'd been with Haley last year. There was nothing tentative in the way she buried her face in Jo's lap, in the rhythmic motion of her head, or the way she slipped her hand into place.

I sat there dumbly, watching the Sapphic show like it was just that—a show. Erin was stretched out on her stomach like a sunbather. Jo was reclined on her arms, her head tossed back, her curly hair damp and wild down her back.

I loved watching, but this opportunity called for action.

I walked on my knees up beside them, running my hands up Erin's silky legs. I could feel her muscles dance beneath my palms. It had been ages since I'd given her an erotic massage. I made a mental note to do that.

Jo's eyes opened, meeting mine below her heavy lids. I smiled quietly and dropped my head down to her chest. Her nipple tasted like sweat and something sweeter. It hardened against my tongue.

Jo moaned. "Jesus, you two. That's...good..."

Erin drilled her fingers into her friend, switching her lips and tongue back to Jo's clit. The blonde shoved her chest against my mouth, filling it with soft tit flesh. Her fingers raked through my hair, tightening. Holding me in place.

I felt a hand close around my cock. Erin's hand, stroking it back to life as she fucked her friend. Pulling away, Erin said to Jo, "Make him hard for me. Suck his cock."

"Yes, ma'am," Jo said. She pushed me away, took my half-hard erection from Erin, and twisted herself until she could take me in her mouth and still have my wife's mouth between her legs. "All that yoga just paid off," she said, then swallowed me into her throat.

I wasn't as young as I used to be, but even still, it didn't take long before Jo had me hard again. When I was, I moved into position behind Erin and drove into her, filling her sweet, familiar pussy with my erection. It felt like coming home.

"You know we're off-script now," Erin said, her words wound tight. "From last night, I mean."

"I don't have a problem with that," I said. In fact, I liked it better this way. Aj had his fun, but here we got to do something new.

"Good, because I want to try something else we didn't do."

We shifted, Jo rotating around to slide in beneath Erin, forming a girl-on-girl sixty-nine. Jo alternated between Erin's pussy and my balls, bathing us with her soft tongue as we rutted and moaned.

I fought the temptation to just give in, to let myself go and fill my wife. My prior orgasm helped with that control. Instead, Jo and I explored Erin together, testing angles and speeds, harmonizing with Jo's tongue until we found the perfect technique to drive Erin wild.

Jo and I synced, matching stroke for stroke. I'd push inside her, Jo would run her tongue across her clit. Erin's

breath turned into a shallow grunt. She was so close. Nearly there.

Push. Lick. Withdraw. She wasn't breathing at all any more. Push. Lick. Withdraw. She was a bomb without a fuse, all potential energy ready to explode. I pushed my thumb against her asshole on the final shove. Jo closed her mouth over her clit, sucking down.

Erin exploded, screaming until she lost her voice. Her pussy rippled and collapsed around my shaft, blurring out the world. I felt a tongue on my balls, but somehow, against all odds, I didn't come. I wasn't ready yet. There was still a thing I needed to know.

Jo crawled out from under Erin, her mouth and cheeks glistening. She didn't pause a beat before dipping into another deep kiss with my wife. I sat back, my cock sliding free before I completely lost control.

Reaching out, I ran my hand along the soft curve where Erin's ass met the tops of her thighs. The women broke from their kiss, turning to look at me. "So that didn't happen last night?" I asked.

They shook their heads. "That was new," Erin said.

"And really fun," Jo added.

"So what did happen?"

Erin turned to me, crawling over me and into a kiss of our own. I could taste Jo on her lips and tongue. I shivered. "You saw part of it. AJ took turns with us, fucking us really, really *hard*." Her hand closed around my erection. "First Jo. Then me."

Jo came up beside us, her hands exploring our bodies.

"But something else happened, didn't it?" I said. The moment felt fragile, like soap bubble floating in the breeze. Erin stared down at me, shyness touching her cheeks, but not her eyes.

"Yes."

"Your kinky fantasy," I said, quieter.

Erin looked at Jo.

"Your wife has some very naughty fantasies," Jo said.

"Like what?" I asked, turning back to Erin.

"I could tell you," she said, stroking my cock. "Or we could show you."

"Yes. That."

Erin smiled, as though about to laugh, but no sound came out. Without breaking eye contact with me, she said, "Jo, reach into my nightstand. There's some KY Jelly there."

My breath caught. "What did you...what did you do?"

Erin's gaze shifted between my eyes as she bored into my mind. I realized the fragility wasn't of the moment, it was of my own psyche. Jo handed Erin the bottle of lube, and Erin expertly applied it to my cock.

"Well, ever since...ever since Haley, I've had this fantasy." She kissed me, then turned her back to me, maintaining eye contact over her shoulder. She rubbed more lube along the crack of her buttocks. "I want to feel a big, hard cock in my ass, while someone eats my pussy."

I opened my mouth to speak, but my chest tight enough that I didn't have breath enough for words. Erin reached back, positioned me against her asshole, and sat on my cock.

We'd had anal sex a few times. I knew she enjoyed it, ever since AJ had introduced it to her last year. In the video I had of her with AJ and Lamar Williamson, there was no doubt how turned on she was when she had a cock in her ass. But to hear her confess that this was one of her ultimate fantasies blew my mind. It almost blew other things, too. Somehow it didn't.

As I sank through the tight ring of Erin's ass, I felt her breath catch in her chest as she reined in a cry. She arched back over me, thrusting her breasts high, a wave frozen in mid-crest. And then her cry broke free, equal parts pain and ecstasy.

"Oh...mygod!" The blasphemy came out like champagne being released from a freshly uncorked bottle. And like the

froth, she couldn't stop. "Ohmygod...*ohmyGOD!*"

"She loves anal sex," Jo said, crawling into place between Erin's legs. "I've never seen anyone so into it than this slut right here."

Jo licked her fingers before running them across Erin's unattended cunt. Erin's cries grew louder. She braced herself, her arms behind her, supporting her. I grabbed her hips and together, we found a rhythm, her ass slowly rising and falling on my erection.

"You can fuck her harder, you know," Jo said. "Trust me, you won't break her."

I looked down at Jo as the woman pushed two fingers into Erin's pussy. Her eyes danced. She added, "Aj certainly had no problem power-fucking your wife's asshole last night."

Something feral awoke inside of me, filling my veins with fire. Jo was right, Aj didn't take the gentle approach with Erin. Not with her body. Not with her mouth. Not with her ass. Jo raised her brows in challenge. *Show me what you're going to do.*

All of a sudden, the gentle husband in me fell away. I thought of Aj that first time Erin had given her backdoor to him, how he'd pinned her to the bed and hammered her ass. I dug my fingertips into her hips and took control, thrusting up as I dragged her down.

Erin twisted, screaming in pain and pleasure. The decent side of me nearly balked. The rest of me ignored her, rutting harder and faster into her. Jo dipped forward, clamping her mouth over Erin's shaven mound. Erin shuddered, like she'd been struck, and suddenly she was screaming harder, screaming her orgasm for the neighbors to hear.

I closed my eyes and did everything in my power to keep from joining her. I thought about work. I thought about how I'd probably need to head down to New Orleans to check up on the team. Or the annual performance reviews

coming up. I thought about how there was a forecast for snow next week, and that I should probably make a reservation for Valentine's Day, and—

“Want to go off-script?” I heard Jo say.

“What?” I said.

“Let's do it,” she said. I looked, and she was holding a flesh-colored dildo that I didn't recognize. It was massive—larger than my cock for sure. “Only thing better would be if this was a strapon.”

With Erin still floating in the wake of her climax, Jo placed the dildo against her pussy and shoved home.

“You love the feeling of two cocks in you, don't you, Erin?” Jo said.

“Uhhh...” Erin moaned in reply.

“You liked feeling them inside you at once, didn't you?” With her free hand, Jo started playing with Erin's clit. “Tell me. Didn't you?”

“Ye...yes...”

Jo leaned down, kissing up Erin's ribs, to the underside of her bouncing breasts. “Maybe the two of us should get together with AJ and Lamar sometime? Maybe you could fly out to LA and we could all...get together.”

The memory of her gym encounter flooded back. I fought back my orgasm, but Jo's teasing words were having the same effect on Erin. Her anus tightened around the base of my cock. Her body tightened as one last orgasm built.

Jo twisted the dildo inside of Erin. “You'd like that, wouldn't you? Taking them together?”

I thought Jo was asking Erin—maybe she was—but her eyes were on me. I saw them going at one another in a furious sixty-nine as AJ and Lamar fucked them in a wild knot of sweaty flesh. I couldn't take it anymore. My balls tightened. I grabbed Erin's hips and pulled her down to me until my pelvic bone pressed into her ass cheeks.

“Oh,” Erin moaned. Then again, louder. “Oh!” Then one final time, her body stiff, her back arched, her eyes shut

tight. "OH!"

Jo pulled the dildo from her pussy, throwing it across the room as she swooped in and finished her with her mouth and fingers. *This isn't a cock fucking you*, she seemed to say. *I'm a woman, and you love what I can do to you.*

I exploded, the last thing I saw was the flat of Jo's tongue running over Erin's exposed clit as her eyes locked on mine.

We collapsed in a heap of heavy breathing flesh. I released Erin's hips, slumping into the pillows at the head of the bed, lost in the haze of my release. I felt drained.

Erin slid off of me, and for a second, I considered pulling the covers up around me and sleeping. Then the women shifted back into a sixty-nine, Jo on top, aggressively eating Erin's pussy and, incredibly, her ass, where my come had begun to leak. I saw it without processing it. That couldn't be happening, right?

And even that sight wasn't going to be enough to get me up. That wasn't going to happen again tonight. Still, it was just beautiful and raunchy and unbelievable to watch two attractive women play with each other.

I stroked them as their bodies ebbed and flowed, breath catching, shuddering, moaning. I skimmed my fingers over the sweat-slick curves of Erin's butt and back, touching the sides of her breasts, her neck, her face. She pulled off Jo's pussy to suck on my fingers before returning to her Sapphic play.

Above her, Jo's climax rolled through her, languid yet powerful. Erin pressed her cunt up into Jo's mouth, reducing the other woman's orgasm to a muffle.

When it was over, they untangled and cuddled up on either side of me. Erin said, "I love you guys."

"I love you, too," Jo said, her voice husky from all the sex. "Tom's not bad, either."

"He's not, is he?" Erin smiled.

OceanofPDF.com

SEVEN

When I woke up the next day, I wondered if what happened last night was some kind of crazy dream. That led me to wonder whether the entire last year has been some kind of crazy dream. After all, until about a year ago, I was a completely normal dude, with a great, but normal family and a better than normal life in general. But in a normal way.

But then Jo pressed her warm, naked body against me on one side, and I felt Erin shift on her side of the bed, and I realized that I'd suddenly fallen into the life of a rockstar.

"You're awake," Jo croaked, her voice smoky with sleep.

I said, "I'm still trying to figure that out."

Jo's laugh was husky. She stretched, her body quivering, before she slipped out of bed. "I'm going to take a shower. Join me?"

"I don't think..." I looked in the direction of my sleeping wife.

"She's been bragging non-stop about your shower trick. Come on, show me."

I dragged my eyes away from Erin, up to Jo, who rose naked over me, her arm outstretched. I thought about my wife in this situation, with me asleep at her side and another man tempting her away. What would I have wanted her to do?

I had no clue.

"Maybe later," I said.

Jo shrugged, as if to say, *Your loss*, then swiveled on her heel and sauntered toward the bathroom. I followed her ass as she put an extra sway in it. While I thought Erin had the best ass in the world, Jo's smaller, tighter one definitely drew my eyes.

She disappeared into the bathroom. A moment later, the shower cut on. I rolled onto my back and thought about the hot water splashing over Jo's svelte body, and wondered if I'd made a mistake. After all, would Erin really care?

That's when I noticed that Erin had turned over to face me. That she was awake and watching with a small smile on her face. That she must have been awake the whole time.

"You could go, you know," she said.

I settled onto the bed beside her, my head on my pillow, one hand tucked up under it. I ignored her offer. "Last night was incredible."

"Yes, it was."

I hated how insecure my next question would sound, but I had to ask it. "How did it compare to Friday night?"

As always, Erin didn't give the automatic answer. Maybe once upon a time, she would have. She'd say, *No question, it's always better with you.* We were beyond that now. Instead, she paused and thought through her answer before giving it. "Different. It's always different." Her smile came slowly, but it came. "But you want to know which was better."

I did, but knew by now that there was no easy answer to that. I held my tongue. Erin spoke for me.

"Honestly?" She took a breath, and my heart rate spiked with it. "Honestly, last night was better. And I'm not saying that just because it's what you want to hear. I'm not sure that it is." She looked at me pointedly.

I shrugged. It was fair.

"With AJ, things are..." She looked up into her lashes as a flush crept across her face. "Physical. Powerful. You've watched. You've seen it. When I'm with him, it's like I'm his plaything. And I love being his plaything."

Jealousy thrummed inside of me, but it was manageable.

"With you...you're more comfortable. More...considerate. Both are awesome. We have a

connection that's more than just..."

"Physical," I offered.

"Right. But last night, I realized something." She sorted through her thoughts. "When you were...inside my ass—" She paused, laughing. "Saying it out loud like that sounds so much worse!"

I nodded, out of agreement, or encouragement, I don't know. I was eager to hear more.

"Anyway, when you were back there, and Jo was going down on me, I couldn't help but compare it when we did that with AJ. At the time, I'd thought it was everything I'd wanted—one of my dirtiest fantasies made real. It was raw and wrong and so amazing to feel."

I'd never known that. Erin had wanted this crazy thing and until now, she'd never felt comfortable to share. I held my tongue, letting her work through her thoughts.

"But when we did it last night... When you were holding me against you as you pumped my ass... When I could smell...*you*. When I could turn my head and kiss you. When I could look into your eyes as Jo did these amazing things with her fingers and mouth... I realized how amazing the fantasy was. How much was missing when I did it with AJ."

Incredibly, a tear formed in her eye. She wiped it away, seemingly annoyed by it, and shook her head. "Ah, anyway. Last night was better. Was the best. I love you, baby. And not just because you let me do dirty things with other men."

I couldn't stop smiling. I kissed her, slow and softly. "Thanks for that. You know, I'm going to have to change one of our rules."

Erin lifted a brow. "Oh yeah? What's that?"

"The one about not doing anything with other guys before you've done them with me."

"Naughty. Okay, maybe we can figure some things out. Now, you need to get in there before she's done."

"I'd rather be here."

“That’s so sweet,” Erin said. “Don’t worry, I’ll join you. But you do need to show Jo the shower trick. I really have been bragging.”

“Ha. Okay. But you better join me.”

*

Jo and Erin ended up going over to AJ’s again before Jo flew back home to LA. It was odd to feel the same nervous excitement watching Jo get ready for AJ as I did when Erin did it, but just as fun. I even got to reclaim her—after I reclaimed Erin—when Erin sent me into the guest bedroom. “I’ll be listening,” she said, gesturing at the wall between our rooms.

Eventually, though, the fun finally ended when Jo packed her things one last time and headed for the airport.

Not that anything really ended there. AJ was still in town through the month, and Erin wasn’t about to let the opportunity pass her by. It was fun watching her get excited as a night out with AJ approached, even more exciting when she was out with him and I was alone, and best of all when she returned and told me how deliciously naughty she was with him. But I couldn’t help it—the encounters lacked the edge that they once had. When I admitted this to Erin one night while we lay in bed, I was surprised when she agreed.

“It’s just that the novelty is worn off,” she said. “That...rush that comes with trying new things.”

Trying new things, not *dating a new guy*. She wasn’t looking for love, or relationships. She wasn’t looking for the next best thing—not that AJ was even close to that. And maybe that was part of why things were less exciting for me. The danger was gone, and with it, part of the thrill.

Then I thought about life without AJ, and knew that while it may not be as exciting as it had been the first time she’d gone off to Annapolis, it was pretty damn exciting.

“What are you thinking, Tom?”

“That I’m not ready to stop...unless you are.”

The way she sidled up to me and placed a hand on my chest caused a fresh tremor to rise up through me. “No,” she said. “I’m not ready to stop either.”

“You once mentioned something about fulfilling fantasies,” I said slowly. “That when you were with Jo and AJ —”

“It was one of my dirtiest fantasies.” Erin brought her lips to my ear. “And you want to know what the others are.”

“You have others?”

I felt her brush her hair away. “I do.”

I knew she did, but hearing her admit it still felt like an exciting confession. I pushed her away, onto her back. “Tell me.”

She stared up at me, scanning my face. She looked like she was trying to decide whether to blush or not.

I decided to help her out. I slipped down between her legs, pulling the sheets with me.

“Cold,” she complained.

I pushed her negligee up over her hips, exposing her smooth sex. “Looks warm to me.” I kissed her mound, where once upon a time she’d kept a strip of hair. That was before AJ. Before we’d begun on this long journey. “So tell me your dirtiest fantasy.”

I didn’t wait for her to answer. I didn’t expect one immediately. Instead, I ran my tongue along the familiar swells of skin, drawing comfort around her like a warm blanket. When I pressed my fingers into her sex, she was ready to talk.

“I want...” She paused to moan, her body lifting off the mattress as an orgasm built. I backed off slightly, tracing my lips around her clit without using my tongue. She rocked her hips forward. I didn’t give in.

“What do you want?”

“To have sex—”

I slashed my tongue across her clit, and she bit back a moan. Once again, I withdrew, leaving her gasping. She threaded her fingers through my hair, tightening them into fists. Pain seared along my scalp, but I didn't indulge her further. I waited, and at last, I was rewarded.

"I want to have sex with men. Lots of men. At...at the same time."

Her confession spread through me like wildfire, set off somewhere deep in my chest. I had suspected something like this, but suspecting it and hearing it were completely different things.

"I want to be at the center of it all. To feel their hard bodies...fucking me. *Using* me."

Her grip pulsed in my hair, tightening and releasing, tightening and releasing. I went to work on her pussy, working her with every trick I had. Her ass rose off the bed, driving her cunt against my mouth and fingers. And still, the confession went on.

"I want to feel them everywhere. In my mouth. On my tits. In my pussy." She moaned. "In my ass."

I saw it in that fevered moment—Erin at the center of muscled men, held up between them as they fucked her into oblivion. How long had she harbored this fantasy? Was it new, after AJ? Or had she always had it?

"I want to be smothered in sex, until I can barely breath. Until I can't even think. And then I want more. I want it until I...until I..." Her climax rose. My jaw ached from working so hard. "I want them to fuck me into unconsciousness."

She exploded, nearly tearing my hair out in the process. I latched onto her pussy, my tongue flicking her clit until she couldn't take any more. Until she shoved me away, her body convulsing in the aftermath of her climax.

Only I couldn't leave it at that. My body craved her feel. My cock needed to find a place to rest. I rose over her, erection huge in my hand. She whined huskily as I pressed it against my lips, but didn't stop me. I pushed in.

“God, you feel big,” she whispered. “You like that fantasy?”

“I love it,” I said. “I love it because it’s yours. Not mine.”

She nodded, understanding what I was saying. We may have started down this road with AJ because of my unearthed desire to see her with another man. She’d made it her own fantasy, but its root was always with me. This one, a gangbang with Erin at its center, was all hers.

She said, “You don’t think it’s disgusting?”

I answered with my hips, thrusting in and out of her with purpose. “It’s a fantasy. Nothing is off-limits if it’s something you want to try.”

Erin laughed. “I didn’t say I wanted to try it.”

“But...”

“That’s the difference between you and me, maybe. Just because I fantasize about it doesn’t mean I want to do it.”

“You came close with AJ and Lamar.”

Erin’s smile was a quiet one. “I did. But that was nothing when I think about what could be.” She laughed at whatever crazed expression I must have made. “Seriously though, I’m not looking to live that dream. I promise. I may think about it sometimes...like when you’re not around and I’m in the shower...”

She felt my cock surge and giggled.

“But if I take it to my old age, I won’t have any regrets. Okay?”

“I’m sure you could talk to AJ. He could probably set something like that up.”

Erin drew me down to her for a kiss. “Oh, I’m sure that he could.”

But she didn’t want that. Not really. End of discussion.

EIGHT

AJ's final night in town came on the first Friday of March. I watched Erin get ready to meet him, taking a little extra effort than she normally did. She spent a long time in the shower, and when she emerged, she was pink and scrubbed clean, wearing just a towel.

"So what's the plan tonight?" I asked her.

She'd already applied her makeup, apparently. She'd put on eye shadow, dark gray and borderline trashy to go along with her dark eyeliner, but it was her lips that were most striking—bright red and so unlike Erin.

"I have a few ideas, based on what AJ told me to wear."

I licked my lips. "And what's that?"

She reached between her breasts and unraveled the towel, letting it pool at her feet. Her nipples were hard, and her smooth mound was practically glossy. She glanced at the dresser. "That's it, right there. Could you bring it to me?"

I was slow to process the request, preoccupied by the sight of her full frontal nudity. When I did, following her eyes to the dresser, at first I saw nothing. Just a little scrap of black leather. Then...

Shakily, I reached out and picked it up. It was a dog collar with a silver ring in the front. "This?"

"That." She bit her lip. Her red, succulent lip. "Put it on me?"

I nodded. When I stepped up to her, and she looked up at me, diminutive and deferential, I shivered. This is how she looked at AJ. This is the kind of woman that she was for him.

I fastened the collar around her neck. Did AJ have a leash at his place? Did he tug on her when she had his cock in her mouth, or pull when he fucked her from behind?

She looked up at me through her long, dark lashes—made to look longer by the dark mascara. “Thank you,” she said softly.

I heard gratitude not just for helping her put the collar on, but for all the potent meaning behind that adornment.

“Hope you have an intense time,” I said.

“Don’t you mean fun, or good?”

“Those, too.”

The only other thing she wore besides the collar was a pair of shockingly tall high heels—heels that I’d never seen before. They were shiny, patent black leather with four-inch heels that looked impossible to walk in.

“Those are some shoes,” I said.

“You like them? They hurt like hell.” She leaned in close enough that I could smell her perfume and see the sparkle in her makeup. “Good thing I won’t be doing much walking in them.”

Erin pulled on her long, black wool coat, buttoning it high enough that I couldn’t even see the collar.

“Keep me updated,” I said.

“I’m not sure that I’ll have my hands free to do something like that.” Her smile was wicked, her tongue peeking out, pink and playful. “But for you, I’ll get creative.”

In the heels, she didn’t even need to go up on her toes to kiss me.

I watched her stroll out the front door and out to her car. She moved with a buoyancy that I loved, that I’d granted to her, even if she was going off with another man. I glanced around our sleepy, little suburb, at all the other houses filled with seemingly normal families. To anyone looking, Erin was just going out to meet up with some girlfriends.

Somehow, that coyness made this all the more sexy. We were flirting with risk and discovery in plain sight, and the risk gave the night a jagged edge. My body stirred because of it.

*

About a half hour later, I got a call from Erin. An incoming call, over voice. Not a text. My first thoughts were paranoid ones. We rarely called one another these days, and only in emergencies. Had something happened?

I pressed *answer* on the phone tentatively. "Hello?"

"It's me," Erin whispered.

"Why are you whispering?"

She didn't answer, just kept on talking. "Aj's weirdly skittish about another video—or anything, really—so the best I can do is let you listen. Is that okay?"

It was more than just a rhetorical question. The question was heartfelt, one that implied that if I wasn't okay, then she'd come home rather than continue. It brought a smile to my lips.

"Hurry, he's coming back. What would you like me to do?"

"Stay. I'll listen."

Erin breathed a sigh of relief. "Make sure you mute your phone," she said.

Then nothing but the muffled sound of fabric against the hypersensitive speakers of her phone. Where was she putting me? In the pocket of her jacket? I couldn't remember if she'd brought a purse.

"*Very nice, baby.*" Aj's voice was clear over the phone, resonate and commanding.

I made sure that I was on mute, then put the conversation on speaker and settled back onto my bed. I stripped out of my boxers.

"*The collar looks good on you. How does it make you feel?*"

"*Submissive.*"

Aj chuckled. "*Come here. I'm going to put this on you.*"

I heard the clink of chain and furrowed my brow. Aj explained for me, a moment later. "*Every pet should stay on*

a leash, don't you think?"

"I'm your pet?" Erin managed to walk that fine line between sounding subservient and defiant, and I was pretty sure she did it to prompt a response from her lover.

"You are," Aj said. *"My slut."* The chain rattled. *"Now suck my cock, slut."*

In a way, being only able to hear made the moment that much more intense. I could actually hear the wet, gurgling sound of Erin taking Aj into her mouth. I turned her groan into a vivid, mental image—Aj standing at the side of the bed, holding my wife against his cock with a leash in his hand, Erin staring up at him with her bright, vivid green eyes.

"Yes, that's it, baby. You like that, don't you? You can use your hands. I won't be tying them up. Not yet, anyway..."

I listened. I'd never noticed how loud a blowjob could be. I'd either been too into the sensations of receiving one, or too busy watching her give one. But now, the squelches and muffled moans that escaped her throat roared in my ears and charged along my own cock.

"It's our last night together. Tell me what you want most," Aj said.

I heard Erin release him and catch her breath. *"I want this,"* she said.

"Where?" he demanded. *"Where do you want my cock?"*

"Everywhere," she said.

"Tell me. Be more specific."

Her answer wasn't immediate. I imagined her swiping her tongue along her length, and when she spoke, I heard a smile in her voice. *"In my mouth."*

"Of course," Aj chuckled.

"In my pussy."

I felt something move in my chest at how slutty Erin could be when she wanted to.

"In my ass."

"Of course you do, my anal queen. You love it back there, don't you?"

"Mmm hmm."

"Now suck my cock," AJ ordered.

I heard Erin gag. Heard the wet fap-fap-fap of AJ's pelvis thrusting into her throat, mixing with his groans, his hard breathing, the clink of her leash. I could feel the intensity of the moment build. I closed my eyes and saw Erin on her knees, staring up at this great, powerful man filled her throat. She was in control, despite the way it looked, and she knew it.

AJ knew it, too. *"Enough. Enough!"*

Erin's grunt cut down the line. My hand froze on my cock, my ears perking up as I tried to imagine what was going on.

"That's it, Erin. Bend over for AJ."

The spank came loud and clear. Then another.

"I'm going to miss this ass. It may be the finest I've ever seen."

Erin's breath caught, held, and a loud moan spilled forth.

"Tell me you're going to miss my cock."

Erin's voice was strained. *"I'm going to miss your cock."*

"What about it will you miss?"

"I'm going to miss feeling it inside of me."

"Fucking you?"

"Filling me so deep."

I listened to the sounds of sex, the harsh breathing, the moans, the curses. I listened and stroked along, wishing I could see, but so turned on that I could not. Erin came hard at one point. AJ didn't miss a beat, fucking her right through it.

"You want it here?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Say it."

"I want you in my ass."

"That's it, slut. Spread those cheeks for me. Open them up for for AJ ."

"Oh—yes!" Erin cried. *"Ohmygod—ohmyGOD!"*

"Fuck, you're tight," AJ announced, followed by a slap.

"So full," Erin said, straining, the rest of her words lost in a loud gasp.

"You good?" AJ asked with a grunt. *"You ready to get ass fucked?"*

"Oh, God!" Erin shouted.

"Ready?"

"Yes!"

"You feel ready," AJ said.

"Do it."

"Yeah?"

"Do it, AJ! Please!"

I swallowed, riveted on the phone with the scene building in my head.

What followed was chaos, Erin's screams distorting the little speakers. I could hear AJ's thrusts come fast and hard as he rode Erin's ass so much more aggressively than I could ever dream of. He rode her like the plaything that she was to him.

AJ said, *"This will be the last time you get it here for a while. Enjoy it."*

I smiled at the small victory. AJ still thought she was withholding that from me. He thought he was still the alpha.

In the background, I heard the faint strains of a hip hop beat going off.

"Not right now, buddy," AJ said. The music stopped abruptly. His phone going off, someone calling.

Erin laughed. *"For a second, I thought you were going to answer that."*

"Naw, babe. Not—"

The ringer went off again.

"Fuck!"

"Go ahead and answer it," Erin said. She wasn't pissed off. She also wasn't the wild version of her who went to AJ's to get fucked. She was the Erin I knew. The responsible one. *"I don't mind. I need some water, anyway."*

AJ grunted. *"Get me a glass, too."*

There was shuffling around, then the ringtone cut off.

"What's up, bro?"

Bro? I probably should have hung up, but I wasn't sure if Erin would be able to reestablish the connection.

"Hold up. Hold up. What's that now?"

This didn't sound good. The feeling of eavesdropping was real, and I felt slimy for it.

"I didn't give it to anyone. Just Erin and her husband. I swear."

I froze. What? What was he—

"I'll ask, but that video's not something that they'd just post—"

I bolted up out of the bed, jumping away from the phone like it had just revealed itself to be a live hand grenade. I stared, wondering if I was imagining what I was hearing. Had I fallen asleep?

"Chill, Lamar. Chill. We'll figure this out. Do you know who this prick is?"

Lamar. So the video that they were talking about must have been...

I felt bile rise in my chest. The gym video. The threesome. Erin's DP. I kept the vomit down, but could feel it pooling in my gut, acidic and painful.

"What's going on?" Erin's voice, returning.

Oh God. All those very male instincts to protect her kicked in. I started calculating how much time it would take to get over there, only to...to what?

"Who did you share the video with?" AJ had been more apologetic than I'd ever heard when he'd talked to the guy on the phone. When he spoke to Erin, it was all accusation.

"What?"

"The video. You, me, Lamar. What. Did. You. Do with it? Who did you show?"

"No one," Erin said defensively. "Just Tom."

"Don't lie to me."

"What the fuck, AJ? Why would I show that to anyone else?"

"I don't know. Because you're a whore."

My hands tightened into fists and I stared up at the ceiling. This sense of powerlessness was worse than watching Erin leave. In this moment, there was truly nothing I could do, and right then, I wanted to storm into AJ's apartment, guns blazing.

"I'm leaving," Erin said coldly.

"No."

"Fuck you!" she spat.

AJ roared, and for a scary second, I thought he might do something to Erin. Then: *"I'm sorry. Sorry."* He blew out a quick breath of air. *"Hey, Lamar, let me hit you back...uh, huh... Yeah, yeah..."*

There was a long pause. Erin spoke first. *"Our video was leaked to the Internet."*

She sounded calmer than I imagined she felt, but what she said had me panicking all over again. If that video was out, how would I explain it to my coworkers, my parents? Our fucking kids?

"No," AJ said. "Not yet. They want money for it."

"Blackmail?"

"That's what they usually call it," AJ said sarcastically. "Fifty grand."

"Damn," Erin and I said at the same time. "I swear, I didn't share it with anyone. Did you?"

"Just you and your husband."

"And Lamar?"

"Never even had a copy."

Erin was thoughtful for a moment. *"Does he know who's blackmailing him?"*

"Doesn't. And if he did, I'm sure he'd fuck them up."

"So what's he...what's he going to do?" Erin had done the calculation faster than me—that video was way more damning to the two of us than it was to Lamar. Had he just told the blackmailers to go fuck themselves?

"I don't know," AJ said.

"Okay." Erin took a deep breath. I could hear her own panic at the edges of that breath, but everything else about her had shifted to problem-solving mode. *"Okay, so first things first, we need to stop that video from getting out."*

"Out of our hands," AJ said. He sounded defeated in a way I hadn't heard from him before.

"We can help pay for it. Tom and I, I mean. But just because we pay doesn't mean that video doesn't show up somewhere. So..."

"So we need to know who has it," I said to myself.

AJ said the same thing, in his own way: *"We need to find these fuckers and come to an understanding that they need to shut the fuck up."*

Erin laughed. It was a nice sound, in the midst of all this stress. *"You only sent it to me,"* Erin said.

"And your husband," AJ said.

"Right." I imagined her pinching the bridge of her nose in thought. *"I'm going to go home. I need some space to think."*

I heard them kiss and was reminded of what they'd just been in the middle of. My gut twisted despite everything. *"Tell Lamar that we can help pay. Okay?"*

"I'll take care of it."

"Hey, it's going to be okay, AJ." I heard more sentiment in her voice than ever before for her trainer.

"I think I may have lost my job."

"Did he fire you?"

"Not yet."

"Then let's deal with that if and when it comes up."

We. I winced. I knew she was just being supportive, but there was something about people growing closer in crisis. Whatever, there were bigger problems to deal with, like the one at hand. We'd all deal with whatever came next, when it came next.

I heard them kiss again, slow and wet.

"Stay a little longer," Aj whispered.

Erin laughed. *"Seriously? Even with the drama?"*

"I never got off. You're really going to leave me with a case of blue balls?"

"There's always your hand, baby. Now I've got to go. And Aj, find out how this guy wants to be paid. I'll get the money together."

The muffled sound of close passing over the speaker filled the phone. Then a pause. Had Erin forgotten about her phone? Then the line went dead. She was coming home.

OceanofPDF.com

NINE

When Erin showed back up at the front door, she was wide-eyed. Any panic she'd been holding inside started to unravel by the time she made her way to our house.

"You heard?" she asked.

"Yeah." I pressed my lips together, unsure what else to say. Then I came up with it: "Fuck."

She looked tiny, standing there in just her coat—even in her heels. Before I could hug her, though, she said, "You didn't send it to anyone, did you?"

It was like a slap—especially because when I looked her in her eyes, she was serious. I crossed my outstretched arms. "How could you even ask that?" I demanded.

Erin looked towards the stairs. The kids. Keep it down. I shut my eyes and repeated my question a decibel lower. "How could you even ask that?"

She looked tired. "I don't know. I'm sorry. I'm just trying to figure out how this happened." Her jaw set and the tiredness fell away, leaving behind anger. She hammered a fist into her palm. "*So stupid.*"

Now I folded my arms around her, brushing my hand over her hair until she stopped shaking with rage. My instinct was to reassure her, to tell her that it was all going to be okay. But I felt the same despair that she did, the same sensation that our happy existence was over, and it was all our fault.

"Do you still have the video?" she asked.

"Of course."

"Let's erase it. It won't undo the damage, but at least...at least it'll prevent the chance of it happening again." *If we are able to make it through this ordeal unscathed*, she didn't need to add.

So we went up to my computer, and with a heavy heart, we found the video—and all the photos that I'd been saving of her and AJ (and Jo), and deleted them. We checked our phones, too, erasing all digital evidence of what we'd done. It was like saying goodbye to an old friend, yet when it was done, I felt—

“Relieved,” Erin said. “Is that weird?”

“No, I'm feeling it, too. Like we just poured the last of the booze down the drain.”

Erin's laugh was half a sob. “That's what we are, isn't it? Sexaholics or something.”

I wanted to deny it, but she was more right than I cared to admit. She'd begun to crave more and more extreme things, and I'd been more than complicit letting her have them. She'd fucked two guys at once—and that was *after* she'd fooled around with my nemesis. Hell, even tonight, I didn't bat a lash when she'd gone to meet him wearing nothing but a collar. What came next? Where was this leading?

“So any thoughts on how to catch this asshole?” I asked.

Erin shook her head. “Too early to make many plans. We need to know more about how the guy—or group...” She trailed off, thinking of how terrifying that prospect was, then shook her head quickly to get back on track. “Depends on how they want to get paid. Maybe they'll make a mistake.”

“And if they don't?”

“Like I said to AJ, we'll deal with that if we have to.”

I nodded. It was really the *only* thing we could do. Right now, the whole situation was out of our hands. We drifted like ghosts into the bedroom. Erin, I realized, still had her coat on.

“Did you have fun tonight?” I asked. “Before...you know.”

Erin didn't look energized. Not like she had in the past, when thinking about her AJ encounters. But she nodded. “I did. It was fun.”

“But?” I asked.

She fell into my arms again. “Right now, I need to make love to someone. Not get fucked.”

I pushed her coat from her shoulders. My breath caught at the sight of her nudity. Her nipples weren’t hard, but they weren’t completely soft, either, and her pussy still glistened. From earlier? From now?

I reached behind her neck and unclasped the collar.

“Free at last,” she said.

“There’s probably something symbolic here,” I said.

“Probably,” Erin said, nodding. “But my brain’s no longer working with those higher functions.”

I kissed her, and it felt like kissing her for the first time in so long. When we made love, we *made love*. This wasn’t reclamation sex. This wasn’t hard and fast. This was me and my wife finding one another for the first time, away from all the noise.

And it’s everything that we stood to lose, if things went south.

*

When we woke the next day, our every day was still there, demanding to be attended to. Work was a distraction, but the children were a reminder that we *needed* to figure something out. They were young enough that they’d not really know what was going on, but one day they would. The Internet made everything eternal.

There was the money aspect, too. Fifty grand was a hell of a lot of money, even with the nest egg we’d been building since my promotion. But it wasn’t just that. If they wanted fifty thousand dollars in cash, how hard would it be to make that happen? It’s not like I could just walk into a bank with a check.

On the other hand, if this operation was more sophisticated and the blackmailer wanted a money transfer to another account, I wasn’t sure how I could possibly trace

that. Not that it was impossible, surely. We'd have a number. Just...a lot harder.

I had to resist the urge to call AJ myself. I knew it would give me no more control over this situation than I already had—which was practically zero—but I felt like I needed to do something. And that was something. I didn't, though. AJ may have known about me through Erin—known that her husband knew about their trysts. Hell, he'd even mentioned that he'd given *us* the video a couple times.

To look him in the face and ask what he knew about this situation would have brought comfort. But there were so many risks and we had already acted so recklessly.

Erin called me later that day. Called, I noted, not texted. We were getting paranoid. We didn't want to leave any more digital footprints. "The guy wants cash. In two weeks. Unmarked bills."

"Okay," I said. Two weeks was going to be tough.

"AJ said that Lamar will pay half. Probably would have paid in full," she said. "He's got a reputation, and sponsors, and is afraid of losing those."

Right. For one, brief moment, I wondered if Lamar was setting us up. Was he really the blackmailer, and this was a way of getting fifty grand out of a couple white suburbanites? I hated that I went there—it felt wrong and racist and shameful. But—

"You don't think this is Lamar, do you?" I blurted.

Erin was quiet long enough that I knew she'd considered the possibility already. "No, I don't. Could be, but he's never had a copy of it."

"He could be bluffing," I said.

"So we call him on the bluff, then what? He wouldn't post that video. It's not only got him all over it, but he's the reason it's so scandalous."

"Don't sell yourself short, Erin. You put on quite a performance."

I could practically hear the tension break on the other end of the phone. “Anyway, this blackmailer sent a clip of the video to Lamar. Lamar showed it to AJ. Only way that could have happened was if this guy had a copy. Thus, it couldn’t be Lamar.” She really had followed that thread.

“Maybe AJ’s the one playing us,” I suggested.

Erin burst out laughing. “Are we talking about the same man? You’re giving him way too much credit.”

She was right, the idea was ridiculous. Still, I said, “Maybe this was some kind of long con. He’s been playing you from the beginning.”

“Seems like a lot of effort to go through.”

“Well, money’s not the only perk he got from it,” I said. I wasn’t sure how to feel when my cock reacted to that suggestion, so I tried to ignore it.

“It’s not AJ,” Erin said softly. “Trust me.”

Because *she* trusted him. That bothered me, but I let it go. “Okay,” I said. “He give a location?”

“Some park in the city. Tucked under a bench in a duffel bag.”

I tried to visualize fifty thousand dollars in bills. I didn’t even know how large a duffel I’d need to buy.

“Okay.” I sighed. “It’ll take some time to liquidate our portion, but I was looking into our savings. We’ve got it.”

It hurt, for sure, losing that much money. I kept vacillating between being sad about its loss and angry that this was happening—angry that someone would do something that could ruin our lives, angry that we’d put ourselves in this position.

“I’ll keep you posted if I get more details.”

We got no more details after that, but that was fine. We had enough to focus on—least of which was getting all the money. We had ourselves to focus on and our lives to live. Suddenly, family dinners tasted so much better, and reading books to the kids at bedtime would practically bring us to

tears. It felt like we were on borrowed time, and I hated that feeling.

I also couldn't shake my paranoia. What Erin had said made sense. The chances that Lamar Williamson was conning us were slim. I looked him up, and unlike most Olympic athletes, who had regular jobs and made next to nothing, Lamar had a number of high profile sponsors and was worth a lot. He was closer to a Michael Phelps or a Lindsey Vonn than the athlete who worked at Home Depot most of the time.

So that left AJ, who very well could be blackmailing his client for some extra cash. Erin was right about one thing: the guy wasn't smart enough to mastermind the long con required for something like this, but as I thought about it, it occurred to me that maybe it wasn't so elaborate. Maybe he was just an opportunist. The threesome happened, Erin asked AJ to record it, and suddenly AJ had something incriminating to make a quick buck with.

Still felt implausible, though. AJ was a meathead who let his cock do the thinking. He just didn't seem like the type to do something like this.

Or maybe I was being naive.

Or maybe it was Erin and AJ together.

I hated that theory, and wanted to forget I even had it as soon as I did. I wanted to smother it because it was so wrong. Erin and I had been together over a decade. We had a life together. We had the kids. For her to give all of that up for a quick fix of cash didn't make sense.

Still, all of the suspicion ate away at me. I didn't know who to trust, so I trusted no one. I shut down, focusing on the problem of getting enough cash to pay the blackmailer off, whoever he, she, or they were.

AJ remained in town those long two weeks, although I'm pretty sure that Erin didn't meet up with him. She said she didn't, but then again, in the past, she'd met up with him when the kids were in school and—

No, I couldn't go there. Not after all that we'd been through. Back then, she'd teased me about her hookups after the fact. Now, all she talked about was scheming to find out who the blackmailer was.

"I checked out that park. The drop site," she said one evening after the kids were down. "It's behind the World War II Memorial, near the Tidal Basin."

"How very Washington espionage," I said. "This guy's watched too many movies."

"I took some pics. Here, look."

She pulled out her phone and brought up her photos.

The park, despite being in the city, was wooded. A gravel path cut through the trees, too bare in the winter to hide behind, before opening up to the large pool of water. Across the way was the Jefferson Memorial, and in a month, the whole area would be an explosion of cherry blossoms and tourists.

"The drop off time is ten at night, so it'll be too obvious if we just happened to be there, but—"

I interrupted. "Wait a second, what are you talking about?"

"We're going to be there. We need to see who picks it up."

"No way. Too dangerous. What if this guy has a gun or something?"

Erin shook her head. "We're not going to confront him. Just follow him."

I raised my brows. Maybe it was Erin who'd watched too many movies about this sort of thing. "So you've got experience tailing guys?"

Erin sighed with exasperation. "No, but we can't just let this happen. This may be our only chance."

"Did you tell AJ about this?" I asked.

The question raised her brows. "Not yet. Why?"

"I don't think we should."

"Why not, Tom?"

I knew I was walking a thin line. We'd both been on edge for far too long. We were both ready to explode. I needed to proceed carefully here.

I said, "Lamar just wants to pay and get this over with. I'm not sure that he'd be okay with the cloak and dagger stuff. And besides, I know that it's improbable, but what if he's somehow involved? It's better that he doesn't know that we suspect, and catch him making a mistake."

Or catch AJ making a mistake, I didn't add.

Erin narrowed her eyes as she studied me. She knew that there was something that I hadn't said. I groaned. Might as well say it all.

"And we still don't know that it's not AJ, either. If we make this drop, and he knows that we're watching, he won't come. Or he'll send someone else or something. But if he thinks we're just going to pay and hope it all goes away, he'll come along and we'll catch him."

Erin pursed her lips, and absurdly I thought how beautiful she was when she looked mad, even as I readied myself for her to defend him—and get angry because she was defending him. But she didn't. She sighed and nodded.

"You're right. I hadn't thought of that." She looked at the ceiling and blew out some air. When she looked back at me, there was moisture building around her eyes. "I don't know who to trust."

"You can trust me," I said. I pulled her close.

"I know. I do." She hugged me tightly. I felt like an asshole and a hypocrite and vowed to stop being both.

"I should be the one to watch the bag," I said. "Alone. This guy would recognize you, since you're kind of the star in that movie." Erin chuckled at that against my chest. I added, "I'm just a guy, out for an evening stroll."

I could feel Erin work through it in her silence.

"Besides, I've got a lot more practice watching from the shadows."

This time, Erin's laughter was heartier. "Okay, you're right. But it's still suspicious if you just happen to walk by when he's making the pickup. So here's what I'm thinking..."

*

Lamar Williamson flew out to Washington to drop off the duffel bag. We'd considered doing that ourselves, but the chances of the blackmailer watching the location were too high. As far as they knew, Lamar hadn't shared the information with anyone.

The day before, I'd planted the same GoPro that had been used in that video into the woods behind the bench. The irony wasn't lost on me. I placed it high, and surrounded it by grass to make it look like a bird nest. I'd be able to activate it remotely when it was needed.

I'd also added a little GPS tracking chip to the duffel bag, sewn into the liner and tiny enough that it shouldn't have been detected.

I told no one about these two things—including Erin. It was a risky thing—if the blackmailer found either the camera or the GPS chip, the video would be on the Internet in record time. I told myself that I kept it a secret because I didn't want Erin to talk me out of it. I trusted her, after all, even with the little doubts, but even still...

Of all the things that had happened, that was the most tragic: the erosion of trust. We'd been through so much. We'd worked through Lucas Hughes and AJ and had finally found our center when this went down. How quickly it could all fall apart. When this was over—if we could get through it—we had a lot to talk about.

But right now, the sting.

The Tidal Basin at night in mid-March was dead. I'd briefly considered posing as a late night jogger, but tossed that out when I realized that no one did that. The benches

all around the Tidal Basin were so exposed that I couldn't just happen to be sitting on one at the time, either. People didn't do that, either, not even the homeless. It was just too cold.

My saving grace: the Jefferson monument itself, and the fact that it was open 24-hours a day. The white columned building itself was lit up at night like a lantern, but that meant I could hide in the darkness off to the side. Anyone looking in my direction would be blinded by the monument and wouldn't see the telephoto lens I had pointed at the bench.

"You're sure you don't want me there?" Erin asked for the tenth time.

"It's better this way. In case I miss him, I need you there to try and ID him on the way out. Okay?"

Erin shivered. Like me, she'd dressed up in all black—black turtleneck, tight black leggings, little black beanie hat. She looked like a cute little spy. "Is it wrong that this is exciting?"

"Kind of," I said, then grinned. "But I know what you mean. Now let's do this thing."

We kissed and I got out of the car. She'd dropped me on the far side of the Mall and I had a long walk to get to where I needed to go, but the walk was good. The cold air cleared my head.

Why was I being so suspicious? Why did I keep looking over my shoulder and second guessing all of my relationships? The answer I kept coming back to was another question: how had the video leaked at all? I'd certainly not shared it with anyone. Only two other people had copies of it: Erin and AJ.

Then again, AJ's email could have been hacked. Or Erin's. Or mine. Or if he'd saved it to his phone, maybe his phone was hacked. If it could happen to dozens of celebrities, then it certainly could happen to a bro from New Jersey.

The night was warmer than it had been recently, and to my surprise, there were a few couples meandering around the monument, snuggling close. Well, that was inconvenient. I couldn't just jump into the shadows in front of them—not if I wanted to stay out of jail.

“Evening,” I said, nodding at a couple as they strolled past. I wondered how I looked to them, dressed all in black. At least I didn't earn any strange looks.

Checking my watch, it was just past 9:30. I still had time to get into position. I ascended the stairs, weaving in and out of the tall, white columns as I did my best to look like a tourist.

Now that we were here, I wondered what came next. We'd ID this guy, and then...what? Follow him home, threaten him until he erased the files? We had no leverage. We had no power, even if we knew who he was.

I glanced over at the bench, where he'd be showing up in fifteen minutes and—

I saw a man—a jogger—skirting the Tidal Basin. He was small from where I stood, but I could make out his muscular build. He wore jogging pants and a gray hoodie, pulled up over his head, obscuring his face in shadow.

My heart skipped a beat. Was this him? Was he early?

I did a quick look around. One other couple had just arrived, but they were busy making out against the Jefferson memorial. The jogger wasn't looking my way. Not yet. Quickly, I descended the stairs on the left side of the monument. There wouldn't be time to get into the bushes or trees. There was barely enough time to get my camera out. I had to count on distance at the brightness of the monument to hide me.

Glancing one last time up to the other couple, I prayed that they didn't come down these stairs as I lifted the telephoto lens in the direction of the bench. The man had stopped. This was it. This was him.

Under the power of the lens, even in the dark, I could make out more details. He was indeed a fit man, broad across the shoulders without being overweight. My stomach twisted. He had the build of AJ.

I snapped a couple shots of the man kneeling down and pulling out the duffel bag. He opened it and rifled through the contents. When he rose, I could read the satisfaction in his body language. He clapped, laughing.

Turn this way, you bastard. Look at me.

Instead, he kept his head down and his hoodie drawn low. He shouldered the bag, and for a second, I thought we'd missed it. Despite the elaborate setup, he was going to get away before we could ID him. And then, just as he set into his jog, he turned and looked across the Tidal Basin.

I nearly dropped the camera when I saw his face.

Instead, I hammered down on the shutter, the click-click sounding like a gunshot. I followed him with my lens, taking shots as he trotted away.

When he was gone, I went back and checked the images. I needed to make sure my brain wasn't playing tricks on me. My heart was beating so fast I worried it might burst. I felt hot. I fumbled with the camera's controls, but when I brought the image up, it confirmed what I'd seen. The blackmailer was Lucas Hughes.

OceanofPDF.com

TEN

I stood there by the monument long after he'd disappeared from sight. The night breeze swept across the basin, rippling the reflection of the lamps in the dark water. I didn't see it. Didn't feel the wind. Woodenly, I let the camera fall against my hip and picked my way around the pool.

This just didn't seem real. Lucas fucking Hughes, our neighbor, was the guy blackmailing us? If a television crew rose up out of the still water of the basin and told me that I was on television, I would have believed it.

But I wasn't on a television show, so it was time to review the facts.

Lucas Hughes was one of three men who fucked my wife since we started playing—and the *only* man not in that video. Lucas had clearly gotten a copy of the video somehow. So back to that question: how?

A frightening picture began to resolve itself as I reached the hidden GoPro. Erin had fucked Lucas as a way to tease me and make me jealous, and as it had unfolded, I'd done nothing to discourage it. So she'd maintained. It had been a series of small mistakes that culminated in my first—and hopefully last—cuckolding experience.

But what if Erin and Lucas were fucking all along?

That thought hit me like a pile of bricks. I actually did drop the GoPro. It clattered in its plastic housing, coming to lay still on the ground. I stared at it without seeing it. I stared as my world crumbled around me.

If she was cheating on me—if she had been cheating on me all this time—this was over. All of it. I couldn't even feel sad for myself. I felt angry enough that I kicked the GoPro, hearing it crunch against my boot.

A memory returned to me from last year. Jo had just met Lucas at the Labor Day barbecue. *You better watch out for*

that guy. Had she known then?

Before I could stop or consider what I was doing, I pulled out my phone and navigated through my contacts. It rang. I waited. My heartbeat rattled against my chest. I looked out over the water, back to the Jefferson monument like I was staring at some kind of fucking postcard. It had no right to look that peaceful—

“Tom?”

“Hey, Jo.”

“Why are you calling me so late?” she said, her voice filled with suspicion. “Is everything alright?”

My chest constricted so suddenly that I grunted. I closed my eyes and willed the emotion out of my voice. “Just wondering something. Trying to settle something. I mean, I needed to know...” Stop mumbling. “Do you remember when you visited last Labor Day, and we went over to the Hughes’ house for a barbecue?”

“Yes,” she said slowly.

“Was that the first time you’d met Lucas?”

“It was.”

Doubt crept in. How could I have gone to this place so quickly?

Jo cleared her throat. “What’s going on, Tom? Why do you want...” As she trailed off, I could practically hear her mind putting it all together.

I tried distracting her before I did. “I’m just trying to figure something out.”

“Wait. Oh, my god. You think they’re having an affair?”

My world slipped sideways at her question. Affair. Affair. Such a dirty, dirty word.

Jo went on before my mind could settle. “They haven’t. She wouldn’t. I was actually shocked when she said that you guys had done that with him. You know I don’t like that man.”

I did. And I believed her. Or I wanted to. Or I did. Fuck.

“Thanks, Jo. We definitely should have listened to you.”

“What’s going on, Tom? Why did you call me? What happened?”

I looked around again, wondering how to explain all of this. “I’ll tell you when I know more. I promise.”

“I’m just going to call Erin, you know.”

She was, and there wasn’t much I could do about that. “I know, but...give me tonight, okay? Call tomorrow.”

Jo was silent for a long, pregnant moment. “Fine. Tonight. But I’m mad at you. I don’t like being left in the dark.”

“I know.”

“And if I need to fly out there to kick your ass, I’ve got four weeks of leave, so you better be ready for it.”

I couldn’t help but laugh. That felt good. “I have no doubt. Night, Jo.”

She hung up on me.

I picked up the pieces of the shattered video camera and stuffed them into my bag. Then, I called Erin.

“You get it?” she asked without even a hello. Was she nervous? Anxious that I’d discovered something I shouldn’t have? Or just nervous because this whole damn thing was nerve-racking?

“I did. Pick me up and I’ll tell you.”

I needed to see her face when I did. I needed to see her reaction.

“I’ll pick you up at the World War II memorial’s parking lot.”

*

I slid into the car, feeling like a black ops agent, dSLR slung at my side like an automatic weapon. As soon as the door pulled shut, Erin peeled out of the lot, tires squealing. She must have been feeling it, too.

“So you got the guy on camera?” she said.

Her dark hair flowed out around her black knit hat and down around her shoulders. I watched her face, paying attention to the muscles around her mouth, her jaw, her eyebrows. She would ask who it was, I'd tell her it was Lucas, and she'd react...somehow.

"I did. Pretty clear shot of his face."

Erin kept her eyes on the road, turning out onto Constitution Avenue. "So it was a he?"

"It was." I watched. Waiting for her to say, *And who was he?*

Only that obvious question never came.

Instead, she released a sigh. "Well, now what? We have a face, but how do we come up with a name?" Her jaw set. "We should have followed him."

I blinked, confused. This didn't make sense unless... unless she didn't actually know who he was. A great weight left my shoulders. She didn't know. *She didn't know.*

"We don't need to ID him. I recognized him."

We stopped at a light. Erin turned to me, eyes wide with surprise—genuine surprise. "You did?"

I nodded slowly, held her gaze, said, "It was our friend Lucas."

Erin stared at me, unblinking, like she'd been hit between the eyes. She didn't look away. Her mouth didn't tighten and her brow didn't furrow. She just looked...stunned. The kind of stunned that couldn't be faked. Then her eyes began to move, shifting rapidly as though reading something in the air between us.

A car honked. She ignored it, but it snapped her out of her trance. "I don't understand. How?"

"Did you show the video to Haley?" I hadn't even considered the possibility until I said it outloud, but it seemed possible.

"No, Tom, I didn't show it to anyone. I swear."

The car behind us accelerated around us, holding his horn down the whole time. I don't think either of us really

heard it, and thankfully no one else was behind.

"And you..." How could I even ask this? What felt so plausible a few minutes ago made me cringe with shame now.

"What?" Erin asked. "What is it, Tom?"

"You and Lucas never..."

Erin's eyes went wide and her brow fell, surprised and angry all at once. "Never what?" she said sharply.

I groaned, but finished my thought. "Never had a thing, did you?"

"A thing? You mean like a fling? An affair? Are you asking if I cheated on you? Because you know the answer to that, and it's no. Never. And...and..." She growled, found the accelerator, and gunned it.

I didn't say a thing until we were on the bridge, crossing back into Virginia. "I'm sorry, I know you didn't."

"But you asked," she said, sounding calmer now. "You *had* to ask."

"I'm still shocked by the Lucas thing."

Erin shook her head. "But that's immediately where you went. You saw him and..." She searched the air again, putting it together. "You saw him and thought we were in this together? Tell me that's not where you went."

My face burned, but I wasn't going to lie. We needed hard honesty right now. "For a second, yeah."

She didn't yell. She did worse. Her face fell, and despair filled the quiet darkness of the car. I thought about apologizing, but for what? For speaking the truth? For the way my damaged psyche thought?

"So many mistakes," she whispered.

A hole had opened up and threatened to swallow us. We were already sinking deep into it. I placed a hand on Erin's thigh and squeezed softly. "So we know it's Lucas Hughes. What next?"

"We go to his house and beat the shit out of him?" she said, laughing darkly. The car began to accelerate before

she realized what she was doing. "I don't know, that's where my mind keeps going."

"Do you think he knows that we know?" I asked.

Erin shook her head slowly, more of an *I don't know* than a definitive *no*. "How did he get the video, anyway?"

"Aj, right? Has to be."

"But Aj swears he didn't give it to anyone else."

"And you believe him?"

"Yes!" Erin said brightly. "You don't..." She trailed off.

"Don't know him like you do?"

Erin sighed. "He wouldn't do this. And it's not just because he's not smart enough to put it together. He just...wouldn't."

"Is he in love with you?"

Erin flattened her lips and glanced at me. "Not everything's so black and white, Tom. No, I don't think he *loves* me. Not the way you love me. But I think he *cares* about me. And I don't think he'd do something like this."

"One way to find out for sure," I said.

"How?"

"Well, if Aj is working with Lucas, then he'd know who I was, right?" Cold fear washed through me at this realization. I groaned, thinking about all the times I'd met with Aj as *Tommy*. "Jesus, think he's known all along? Every time I 'ran into him' at the bar. Every time we got together for personal training?"

"And if Lucas and Aj are working together, then Lucas would know that we put up part of the money. Think he'd dig for more?"

He could hold that over our heads forever. But he hadn't blackmailed us. He'd blackmailed the celebrity athlete instead. "I think he's smarter than that. He doesn't want this getting back to him. Otherwise, he would have gone after us, right?"

"Okay, I'm back to thinking that we beat the shit out of him," she said.

“How ladylike of you. How about we figure out a way to make sure he never shares that video?”

“How?” asked Erin.

“Still working on that. We need some kind of leverage. And we need to know who else knows.”

Erin gasped. “You think...you think Haley does?” She covered her mouth. “No, she couldn’t.”

I sucked air in through my teeth. I didn’t want to believe the sweet blonde was capable of such deceit, either, but in a way, it made sense. “Maybe not,” I said, unconvincingly.

Erin groaned. She reached down and took my hand, squeezing it. “One thing at a time, right?”

When we got home, the house was quiet. We paid the babysitter, both of us relieved that we hadn’t used Lucas’s daughter, Paige. When she was gone, Erin announced that she was going to have a bath.

“I just need to soak and let my mind process this.”

I understood. I kissed her, squeezed her hand, and watched her ascend the stairs.

Looking around the house, I wondered if we’d lose it all. Or at the very least, we’d have to sell and move somewhere else. I could probably get another job in commercial real estate with my resume—that sector cared more about profits than scandals. Maybe on the West Coast. It wouldn’t be so bad, starting over. We’d leave our extended families behind, which would be hard, but we had a few friends out there.

I ended up in the kitchen, pulling a bottle of wine down, along with two glasses. I could close my eyes and hear Erin’s laughter fill this space, a ghost of a happier time.

I filled the glasses and set them on the island counter, and another memory stirred—walking in on Lucas and Erin sharing a glass while I was out of town. This time, I wasn’t filled with suspicion or dread. I was filled with anger. Leaving what we had would be admitting defeat to Lucas Hughes, and there was no way in hell that I’d do that.

I remembered the GPS tracker I'd placed in the bag. If Lucas were smart, or careful, he would have transferred the money to another bag and dumped our duffel in a dumpster. I expected that. But when I booted up the tracker app, I was surprised to see it moving steadily out the highway into Virginia. Curious, I set the phone on the countertop and watched the little blip move, sipping my wine.

It pulled into some kind of industrial complex, stopped for a moment, and then moved slowly into one of the buildings, where it stopped moving for good.

"Huh." I marked the address on a piece of paper, shut my phone off, and headed upstairs with Erin's glass of wine.

She was lost in the bubbles that filled the bath, her head tipped back against the lip, her eyes closed. She didn't open them when I entered, but she stirred.

"Wine?" I asked, setting her glass down and taking a seat on the floor beside her.

She opened her eyes at last. She looked less harried. "I was just thinking that I could use this very thing." Her hand slipped from the water, wrist trailing bubbles, and picked up the glass. "To new experiences."

It was so cynically optimistic that I couldn't help but laugh and clink my glass against hers.

"So you think that's the end of it?" I said. "Now that he got paid?"

Erin swallowed deeply at her wine. "I don't know. The man is full of surprises."

"Think we should start looking at houses in other cities?"

Erin's laugh was somehow both bitter and comforting. "I thought about that. A lot. Even before we knew what wonderful neighbors we have. But that's not going to work. The Internet means that we can't escape it. Not with distance. And besides, Lamar is a celebrity, which means I'll probably get my fifteen minutes if it ever got out."

"Lucky you."

Erin disappeared beneath the water for a moment. When she reemerged, she was smiling again. "Running isn't going to work. We could ignore it and hope it passes..."

"But?" I asked, hearing the word.

"You were right, we need to burn him."

The way that she looked at me out of the corner of her eye made me wonder if she meant that literally, although I was pretty sure she wasn't.

I cleared my throat. "I think I said that we need to make sure that he doesn't share the video."

"And we do that by burning him."

I laughed. This was a vindictive side of Erin that I hadn't seen before. It was oddly sexy.

She went on before I could analyze that thought. "But first, we need to figure out who was in on it."

"Haley?"

Erin nodded, looking tired. "And AJ." She held up her hand. "I know, I know. I still don't think he has a clue what's going on, but we should make sure."

It was a greater relief to hear her say that than I would have thought. It felt like coming home after a long road trip. "You have an idea, I take it?"

Erin nodded. "I'll call him tomorrow. Ask him to meet me at Callahan's so we can talk about things. Now that, you know, we paid and all that."

Despite everything that we'd been through, and how wrong it was, I felt things stir in my pants. I sucked my lips in between my teeth and held my tongue.

"You go ahead of me. Run into him as 'Tommy.' If AJ is in on the blackmail, then he knows who Lucas is, and he'd know who you were."

That could work. I said, "If he's not, then he'll just assume it's some kind of coincidence that I'm there."

"Right, although...we need to tell him the truth."

I hated the idea, and I hated the reason why I hated it—I was afraid. AJ didn't seem like the kind of guy who took

deception kindly. The man had too much pride for it. But she was right. There was already too much deceit going around. It was time to make things right.

"If he's not involved, he's not going to be happy," I said. "With either of us."

Erin nodded. "I know."

"You may have to help him get over it," I said.

It was meant to be a joke, but regardless, things...tightened for me. In my chest. In my boxers. With the whirlwind of the last few weeks, I'd nearly forgotten about the fantasy at the heart of it all, and at least a part of me figured it was over—if not satisfied, then at least frightened away. Apparently it was more resilient than that.

But first, I needed to get one last thing off my chest.

"You know what I hate most about what's happened?" I said. "I hate that this has challenged the trust between us."

When I refocused on Erin, she was looking up at me curiously, still buried in the bubbles. A strand of wet, dark hair ran down the side of her face and along her jaw. The moment felt as fragile as the beads of water that balanced on her lashes, ready to drop.

"You trust me now?"

"I do. And I always should have."

"But for a moment, you didn't. Do you now?" She repeated.

I forced myself to consider it, not just answer blindly, and when I did, my answer was the same. "I do, yes."

"Then maybe that's a pleasant side effect to this whole mess."

I stared down at her, she up at me. A smile curled on her lips. We could go around and around in circles all night, but right now, we needed something else. I leaned down and kissed her. Her lips were hot to the touch. I braced my hand on the edge of the tub, but she wrapped her fingers around my neck and pulled. I slipped into the water, clothes and everything.

I didn't care. Didn't even think about it as I sought out her mouth and ran my hands along her body.

"You're naked in here," I said.

Erin laughed. "That's usually how I take my baths."

"I learn new things about you every day."

We kissed again. She peeled my soaking, black shirt off and tossed it wetly on the floor.

"I'm sorry I ever doubted you," I said.

"Looks like I still have to work to do on my New Year's resolution."

"Sounds like fun. Can I help?"

OceanofPDF.com

ELEVEN

"No, you don't need to... uh, huh... I know... Seriously, Jo, we're dealing with things just fine... Yes, just fine... Ugh! Fine... I love you, too."

Erin walked into the kitchen, where the kids and I were eating breakfast, the tail end of her phone conversation equal parts fondness and sarcasm.

"Bye now. See you soon." She hung up and glared at me. "Everyone, Auntie Jo's coming to visit!"

The children cheered.

"You can thank your father for freaking her out."

Mary said, "Dank you, daddy!"

"What's 'freaking out' mean?" Martin asked.

"It means that she's worried," I said.

He pressed like the five-year-old that he was. "Why is she worried?"

"Because that's what Auntie Jo does," Erin said before I could put my foot further in my mouth.

"When's she coming?" I asked.

"Today. She booked a flight while we were still talking."

I laughed. "That sounds about right."

Erin rolled her eyes. "Oatmeal's ready!"

Later that morning, Erin cornered me alone as the kids were watching cartoons. "You know why she's coming, right?"

I thought about my conversation with Jo last night—had that only been last night? "Because she's concerned about our welfare?"

"That's part of it."

I'd accused her of cheating on me, and brought the suspicion up with Jo. Jo wasn't good at butting out of things, especially when those things involved her best friends.

"She's coming to kick my ass," I said.

Erin cracked. She laughed. "That's also part of it."

"I'm sorry I called her. I wasn't thinking straight and I..."
I didn't want to finish that statement. Erin did for me.

"Had to know if I was cheating on you." She finished with her lips pressed into a tight, crooked line.

I winced, but had no defense other than what I'd said before—I wasn't thinking straight.

"Anyway, it's a good thing that Jo's coming tonight. Now we don't have to worry about a babysitter."

"A babysitter?"

"Tonight, we're going to come clean with AJ."

*

I hated this idea.

But I didn't, because it made so much sense.

But I really did hate it.

This early on a Saturday, Callahan's was filled with the dinner crowd, and the bar itself was nearly empty. Nearly, but not quite. Sitting on a stool on the corner, his broad back to the door, was the man I'd come to meet. The urge to turn around and leave was almost impossible to resist.

All it took not to was the thought of Lucas Hughes getting away with all of our money, and I squared my shoulders and walked in.

The bartender, who was chatting with AJ in a friendly manner, looked up as I approached. "Hey, can I get you anything?"

"Guinness please," I said. A wave of *déjà vu* rolled through me. For an instant, it was last year and I was about to pretend to be Tommy for the first time. Now, this would be my last.

AJ turned at the sound of my voice. My heart lodged itself into my throat as I watched him. This was the moment of truth. Everything balanced on his reaction, and my reading of it.

"Tommy?" he said when he saw me. "Fuck, it *is* you, man. Long fucking time."

His smile, as broad and toothy as an alligator's, looked genuine. This really did look like a man who hadn't seen an old acquaintance in a "long fucking time." He stood, and for a moment, I thought he might hug me. Instead, we clasped hands, half high-five, half handshake. He turned to the bartender. "Max, I want you to meet an old client. Tommy."

"Nice to meet you," the bartender said. He set a pint of Guinness on the bar in front of me, then backed away. "I'll leave you two to catch up. It was good seeing you, AJ."

"Tell Katie I said hi," AJ replied.

"Already texted her."

Max moved down to the other side of the bar, making himself busy even though there were no other patrons to serve. AJ turned to me, and I felt my heart constrict.

You're a lying sack of shit, I imagined him saying. Or maybe I was thinking that about AJ. Or maybe I was thinking that about myself.

Instead, AJ said, "You've been doing those routines I showed you?"

"Have."

AJ assessed me quickly—not in a sexual way, but the way a jockey might evaluate a new horse. "You have. I can see it in your shoulders."

"Thanks." This was not the conversation I thought I was going to have when walking in here. This man, clearly, had no clue who I was.

And there was zero chance he was involved in any kind of schemes. AJ was, as always, refreshingly himself. He demonstrated that when he gestured to the bartender with his chin. "That guy is married to one of the hottest women I've ever met."

"Yeah?"

AJ nodded. "She's this stacked redhead. Smarter than hell—has her own accounting firm or some shit—but bro,

she's totally wild in bed."

I gawked. Did he just say that he fucked the bartender's wife? It made some perverse sense, although the bartender didn't seem particularly bothered by AJ's presence. When I'd walked in, they seemed friendly. "How do you know?"

AJ grinned, but said no more on it. "You know what's strange? I'm from New Jersey, right, and I lived in New York for years, but whenever I come back here, to DC...it feels like home."

"Because of the stacked redhead?" I asked.

"Naw. That's long over. And besides, I'm not just talking about pussy. I'm talking about this bar. Max. You."

Guilt stabbed through me. He really had no clue.

"And pussy, yeah. I ever tell you about Jana? MILFy blonde, always up for a good time."

I shook my head, already feeling myself slip back into Tommy. I mapped out the conversation ahead: how to steer it towards Erin. *What about that brunette you trained with last year? Still seeing her?* I could practically hear myself ask the questions.

Only I was done with that. No more lies.

Erin would be along any minute now, to introduce me to AJ as her husband. I could wait for her arrival, hide as Tommy for a little while longer, procrastinate on the problem of AJ.

"I'm Erin's husband." I heard myself say the words more than I actually said them. Like I was eavesdropping in on this conversation. Like I wasn't the focus of AJ's intense confusion.

His brow fell, furrowed and sharp. He squinted one eye, the other fixated on me. I snapped back into myself with all the intensity that came with it. Strangely, I felt completely at ease. The truth was out now. I was released.

Then, improbably, he grinned and wagged his finger at me. "For a second there, you had me going."

I was about to say that I was serious, about to explain to him that this was no joke. But he went on before I could.

"See, I've actually met Erin's husband, and you ain't him."

"No, for real, I'm really..." He'd met Erin's husband? What? "What?"

"Yeah, man. He comes into Callahan's from time to time, just to get updates. Or came in, before I quit." Aj looked around, like he'd made a joke for others to laugh at. "Remember, way back when, I told you that he's into the fantasy, right?" Aj shrugged. "I don't get it myself, but this isn't the first time I've been with a chick with this kind of arrangement."

His eyes actually ended on Max. Max and his stacked redhead of a wife.

I was. So. Confused.

"He came into the bar?"

"Yeah. He did. Haven't seen him in...since sometime last year, I guess. Guy wants to keep up with things, you know? He's actually the guy who suggested the triathlon. Coached me on how to seduce his wife and everything—play it slow, don't be a dick, all that stuff. I probably could have been banging her earlier than race day, but that's how this guy wanted it."

"What are you talking about?" He wasn't making any sense.

Aj rounded on me, annoyed. "You keep asking that. What's there not to get?"

I took a deep breath. I had all kinds of answers to that question, least of which the fact that none of this made sense. I settled on the most straightforward of my options. "I don't get it because *I'm* her husband!"

Aj's eyes narrowed, receding into his thoughts for a moment. He looked vaguely at my mouth, as if working through my statement, his lips repeating it wordlessly. *You...are her husband?* When he looked back up, his focus

was back. He drew his head ever so slightly back. For the first time since we'd met, he *saw* me. And perhaps I was seeing him, too.

"Well, is this a bad time?"

Erin's voice, breaking the closest thing to a standoff that I'd ever have. We drew our metaphorical guns back and turned to the source of our conflict.

Erin stood there, looking cuter than she was sexy. She wore a striped sweater and a pair of tight jeans, had her hair back in a ponytail, and judging from her height, wore something heeled.

AJ turned to Erin, although he kept his eyes on me. "Hey, just the person to settle something," he said.

"Tom is my husband," Erin said.

AJ's eyes shifted once, to Erin, as if checking that she was real. Then he was back on me, and while he may have smiled, it wasn't friendly.

"Well that's weird, because I've met your husband, and this guy isn't him."

I glanced at Erin, shrugging as she looked as confused as I felt.

AJ barreled on, misinterpreting our stunned silence for something else. "What are you two up to? What's your game?" His face darkened. He seemed to take a step closer to me without actually moving. "Are you behind the blackmail?"

Erin slipped in between us, a hand on each of us. "AJ, listen to me. Tom is my husband. Has been for almost ten years. We have two kids together." She turned to him, the touch on his chest growing softer. "Now what are you talking about? Who is this guy you met?"

It was AJ's turn to be stunned. He shook his head and backed away, stumbling into his stool. The bartender looked up in concern. "You okay, AJ?"

AJ held his hand up. "Fine." To us, he said, "Your husband has a beard. Big guy. Has a trust fund thing going

on.”

My stomach sank. Erin and I looked at each other, coming to the same, horrifying conclusion. Lucas? He had to be talking about Lucas Hughes.

When Erin spoke, it was as if she was trying to calm a lion. “Aj, I think we’ve been set up. That guy you said is my husband? He’s actually the man who blackmailed us.” Something else seemed to slide into place in Erin’s head. “Wait, did you send the video to just me?”

“I told you, I sent it to you and your...husband.” Aj got it too. That’s how the video leaked. Aj had sent it right to Lucas. Only...it still made no sense.

I said, “When did you meet the guy?”

Aj ran his hands through his short hair. “I don’t know, a while ago,” he said, agitated. “Wait, fuck all that. You two have been lying to me all along?!”

Erin sidled up closer to him. “Aj, Aj, listen to me.” She didn’t beg. She didn’t plead. She was affectionate, in the way she was affectionate with our kids when they were upset. Only there was something more, an intimacy between them that shifted things uncomfortably inside of me. “I should have told you. Right from the beginning, I should have been straight.”

“Yes—”

“But we were new to all of this. I didn’t know what I was getting myself into, and I wanted to include my husband in this.”

I watched Aj carefully. Something changed about his expression, although at first I didn’t recognize it. When he spoke, he was less angry and more...hurt? That didn’t seem right. “You were right, you should have told me.”

Erin nodded. “I’m sorry that I didn’t.”

I watched the way her hand touched Aj, her fingers splayed out in a caress. My gut squirmed as I watched Erin work her magic, remembering her statement about love and

like and things not being black and white. I kept my mouth shut.

Erin took a small step closer. Her voice came even quieter. "But listen, AJ, this is important. I think I know who blackmailed us, and I'm pretty sure it's the same guy who posed as my husband. So tell me. Think. When did you meet him?"

AJ looked up at the ceiling, tonguing the inside of his cheek. He actually smiled. "Hey, Max, how do I keep winding up in these fucked up relationships?"

The bartender didn't move from his position where he was drying glasses. His smile was thoughtful. I wondered how much the man had heard, and suddenly felt embarrassed.

AJ sighed and looked back down at us. "After...pretty sure it was after I met you."

"After you met Erin? Or me?" I asked.

AJ glanced at me, as though he'd forgotten I was there. "Oh, definitely *before* you and I...met. So what? When you ran into me at the gym, were you stalking me? Was it all a setup?" His eyes went bright. "Was that some mission to check me out naked, to see if I was, what? Big enough?"

For a second, I was lost. Then I remembered the true first time we'd met: in the locker room at City Fitness, in the sauna, and then after, when I'd run into him and his towel had slipped. My face filled with heat, as if I was back in that sauna again.

"No, that was an accident. Seriously, I didn't know who you were then."

"And I should believe you...why?"

My shoulders stiffened. "Why would I lie about that?"

Erin, sensing the tension mount, inserted herself between us again. "He didn't know. Not until after. When he told me, I thought he was setting it all up, too. You met him the same day you asked me to do the triathlon, if I remember."

AJ barked out a laugh, suddenly amused.

"What?" asked Erin.

"Oh, this is good. This is so good," he said. "Max, could we get a round of Jameson's."

The bartender went about preparing the shots, and AJ didn't speak until he'd handed us each a glass. He raised his in a mock toast. "To lies and treachery."

We didn't repeat his toast, and he didn't wait for us. He tipped the Irish whiskey back, downed it, and slammed his shot glass back onto the bar. I shrugged and followed suit.

AJ wiped his mouth and spoke. "So want to hear the most fucked up thing? My own little confession?" He rolled his head, cracking his neck, a boxer stepping into the ring. "Your *husband*, the fake one, suggested the tri. He said that you hadn't done this before. He said that you didn't even know about his fantasy, and that he preferred to keep it that way. For him, he said, part of the thrill was for you to cheat on him, so he didn't want you to know that he knew."

AJ's laugh was macabre. He shook his head. "I always thought that that guy was an asshole. I wondered why you'd married a guy like that. He didn't want me telling you that we talked, so I didn't." He glanced at me. "I'm not a literary...guy, but I believe this is called situational irony."

He held up his finger and twirled it in the air. "Another round."

We moved to the tables after that as we compared notes. AJ sat on one side, Erin and I on the other. The depth of Lucas's involvement, from the very beginning, was unbelievable. It had been Lucas from the very beginning. Somehow, Lucas had learned that AJ was Erin's personal trainer and that she had a thing for him. That was probably through Haley, although we weren't sure whether Haley was an active participant in the deception. After that, Lucas had convinced AJ to seduce Erin through the triathlon training, and had been meeting with him regularly to get updates.

"Pictures?" Erin asked.

"A few, yeah."

"Oh, fuck," Erin swore under her breath.

AJ said, "I tried reaching out to him when the blackmail thing came up, but didn't get a response. When I called the number, it was disconnected."

"And you didn't think something was weird about that?" I said, heat in my voice.

AJ leveled a hard look at me. "I guess I didn't." *Asshole* wasn't said, but I still heard it.

I swallowed my pride and pressed on. "The real question is *why*. Why would he do something like that?"

"To get into your wife's panties," AJ said.

Shamefully, the suggestion registered between my legs. I ignored that.

"It just seems so...elaborate," I said. "So much setup."

"I'm not worth it?" Erin teased.

"Oh, you're worth it," AJ said, hunger in his voice.

"How did you two meet?" I pressed. "The first time. You and Lucas."

"Lucas? That's his name?" AJ said the name like he was sizing the man up. "Gym. I was his personal trainer for, like, a few months. Before."

I said, "Had to be a coincidence, then. At first."

"And then he just went with it," Erin added.

AJ nodded. "Could be. He was definitely adamant that I send him photos."

"And the video," I said.

"And the video," AJ repeated.

"So..." I said.

"So..." AJ said. He cracked his knuckles. "Where does he live?"

Erin reached across the table, setting a hand on his arm. She shook her head ever so slightly. "Going over there now will only make things worse."

AJ growled. "For this guy's face, hell yeah it will."

"We need to make sure he doesn't share that video," Erin said.

"Oh, fuck that video," AJ said, his voice growing louder. "What do I care about that fucking video?!"

I looked between AJ and Erin. I should say something, but I didn't know what. I didn't know how to slow the situation back down. Erin did. She squeezed his arm and looked him right in the eye. "You care," she said. "I know you do."

AJ gritted his teeth, his neck straining like he was trying to break some invisible restraints. He glanced away from us, towards the bar. I followed his eyes, catching the bartender leaning forward, listening. Their eyes met. The bartender nodded. *Listen to them*, he seemed to say.

AJ took a deep breath. Let it out. "You have a plan?" he asked.

"Working on it," Erin said. "You staying in town?"

"Yeah, for a little now, anyway. Lamar dropped me."

I winced. That didn't make this situation any better.

Erin said, "Sorry to hear that."

"Yeah, whatever. I made some connections already. I've got some feelers out."

"I'll be in touch, okay? Soon. Give me a few days."

"And if you don't come up with anything?"

"I'll give you Lucas's address. Promise."

AJ grinned. "Fine. A few days. Then I come looking."

OceanofPDF.com

TWELVE

We'd arrived separately, so we went home separately. But not before I took Erin into my arms at her car and kissed her like we'd just started dating.

"I'll see you at home," I said.

"Be safe."

Too late for that, I thought but didn't say. The sun had set by the time we left the bar, and the streets had begun to fill with the bar scene. It was after nine when we finally got home, and we walked into the gleeful shrieks of our kids.

Martin came screaming down the hall, shouting, "Daddy!" His face was smeared with chocolate. Mary was right behind him, her cheeks in a similar state, and a moment later, Jo emerged.

In the anxiety that I'd had around my encounter with AJ, I'd completely forgotten about Jo's promised arrival, and despite everything, seeing her again instantly brought me back to our last meeting and the way she panted when we fucked. It didn't help that she wore a tight sweater that scooped low enough to give me an eyeful of cleavage, or a pair of tight jeans that may as well have been leggings.

"So how did it go?" Jo asked, her concern snapping me back to the reality of our lives.

"Better than expected," Erin said, coming in behind me. "Things didn't come to blows."

"So not like your usual meetups with him?" Jo asked, unable to help herself.

Erin shot a look at our children. "Jo!"

Jo held up her hands, which in turn pushed her breasts together. Jo said, "Sorry, sorry."

"Instead of making us brush our teeth and get into our jammies, Auntie Jo gave us Girl Scout cookies!" Martin said.

"Gur scout coo-coos!" Mary repeated.

Erin laughed. "I see that."

Jo held up three fingers in the Girl Scout salute. "Always prepared, right?"

"I'd forgotten you were a Girl Scout," Erin said flatly. To me, she said, "When the time comes, remind of this when Mary asks to be a Brownie."

As a trio, we got the kids to bed by ten, although with all the chocolate coursing through them, there was a moment when I thought that they'd be up all night. When that was done—and we stopped hearing them shouting "goodnight" at each other—we retired into the living room and opened a bottle of wine.

"I think you two need to catch me up on a few things," Jo said, curling up into the armchair. I glanced at Erin, who looked back at me. I shrugged, then launched into our story.

We told her everything we knew, from the very beginning. I was a little surprised at how little she did know about some things that I'd just assumed Erin had shared—like my first, naked encounter with AJ in the sauna, or just how much Erin saw AJ.

Retelling our theories served to bring clarity to a few things. It also made it real. Lucas had played us. Everything we'd done, all the adventures and discoveries and excitement, had been because of his manipulation from the very beginning. If he hadn't suggested that AJ seduce Erin, would he have done it? Or, more likely, would AJ have come on too strong, and Erin would have yet another trainer on Tuesday and Thursday nights? Would we still be living our normal lives, ignorant of this huge, new fantasy?

We talked about motive, and why Lucas did what he did at all. We shared AJ's theory that he did it to sleep with Erin, and while Jo acknowledged that that was probably part of it, she had another thought. "I'm not sure how to put this delicately, but...that guy hates you, Tom."

"What?"

"You don't see it?" Jo asked, propping her head on up her hand. Her curly hair spilled down around the armrest in soft, beautiful ringlets. "He hates what you have. He hates your life and how good you have it. I can't say for certain this is why he did what he did, but my guess is that it was part of it. He saw an opportunity to mess with you, and he took it. That's the kind of guy your friend, Lucas Hughes, is."

"No friend of mine," I growled.

"But his wife is," Jo said. "Or so we think."

"So we hope," Erin said. "But yeah, it's possible that she knows. I hate it, but it's possible."

"So how do we find out for sure?" I asked, already working through the logic. "If Haley knows, then she's seen the video..." I looked at Erin. "You didn't show her?"

"I told you, I didn't show anyone. Not even Jo here."

"It's true, and I would have loved to see that video."

"She asked," Erin said. "She begged."

"I don't beg. Whatever."

I barely heard the banter. "So if she's in on it, she's seen the video and knows who AJ and Lamar are. If she isn't..."

"Then she has no idea who he is, other than a name," Erin said, quickly following my thinking. "All we need to do is have Haley meet AJ and watch her reaction."

Jo clapped, as giddy as I felt. She said, "Erin, looks like it's time to introduce my new boyfriend to your neighbor. Girls' night out?"

*

"She's not in on it," Erin said before she was even two steps into the house.

It was Tuesday evening, the earliest evening that Erin could get Haley to go out without sounding suspicious. Jo and her "boyfriend," played by AJ, were visiting from California and were tagging along.

I'd spent the evening while they were away pacing with my phone at the ready. We hadn't really thought this one through, despite having thought it through. We'd spent too much time under the assumption that Haley *didn't* know. If she did, and she recognized AJ for who he was...what then? Presumably the other neighborhood wives would have stopped Haley from making a scene, but the truth would get back to Lucas eventually, and then what would *he* do?

But now it didn't matter. "You're sure she doesn't know?"

"Positive. She had no clue who *Arnold* was." She laughed once again at the name—apparently AJ stood for Arnold Johnson, which made me regard the man in a completely different light.

The knot in my gut finally unraveled. I pulled her into my arms and kissed the top of her head. "Oh, thank god for that."

I felt Erin's relief, too, as she hugged me back. It was the first piece of good news we'd had in awhile.

"I think that you may have forgotten someone," I said, realizing that Jo wasn't behind her.

"She's going to be late. AJ's holding her to the whole girlfriend thing."

"Ah, I see."

Erin looked up at me, her hand running along my chest. "You know what she had to agree to in order for him to do this, don't you?"

"I'm guessing it's not just a night with her."

"No, not just that." When she kissed me, we'd gone beyond the loving, relieved embrace. Her mouth was wet, her tongue probing and suggestive. "Come on, let's take it to the bedroom," she said.

Erin looked cool in her short, leather jacket, tight black jeans, and tall, black boots. When she shed the coat, revealing a black, sleeveless blouse, I couldn't help but wonder where this femme fatale had come from. She was so

sure of herself. Just a year ago, I'd never seen this side of her—or even when we'd first started dating. I hated that Lucas tainted all of it.

I followed Erin up the stairs, the buzz of anticipation riding low in my gut and high along the top of my scalp. It was a good feeling, one that reminded me of all the times I'd stayed home as Erin had gone off to play. Only this time, Erin was here.

Erin turned back to me, looking at me over her shoulder with bright eyes and a smile poised nervously on the corners of her lips. "I'm not worried, just..."

"On edge?" I offered.

"Yes!"

I spread my hands out before me. "Welcome to my world."

She shook her head. "That's pretty intense."

"So what are we on edge about?" I asked, moving up behind her. I wrapped my arms around her, pressing my growing erection against her ass. Beneath her black blouse, her nipples were hard, her tits swelling with excitement.

Erin reached into her back pocket and pulled out her phone. I watched over her shoulder as she slid it open, navigating to Snapchat. Since when did she have Snapchat on her phone? Her breathing quickened, and when I watched her fingers dance across the screen, I half-expected to see them tremble.

The first photo she loaded up was one of the whole gang at the bar—including Erin—posing for a shot. There, in the middle, was "Arnold," looking somehow both out of place and right where he belonged in the midst of all those suburban moms.

"Photos? Really?" I asked. After the mess that they got us in, were we really about to go where I thought we were going?

"They don't last. They're not saved. The photos disappear forever after a few second." As if on queue, this

photo disappeared and was gone from the message history. "I know, it's crazy. Reckless, even, but Jo seemed to think it was fine. This...is sort of meant to prove how confident she is."

She opened the next photo. It was of Jo and AJ, their cheeks pressed together as they posed like the couple they were not.

"They look very convincing," I said.

The photo disappeared. Erin loaded the next. This photo must have been taken a moment later. The two had turned to one another, kissing openly.

"Yes, very. They almost had me fooled."

I looked down at my wife, who was staring at the photo. "Jealous?"

She shrugged. "I was there."

"You didn't answer my question."

The photo blinked out of existence. Glancing at me out of the corner of her eye, she stepped away, she released a tiny exhalation. "A little. I'm sorry."

"You wish you were there, with them?"

I expected her to say no, or maybe hedge with a vague, *It's not like that*. Instead, she turned fully to me, embarrassed by her honesty. "Part of me does, yeah."

He's turned you into a slut, was my first thought. She hadn't always been like this. But then, maybe she had, buried deep inside of her. Maybe the woman who craved big cocks in her ass had always been there. I'd just not tapped into it the way AJ had.

"Well, I'm afraid you're going to have to settle for me."

"No, it's not like—"

I pushed her to her knees before she could finish the deflection. Erin gasped, looking up at me, the apology wiped from her face.

Looking down at her, I said, "Think Jo will do this tonight?"

Erin reached for my belt, sliding the leather past the metal hasp. "If we're lucky, maybe we'll get a photo."

"Give me your phone."

Erin's hands froze on the zipper of my pants. She looked nervous. I nodded with as much confidence that I could muster. This felt risky, but less so than so many other things that we'd done. Better, it was Erin and I doing it.

Whether Erin arrived at the same conclusion or not, I wasn't sure, but she slid her phone back out of her pocket again and handed it up to me. I unlocked it, used the password that she'd always used—it still worked, and I felt slightly guilty that I ever doubted that it may not.

Snapchat was still open, the message screen to Jo now empty. The evidence of their time in the bar was gone; only the memory remained. That's the way these things should have been, I realized. Our memory was what was important, and how we managed those memories.

I looked down at Erin, still on her knees, her hands resting on my fly. I nodded again. She sucked in a sharp breath, understanding what I was about to do.

"Take it out," I said. "Show me how much you want it."

It didn't feel like a thing I'd normally say...until I said it. Until Erin did as I said so eagerly.

I snapped a photo of Erin pulling my zipper down, green eyes focused on her task at hand. Then another as she pulled my cock out, her diamond ring sending lens flares across the photo. It was beautiful. The last photo I sent was Erin, holding my erection as she looked up at me, at the camera, a bit of color in her cheeks and a sly smile on her lips.

Then I tossed her phone onto her bed and enjoyed my blowjob.

Erin had gotten very good at giving head over the months, but I couldn't help but wonder if she was a little more enthusiastic tonight than before. Was it in my head?

And if not, was that because of me, or because she was thinking of AJ?

I pulled my shirt off as Erin bobbed, then stepped out of my pants. Being naked with a fully clothed woman servicing me could have made me feel vulnerable. Instead, I felt my muscles swell with my excitement. I felt powerful.

Her phone buzzed on the bed. We both heard it. My gut trembled at what was waiting for us there. Erin moaned around my shaft.

“Want to check it?” I asked.

Erin pulled off of me, gasping. “I do.”

“First, strip.”

She nodded, rising to her feet, her body so close I could feel her warmth on my bare skin. She didn’t step away as she pulled her black shirt over her head. She didn’t move when she worked her jeans over her hips, leaving her in nothing but her lacy black bra and her tiny, little thong.

“Everything?” she asked.

I looked her over, my heart rapping against my chest. Had she put that bra and panty set on for AJ, even when she knew she wouldn’t see him? I loved idea, even if it wasn’t true.

“No, keep that on for now. Let’s show AJ what he’s missing. Get the phone.”

The thong did so very little to cover her ass, barely a triangle of close at the top of her buttocks, as lacy as the bra. I couldn’t help myself. I reached out and touched her smooth cheek. She was still cold from being outside.

She retrieved the phone, standing up and pressing herself against me as she unlocked it. I kissed her neck. “Did they respond?” I asked. I pushed my hand down into her panties. She was already so wet.

Erin moaned. I ventured lower, sliding my middle finger into her as she refocused on the phone. “Um...yes, we have a new...three new photos.”

“Open it.”

Her thumb shook as she tapped the first, incoming photo. It was taken from above, in a very similar pose as Erin had been in, moments before. The bare sweep of Jo's shoulders were visible, although her breasts were obscured by the thick protrusion of AJ's cock. She held it in her hand, her fingers barely wrapped around its bare-shaven base, and she was smiling into the camera.

Erin's breath caught, although that could have been the way I rubbed my thumb across her clit at the same time.

The photo disappeared after the allocated ten seconds. "Go to the next one," I said, then held my breath.

The next was the same angle, same position, only this time Jo's head was turned so she could run her tongue along the crown of his cock, right where it was most sensitive. And in the final shot, Jo had him in her mouth—all of him.

"Wow," I said as the picture disappeared.

Erin turned and sat on the edge of the bed. "Come here," she said.

I moved forward, and in one fluid motion she caught me, dipped down, and swallowed my cock. All of it. I felt it slid into her throat. She gagged, but only once, then she found her rhythm. It was fast and long, the wet slurps making it that much raunchier. She looked up at me, meeting my eyes, showing me what a good, submissive slut she could be.

I grabbed her phone again, this time shooting a video. I directed it down at her, but just before hitting record, something came over me. I reached down, grabbed a fist full of her hair, and took control.

I'd never done that, but Erin seemed to know exactly what to do. She froze, opened her mouth and throat to me, and let me fuck her face. When she put a hand on my ass, it wasn't to slow or stop me, but to stabilize herself under my onslaught. And I recorded ten glorious seconds of it and sent it to another man—her one-time lover.

AJ's response—although the chat came in through Jo—was almost instantaneous.

-She loves to be treated like a slut, doesn't she?

I looked down at Erin, still looking up at me with a meekness that I only recognized because she'd looked at AJ and Lamar that way. Now it was my turn, and it was thrilling. I fucked her throat harder. She gagged again, adjusted, but didn't pull away, didn't use her hand to still my driving hips.

She began to moan, sending vibrations along my shaft that boiled the come in my balls. I felt everything loosen, everything take one last, collective swallow of air before the end came. In that sliver of clarity, I saw Erin's free hand shoved inside of her thong, where she played with herself in time with my thrusts. The phone buzzed again. Another message. From AJ.

-You slap her with your cock? That slut loves that shit

I couldn't have tried that even if I wanted to. Reading it alone triggered the end. Thinking about AJ bludgeoning my wife's sweet face with his erection was too much.

I came in a roar, exploding into the back of Erin's throat. She choked at first, swiftly moving to angle herself best to swallow, to take my pent-up load.

When the moment had passed and Erin and I were laying side-by-side on the bed with our legs hanging off, breathing heavily at the ceiling, Erin's phone buzzed again.

Erin picked it up, holding it over her head.

"This one likes it, too," she read. "Likes what?"

"He told me you liked it when he slapped you with his cock." I felt embarrassed just saying it aloud. This was much easier to type.

Erin laughed. "Not sure about that, but it does feel really...dirty. Oh, look. A photo. Shall I?"

She loaded it before I could tell her yes. There was Jo, smiling up at the camera, her face covered in the milky film of AJ's come.

"If I were there, he'd make me lick that off of her," Erin said when the photo disappeared.

"And you would have."

"And I would have." Erin's smoky agreement had my cock stirring all over again.

I pushed her up to the head of the bed, crawled over her, and kissed her deeply. "You could have gone."

She gave the question thought. "I know, but I'm glad I didn't. This is actually a lot more fun."

"What's that?"

"The waiting for the messages. The photos. It's like the raunchiest tease I've ever had. You never know what'll come next."

I nodded, stroking a stray hair over her ear. "When you're out there, it's always like that. It's...fun."

"But confusing," she said. "Anxious."

"Yes."

"God, I can't even imagine what that would be like if I was waiting on you, not Jo and AJ."

I shook my head. "You don't have to worry about that."

"Who says I'm worried? Maybe I want it?"

I turned to her. She'd set the phone down, but was still staring at the ceiling. "You do?"

"It was pretty sexy watching you with Jo." She shifted to her side and watched her fingers tease through my chest hair. "Really sexy."

"I won't disagree with that," I said lightly.

"Just thinking about you going out, without me..." She finally lifted her eyes to mine. "I'd like try that one day."

"Will you be here to reclaim me?"

She cracked a smile. "Always."

We kissed again. I was hard enough that I pushed her onto her back and entered her. We groaned at the slippery union, finding a slow, steady rhythm.

"You know, you could reclaim Jo if you wanted to. Tonight."

The well-behaved version of me would have denied that I'd thought about that, but we were well beyond well behaved. Besides, she must have felt me grow inside of her at the possibility. "You want me to?"

"If I could watch."

"Someone's becoming a real voyeur," I said.

"I guess you're rubbing off on me."

"I sure am," I said, thrusting hard. Erin giggled.

"I love you, you silly man," she said.

"I love you too, silly woman."

We made slow love, working up a gentle sweat between us until our naked bodies glided together. Beside us, Erin's phone buzzed. Once. Twice. Three then four times. We ignored it until I could feel Erin's orgasm rise like a fire finally catching. I nurtured it, speeding my hips when she needed it, kissing her neck and the backs of her ears.

Her hands tightened in my hair as her moans rose, high yet still quiet. I fucked her through her sweet climax and kissed her to keep her quiet. Only then did we snuggle together and grab the phone.

"Wonder what they've been up to," Erin said as she unlocked it.

It was still weird to open the chat window and only see new messages. All the old ones were wiped away, lost to the corners of the Internet. Erin tapped open the first photo, and there was Jo, posing naked in the shower. Her unruly hair was wet, tempered down, yet still fighting to get wild despite that.

"She's pretty," Erin said as the photo disappeared.

"She is."

The next photo made my heart squeeze. It was a slightly closer shot of Jo, and in her hand was AJ's razor.

Erin laughed.

"What?" I asked.

"AJ's got this fetish..." she explained, going to the next photo.

This one was of Jo, leaning back against the shower wall, with shaving cream spread across her mound. I could see the light brown streak of her landing strip through the white foam, but just barely.

I reached down, touching Erin's own smoothly shaved mound. "It's not the worst fetish out there."

Erin rolled her eyes, but smiled. "I suppose he could be into feet."

"You've got very cute feet," I whispered, kissing her neck.

She moved on to the next image. This one was a close up of Jo's pussy as she dragged the razor across her mound. I could already see the trimmed stripe was mostly gone. I had to admit, that was a pretty sexy sight.

I rubbed Erin's pussy, avoiding her protruding clit. "So after this is all over, are you planning on keeping it this way?"

"You mean after AJ?"

It was the first acknowledgement that our future may not hold the personal trainer. We hadn't discussed it, but we both knew that conversation was coming.

"Yeah, after."

We could have had it now. It wasn't the worst time, although it would have lent a certain finality to what we were doing. I left it up to Erin, though, and didn't press. When she reached down and circled my cock, I had her answer: *later*.

"I like it. I can't say that I'll keep it this way forever, but for now, yes. And besides, I like the effect it has on you."

I knew my role. I smiled, kissed her one more time, and then made my way down between her legs.

Above me, Erin hummed. "Mm, can't wait to run my tongue along that."

I kissed her cunt. "Maybe you should do the reclaiming."

"Maybe we both should—ah!"

I pressed my tongue against her clit and two fingers against her opening. She spread her legs, gasping at the onslaught.

"You're so...good at that," she groaned.

"It's just the effect you have on me," I said.

Erin laughed, but somehow it didn't break the mood. It only made me feel closer to this woman. She pushed my head between her legs, and I went back to work.

There was something beautiful, hearing Erin's orgasm grow and build under my handiwork. My jaw ached and my tongue cramped, but I always kept going, driven by the sound of her gasps and sighs, the little moans that always slipped out, even when she was trying to be quiet.

I ate her until she wrapped her thighs around my head and lifted her hips off the bed. I ate her until she couldn't take it any longer. She released one, loud shriek before she got her voice under control. I could barely breathe. Could barely move. And what I could, I did, my tongue swamping her sodden pussy as she came.

I slid up over her before she was fully recovered, and pushed into her slippery embrace. I kissed her, sharing her own excitement with her, and got turned on when she didn't pull away in disgust.

We rearranged ourselves on the bed, Erin riding me cowgirl style. I took a photo of her like that, nude and dappled with sweat, the lighting dramatic, and sent it to AJ. He returned with a photo of his own—Jo in his lap, facing away, her newly clean shaven snatch stretched around AJ's thick shaft.

That photo was the beginning of the end for me. I didn't come immediately, but I lost the will to fight it. I grabbed Erin's hips, holding them steady as I began rapidly pumping her from below, rocking my pelvis until my abs screamed and my buttocks were sore.

"That's it, Tommy. Fuck me. Fuck me. Fuck...*me!*"

Tommy. That's who I was for a moment. AJ's workout buddy. A guy who casually talked about pussy like a Jersey bro. A guy who knew guys like AJ. For one moment, I was transformed, and Erin begged me for more. I grabbed her ass, squeezing harder than I usually felt I could. She moaned louder. I squeezed, driving her whole body up and down, in and out, deep and deeper and—

"Take my come," I groaned.

Erin came again. Or maybe she'd never stopped. She tossed her head back, her hands filled with her tits. My world slid sideways as I fell into myself, into my climax and a world of stars.

When I came to, only a moment had passed, but it was still disorienting. Erin was curled over me, panting, sweating, cooing when she could.

She took a deep breath, the kind of breath she took when she had something to confess. I tensed. "What?" I said.

"So I may have led Haley to believe that we were having some trouble, you and I."

"You did? Why?"

"Because then Lucas thinks we're having some trouble."

"What's your plan, Erin? What are you thinking?"

"Well, to trap this asshole, we're going to need some bait."

I followed where she was going, but I didn't like it. "Erin, I don't know. I don't trust him."

"Then you're going to have to trust me. Now, here's what I'm thinking..."

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTEEN

I ran into Lucas the following weekend at the park. It was planned—as planned as these things could be. It would have happened no matter what. Our neighborhood was too small to hide in. This way, though, we could control it.

We lucked out on the weather. It was unseasonably warm for March, pushing into the mid-60s, so of course everyone was out at the park on Saturday morning. I figured that the Hughes children would be out, and was counting on Lucas to take them because we knew Haley usually attended a Saturday morning yoga class.

Lucas spotted me before long and made his way over, with his son Andy at his side. He wore shorts, a t-shirt, and a fleece vest like he'd just come from an L.L. Bean catalog shoot.

"Tom," he said without offering a handshake.

The last time I'd *talked* to him was at the New Year's Eve party, when I'd threatened him. He watched my reaction carefully as I did likewise. I needed him to believe that I had no idea that he'd blackmailed Lamar. Everything hinged on him believing that I was completely ignorant.

"Hey, Andy!" my son Martin said. "Want to play castle?"

"Yeah!"

The boys ran off, and we watched them go, standing side-by-side in silence. It was Lucas that broke it. "Erin at home with Mary?"

I nodded. "Mary's not feeling well."

"I hear that. Winter sucks."

I turned to look at him. He had his eyes on the playground, watching our sons play, but his mind was elsewhere.

I know what you did, you asshole, and I'm going to fucking kill you. The words kept coming to me, over and

over. And when they weren't, I thought about putting him into a chokehold, right here in the midst of all of our friends.

But that wasn't why I was here. I took a deep breath and got into it. "Hey, you ever worry about Haley...you know...stepping out?"

Now Lucas turned to me. I could see him read the air between us, processing this new and unexpected bit of information. I could practically see him try to decide whether he should say something snarky and mean, like the kind of man he was, or whether he should act the sympathetic friend and dig for more. I was counting on the latter.

"I mean, sometimes, sure. I travel a lot, and she's a beautiful woman." He didn't let that sit for too long, quickly asking, "You?"

I smiled inwardly, but kept my face downtrodden. "Her personal trainer is back in town," I said.

"Ah. AJ, right?" The man was good at lying.

"Yeah. He was out in LA for a while, but apparently he's back. And Erin's been seeing him."

Lucas nodded. Everything I'd said fit what he knew, my story confirming authenticity. "But you're into that, right?"

He was working so hard not to come off as insensitive, yet he just couldn't help it. I kept in role. "I am," I agreed. "When I know about it. When she *tells* me about it."

"She hasn't told you that he's back," Lucas concluded.

"No. I only know because I saw some texts on her phone. It was a booty call. And she'd told me that she was going to the gym."

Lucas stroked his blond beard. "Man, I'm sorry to hear that." He couldn't have sounded more insincere.

I had him hooked. Now I just needed to slowly reel him in. "So I looked into it. I checked her accounts. I know, I know, it's pretty awful. But...look man, I think...I think she may be falling for him. Apparently there's been a lot more meetings going on with him than I thought."

“Really? Like how many?”

“I thought they’d taken a break after...you know, the birthday thing, right? I’d asked her to. But...she didn’t. She even...” I released a heavy breath. “She even had a threesome, man.” I leaned in close, whispering, “With Lamar Williamson. The track star.”

Lucas lifted his brows, feigning surprise. Only his eyes gave away his duplicity. “Damn, that’s crazy.”

“You can’t tell anyone, okay? Even Erin doesn’t know that I know.” I put my hand on his shoulder, then realized that maybe that was too much. “Look, I know we’ve had our...disagreements. But I also know you’re a man with integrity.” Shudder. “I asked you to stay away from her after New Year’s, and I know that you have. I looked for your name on her recent contacts. Didn’t find anything.”

I saw the tension leave his shoulders. He was mine.

“So we’re good?” Lucas asked. If his tongue had come out forked like a snake’s, I wouldn’t have been surprised.

“We’re good.”

“Is there anything I can do? You need anything?”

I did, but it was too early to ask. “Maybe. I’m still working through this shit.”

“Damn, man, I’m super sorry,” he said.

I nodded. “Thanks, Lucas. I never thought I’d say this, but you’re alright.”

I gathered Martin up, said my goodbye, and left. As soon as my back was to him, I couldn’t stop smiling.

*

Funny thing about that encounter. Until that meeting with Lucas, I felt like nothing was in our control, that the whole world was conspiring to expose our secret and destroy our lives. The threat was larger than life, and unstoppable in the long run. Eventually, that video would get out, whether it was sold to a porn studio or just released

to the darker corners of the Internet, it was only a matter of time.

But talking to Lucas put everything into perspective. He was just a man, and a fallible one at that. He could be deceived. He could be made vulnerable. And he'd just stepped into the trap that we'd set.

That night, Jo and Erin went out, but before they did, Erin made this call:

"Haley? This is Erin. I have a small favor to ask you...It's not big, and probably won't even mean you have to do anything, but if Tom happens to call you or something, can you tell him that we're all out...? Yes, girls night...Yeah, everything is fine, it's just that my friend Jo is still here and we're meeting up with her boyfriend, and I'm not sure Tom would be...What's that?" Erin laughed. "Okay, so maybe that has something to do with it..." Another laugh. "Yes, he does have nice, big hands."

She looked at me, her eyes bright. Added: "Maybe you should come along. Jo says he's more than capable of handling three."

I groaned. She didn't mean it—they were actually just going out to a restaurant together—but it was still hot to think about.

"Suit yourself. And if he does call—which he won't—tell him we went to Alexander's...Thanks!"

She hung up and dropped her phone into her bag. She was dressed casually—dark jeans, long flowy top, long flowy sweater—not an outfit to seduce "Arnold." But the idea was still there, even if fake, and was still sexy.

"Have fun," I said, kissing her sweetly.

Jo joined us a moment later, dressed equally as casual. "You think she'll tell Lucas?"

"I do," Erin said. "Especially if he passed on what you talked about earlier."

I said, "And if we're lucky, he'll be watching for your car going out."

“I’ll make sure to drive extra slow down the block.”

I watched the two of them leave with the same trepidation that I did when they’d gone out to meet AJ for real. She said she wasn’t, so I believed her. I liked the thought, though, it was exciting and wrong and got my heart racing like always, but I knew it was time to move on.

Not that Erin didn’t tease me. She sent a couple suggestive texts intended to get my blood pressure up.

-Jo is so naughty!

Or,

-I may have had a little too much to drink.

Or,

-Arnold left quite impression on Josephine, it seems

I didn’t bite. Didn’t even answer her. But by the time she got home, just before midnight, I was ready to explode. We reconnected just as we would when she came back from AJ, and a small part of me wondered if they really had gone to his place. But I didn’t smell him on her—no cologne, no musk, no heady scent of sex...and no smell of the shower, either.

She was horny, but innocent. Relatively speaking. Once upon a time, I may have been disappointed by this. Maybe a small, dark part of me still was. But mostly, I felt relief, clear and refreshing.

*

The setup after that felt downhill. Lucas was a predator, and in our marriage he tasted blood. A man like that wouldn’t be able to resist, no matter the risks.

It only took a week for him to “bump” into Erin at the gym. He didn’t ask her out, but Erin reported that they flirted. The idea made me sick to my stomach, but I knew it was a necessary evil. We were nearly ready to set things in

motion, but there were still a couple loose ends to tie up: Haley, and the location that Lucas had taken the money.

I'd driven out to the address where my tracker had stopped and eventually died. It was a nondescript building in a warehouse complex. Other businesses operated out of the place—a catering group, an indoor volleyball gym, an auto body shop—but the specific place where the GPS dot had stopped was unmarked.

Luckily for me, I worked in commercial real estate, and this, right here, was definitely commercially zoned. It didn't take long to get an owner back, and that owner wasn't surprising: Hughes Security.

Getting Haley on board was a lot riskier. She was Lucas's wife, which made her a wild card. Haley was sweet and kind, the kind of girl-next-door that lived up to the idea of it. She had a good heart. But she was also married to Lucas, and worse, knew about his sexual escapades—at least some of them. We were banking on the fact that she had no idea about the ones that went down when he was out of town.

"This is going to be hard," Erin said, pacing the kitchen. "She's been living in denial for so long. And that can be a comfortable place. What if she doesn't appreciate us showing her the truth?"

I watched Erin quietly before answering. We were talking about Haley, of course, but we might as well have been talking about ourselves. "Comfortable is comfortable, but not always good. Sometimes, facing the hard truths is the only way to move forward."

Erin stopped, picking up where I was going. I was glad Jo wasn't here. This was a conversation that we needed to have alone.

"So this is it," Erin said.

"Probably should be."

"That's not an answer."

I raised an eyebrow. "Were you asking a question?" It sounded so much calmer than I felt inside.

Erin softened from her spot and took a step towards me. We'd been so caught up in plotting our revenge on Lucas that we'd done our best not to confront the bigger question: our future.

"It is," Erin said. "We need to make this decision together."

"Do you have feelings for AJ?" It had been a question that I'd wanted so badly to ask, so many times, but could never bring myself to even form in my head. Now, it just spilled out. Just like that.

Erin blinked, as stunned by it as I felt asking. "I don't love him. I've told you that before."

I shook my head. "That's not what I asked. Do you have feelings for him?"

"Is there a difference?"

I sighed. I didn't want this to be confrontational, and yet how quickly it had turned that way. That, alone, was answer enough. But I wanted to hear it, and not just to shove it in her face. I wasn't sure she'd come to terms with it, either.

"Yes," I said, gently, softly. "I think there is."

Erin shut her eyes, emotion seeming to pull at her like gravity. She took a deep breath. When she opened her eyes at last, her face was set. "I don't love him..."

I began to interject again, but held my tongue.

"...but yes, I guess I do have...feelings for him. I like him."

"You do." I stepped forward. She began to break down, tears lining her eyes.

"I care for him."

"I know."

When I folded her into my arms, she sobbed. "I'm so sorry."

"Don't be. It makes sense. Especially after everything you two have been through." She cried. I held her closer,

shushing her softly. "You said it yourself, when talking about AJ's feelings for you. Nothing's ever black and white, as much as we try to pretend that it is. If this whole experience has taught me anything, it's *that*. Even a guy like AJ. You don't love him, but he's not just a fuck buddy—as much as you want to believe that."

"I haven't seen him since the night we went out with Jo and Haley, and nothing happened then. I swear."

"I know, and I believe you."

"And I won't." She looked up at me, serious.

I laughed lightly. "Just like that, huh? That easy to give it up?"

"It has to be," Erin said, her voice grave.

"I thought we were making this decision together."

Erin blinked up at me through her tears. "What did you have in mind?"

I had something in mind, didn't I? The beginnings of a real plan to get Lucas off of our backs together. And it was hot enough that it got my blood racing.

"One last hurrah," I said. "You can't just leave it the way it was."

Erin searched my face for some indication that I was testing her. I wasn't. "You've got a plan, don't you?"

"It finally arrived and...I think you're going to like it."

*

Haley sat across the kitchen table from us, her hands folded, looking confused as to why she was even here. She was playing the part of best friend in this intervention. I was the observer, making sure that she really was on our side.

"Haley, we need to tell you something about your husband," Erin said gently.

Haley nodded, as if we'd answered her unasked question. "I'm sorry about...what happened. I told him it wasn't a good idea to...for the birthday thing. He was so

fixated on you, you know? And when Lucas latches onto an idea..." She sighed, then grimaced. "I never wanted to lose you as a friend, though."

Erin looked at me, before turning back to her one-time friend. "It's not that—not *just* that, anyway. He's...well, he's been seeing other women."

Haley's laugh sounded slightly bitter. "I know about them." Then something occurred to her. "How do you?"

Erin licked her lips, then pulled out some photos we'd gathered over the last couple weeks—photos of Lucas meeting strange women in strange cities. We'd gone back and forth about whether to involve Haley in the scheme. We could have worked around her, but we had to know. And if she wasn't involved, then *she* had to know. So here we were.

Haley peered at them curiously, her shock more at their existence at all than what was on them. She shifted one of the photos in front of her, unveiling another beneath—this one of Lucas in Las Vegas with his arms around two hookers as he entered a hotel room. Lucas had been seeing a lot of prostitutes since we'd started watching him—being fifty grand richer probably had something to do with that.

"Why do you have these?"

"We..." Erin glanced at me again, looking less certain of herself. "We wanted some...evidence. Proof that he was seeing other women behind your back."

Haley was shaking her head before Erin had even finished. "Not behind my back. Not exactly. I know he sees other women when I'm not there. It bothered me...once. But we worked through it."

In that moment, I imagined our future in Haley's statement—Erin meeting up with strange men behind my back, the first time I discovered her, and then the second, and then the slow numbing. I looked at Haley in an entirely different way. Gone was the naive homemaker, and in her place? A tired cynic, trying to hold it all together.

I said, "You know you don't have to just work through it."

"Isn't that what marriage is all about? Isn't that what *you* are doing right now?" The you could have been directed at the two of us, but her eyes never wavered from mine. She may as well have reached into my chest and squeezed my heart. "Stop looking at me like I'm an idiot. I'm know who my husband is. I know what he does."

I wanted to interrupt her, to tell her about the blackmail. That would come soon, but first she had some things to get off her chest.

"But I love him. He's so different from other men I've been with. He's sexy. Dangerous. I went into the relationship with my eyes wide open. I thought that if I...indulged his appetite, that it would work. I still remember the first time we took another woman home...I should have freaked out. I mean, we'd been married for less than a year, and here we were at one of the shows that Lucas was working security, taking some drunk groupie home. I remember watching Lucas fuck her in our bed, and..."

She paused, shaking her head. I almost felt sorry for her before she finished the thought.

"And it was one of the hottest things I'd ever seen. I stood there in the doorway, watching, touching myself, until I came." She nodded at me, both haunted and electrified by the memory. "You know what I'm talking about."

"I do," I said.

She looked back to Erin. "I know he's not a...good man. Not a faithful one. But he gave me something that I didn't know I wanted, and he let me be the PTA mom who cooked the best tuna casseroles, and also be the one who indulged this darker side." She pushed the photos subtly away. "I know you two mean well, and I love you guys for that, but nothing here is new. So please...stay out of our business."

Erin looked like she'd been slapped. I could see the anger rise through her, and was proud of her when she kept

herself in check. She pinched her lips and took a deep breath.

"There's one other set of photos you should see," Erin said at last.

"Erin..."

"Please," Erin said. "Indulge me."

"Fine."

The photos Erin retrieved were the ones that I took. Ones of Lucas picking up our duffle back. Proof that he'd blackmailed us. To Haley, they meant nothing.

"What am I looking at? Lucas out for a jog?"

"Does he normally take jogs around the Tidal Basin at night?"

"I still don't understand."

I stepped in. "Had you ever met Jo's boyfriend before last week? Arnold Johnson?"

Haley turned to me, unnerved by the sudden cross-examination, but when she answered, she wasn't lying. "No. Should I have?"

Erin reached out and took Haley's hands into hers. "Arnold Johnson is AJ," she said.

Haley switched back and forth, looking skittish. Trapped. "What? What are you guys talking about? Like, *AJ* AJ?"

"Yes. And your husband *does* know him. *This* is what you need to know, Haley. You may have thought you knew your husband, but it's so much worse. He blackmailed him. He blackmailed *us*. "

And we told her the whole story, from the beginning, all of our theories pouring out once again in hard, stark truth—and sounding just as far fetched. Yet we had those photos. We had Lucas Hughes collecting our cash and hiding it away at his company's warehouse.

When it was all told and we were caught up to our present predicament, when a silence so thick I couldn't breathe descended on the kitchen, I still had no idea how Haley would react. She could leave now and tell Lucas

everything. She could lose herself in a rage and confront Lucas with everything. Or she could do something more rational in between those two. I hoped she was feeling rational—at least a little.

“I don’t... I can’t...” She sighed. “It’s a lot to process.”

That was a good sign. She wasn’t immediately denying it, nor was she working herself up.

“Let me think this through, okay?” She stood, her chair screeching across our floor.

Erin looked at me. I saw the worry there. The fear. I felt it, too. She said, “Are you going to... Going to tell...?”

“No, I’m not going to tell Lucas.” She looked serene. “You’re planning something, aren’t you?”

This time, Erin didn’t look to me. “Yes, we are. We need to protect our family.”

“I understand,” Haley said. “I want in, for me and my children.”

Erin’s face split into a wide smile. “I was hoping you’d say that.”

The women hugged. Said they’d call. We watched her go in the quiet of our home. At last, I couldn’t help it. I put my arm around Erin. We stared out the window, where the night had already swallowed our neighbor.

“You see?” I said. “Nothing’s ever black and white.”

FOURTEEN

It was hard to sleep that night, for both of us. I kept running through the possibilities in my head: Haley telling Lucas; Haley murdering Lucas; Lucas coming over to our house and lighting it on fire. The scenario that I kept replaying—and the scariest because it was the most possible—was waking up in the morning to find Erin’s video available online for millions of viewers to see.

I heard Jo come in early in the morning, but I didn’t dare look at the clock. I didn’t want to know how long I’d been not sleeping, or how much longer I had to not sleep. She’d gone out last night, giving us space to talk to Haley. We hadn’t asked where, but I imagined it involved clubs and sex.

I buried my face in my pillow and searched for some kind of sleep.

Sleep must have come at some point, because the next thing I knew, Erin was getting out of bed and stiffly walking toward the bathroom. I got out, too, and went to my laptop. My heart raced. I felt sick to my stomach.

My inbox was filled with the usual stuff: junk mail, a couple alerts, some work updates. Nothing that said, “I posted a video of your slutty wife getting DP’ed, don’t ever mess with me again mother fucker!”

In fact, I couldn’t find any evidence that the video had been posted, but that didn’t mean much. If there was a seedy side of the Internet, I didn’t understand it beyond a couple subreddit’s and what I could turn up on a Google search. I found nothing when searching “Lamar Williamson sex tape” or “Lamar Williamson threesome”—nothing real, anyway, although I did find a few disturbing fakes—and breathed a sigh of relief.

I went downstairs, where Jo was making breakfast for the family. The children were still asleep. It was 7:30. How was she looking so bright and cheery?

“Have a good night?” I asked.

She smiled coyly. “Great one. How was yours? You look like you cleaned out your liquor cabinet.”

“I know, right? It’s not fair that I feel this shitty after just one glass of wine.”

Jo rose her eyebrows. “A swear word in the house. You really did have a rough night, Tom. Did it go that badly?”

“Actually, it went really well. Haley took it about as we’d expected. She was shocked, but it’s hard to deny. Deep down, she knew something was going on.”

Jo frowned, pouring a cup of coffee for me. “That must be hard for her. I’ve dated my fair share of jerks, but Lucas makes them all look like nice guys.”

“She came around in the end. I think she’s going to help us.”

Erin cleared her throat from the doorway. She had a sleepy Mary on her hip. “Not just help us,” Erin said. “She said she wants in on it.”

Jo clapped. “Excellent.”

*

The plan came together over the next couple weeks. We’d bought ourselves some time, although maybe it had always been in our heads. Lucas was alone in this operation, so that gave us some feeling of control.

Jo flew back to LA to take care of some things at work. I loved having her around, but it was also nice to have some space. I kept an eye on the trashy newsfeeds, setting up a Google alert for “Lamar Williamson sextape” just in case. It was amazing how much fan art that produced, but nothing real popped up.

Meanwhile, in public, as much as I hated it, Erin and I pretended we hit a rocky patch in our relationship. With an accomplice in Haley, she was able to sell it to our small group of friends, which in turn sold it to Lucas.

Lucas did show up a few times at Erin's gym, but just to flirt. He seemed to play her the same way AJ had, by taking it slow. Not surprising since that had been his own idea. If he had bought into the fiction that Erin was on the outs with me, then he also must have concluded that it had something to do with her deepening affection for AJ.

It was time to give him a little nudge.

"Hey man, what's up?" Lucas sounded surprised to hear from me.

"Is this a bad time? I can call back." The roar of music filled the space in between the words. Haley had said that he was covering a show up in Baltimore.

"Nah, man. It's fine." A moment later, the sound muted behind a closing door. "Go ahead."

"So remember when I saw you last month? At the playground?"

"Oh, right. How are things with you and Erin?" *Oh, right,* he seemed to say, *I forgot that I was pretending to be your friend.*

"Not great. Bad, actually."

I looked down at Erin, who was on her knees, wearing nothing but a pair of stockings. She'd insisted on making this difficult.

"Sorry to hear that," Lucas said. I heard it, but was slow to respond as Erin took my cock into her mouth. I bit back my groan. Lucas pressed on, misinterpreting my silence for grief. "You need me to help you with something? Want me to track down this guy? Have a little talk with him?"

I shook my head. "No, we're past that now. I need to catch her. Cheating."

Erin sucked down on me. I took a steadying breath.

"What are you thinking?" Lucas asked.

“Um...So...I told her that I’m headed out of town. Think you could get her to go out? Meet up at a club or something? Somewhere public. I want to watch her in the act, just to know for sure.”

“How far do you want me to take things?” I hated how lecherous he sounded. And I hated that it got me going, despite who this was.

“I don’t care,” I said, feeling a pit open up inside me, even though I knew this was all fake. “You want to fuck her...” Erin swallowed me into her throat at just that moment and I nearly moaned. “Go for it. We’re done.”

“Probably won’t, but I can push things if you want to see how far she’d go.”

You’d do that for me? I nearly said. “Whatever.”

“When?”

“This weekend. Sorry, it’s short notice.”

“Hey, no problem. I can make that work.”

Everything the man said sounded so disingenuous. “One other thing. Please don’t mention this to Haley, okay? Erin’s still pretty tight with her, and I wouldn’t want it to get back to her.”

“Of course, of course.”

I wondered if he would have if I hadn’t asked. Hard to say. “She’ll be at the gym tomorrow if you want to set it up,” I said. I looked down at Erin, who seemed to smile around my cock. “Thanks, man.”

“No worries. Sorry again.”

I hung up.

“It’s done.”

Erin pulled off of me, moving up into my lap. A moment later, she was sinking down on my cock. She wrapped her arms around my neck and looked me in the eyes. I expected her to say something, but she didn’t.

“What?” I asked.

She shook her head, but spoke anyway. “Just thinking about us. And where we are now. Where we may be next

week.”

“Free of Lucas.”

She smiled, but I didn’t think that was what she’d meant.

The days leading up to that Saturday felt like the lead up to a battle. I hadn’t felt this anxious since my confrontation with Brian Benoit with the New Orleans office. I wanted it to be here already, yet I never felt prepared. We went over the plan, the contingencies, the escape routes.

“It’s going to work,” Erin said, sounding like she was trying to convince herself as much as me. “It will.”

We had a hotel room reserved. We had small cameras and hidden mics. We made sure that Erin’s phone broadcast her location, and tested it over and over again.

Lucas took the bait. He’d met Erin at the gym and casually mentioned that he’d heard I was out of town next weekend. He mentioned Chic. She said that sounded fun. It could have sounded like a couple friends making plans were it not for their body language. Erin told me that when she’d put her hand on his arm and said that she couldn’t wait, he’d looked like he wanted to drag her into the showers right then and there.

“He actually did suggest that we go someplace private,” Erin said as she recounted the night. “He said something like, *Why wait?*”

“Lucas was never a patient guy.”

“Maybe he just wants to help you out more quickly,” Erin suggested.

“Such a good friend.”

We laughed.

He didn’t tell Haley about the encounter, or his plans to meet up with Erin on Saturday night. In fact, he told her that he was working a show down in Richmond and wouldn’t be home until Sunday morning.

Despite what we were about to do and the risks that came with it, I felt so incredibly close to my wife. I reflected

on the many stages of our relationship—not just the recent ones, with AJ and our hotwife adventures, but the whole of it. I thought about that first moment that we'd met and all I knew about her was through her eyes and her friendly demeanor. I thought about the dating period, when we explored everything from each other's hobbies to the things we liked to the way our bodies responded to one another's touch. We pulled out the old photos, laughing at Erin's blonde phase, to my long hair, to our wedding.

"We look so young," Erin said, pausing on a photo of the two of us, bride and groom. Erin wore her hair up and her shoulders bare. Her smile lightened my heart, even now.

There were the photos of her pregnant. Of us struggling to figure out how to raise a baby. Then two. Then toddlers. Then preschoolers. We transformed into our parents in the space of those photos. I got promoted. Then promoted again. We moved into our house.

And then there was the image of AJ and Erin on the dock. Things hadn't yet crossed their inevitable line, but we were well on our way.

"And this was all Lucas," I said bitterly.

Erin disagreed. "Let's not give him that much credit. Should we be thankful for your poor sense of dental hygiene? Otherwise, we'd never have met."

I held up my hands. "Hey, now. That was a routine cleaning."

"Doesn't change my statement about your dental hygiene. I mean, who doesn't floss?"

I rolled my eyes, laughing.

"Lucas got us here, but that's it. The rest of it was all us and our decisions. I mean, I'm pretty sure Lucas never anticipated what happened. He just wanted to ruin our marriage."

"That backfired."

Erin took me into her arms. "It did."

By the time Saturday arrived, I was both ready for this to be done and wondering if there was a way out of it. Jo flew into town Saturday morning and the two spent the day preparing. They went shopping. They went to the salon. They primped and preened as I reserved the hotel room and set it up as our live studio.

The plan was simple: lure Lucas back here and create a home movie so incriminating that we'd have leverage over him for the rest of his life. Jo, Haley, even AJ were on board to help. Lamar's presence would have been the icing on the cake, but he'd cut ties with AJ already. Not that he would have been up for anything that involved video, ever again, even if it was intended to be used for good.

Once the hotel room was wired up, I stopped by Callahan's for a final drink. I wasn't expecting AJ to be there, although I was still disappointed when he wasn't. But his bartender friend, Max, was.

"What can I get for you, friend?" Max was friendly in the way all bartenders were friendly.

"I'll take a bourbon. Something expensive."

He pulled a bottle of Woodford's down and filled a lowball. "We celebrating? Or mourning something?"

I said, "Can I get back to you tomorrow? I'll have a better answer then."

Max leaned back against the liquor cabinet and folded his arms. "Ah, so this is fortitude you're drinking."

"Something like that."

Max nodded. "Can I ask you something?"

"Sure."

"Would you consider the thing you're about to do stupid?"

I scratched my cheek, feeling scruff. I hadn't shaved in a few days. Maybe longer. "Stupid?" I said, trying the word out. "No, not exactly stupid. Necessary, maybe?"

Max seemed fine with that response. I wondered how much he knew about what was happening. He certainly

knew AJ. He'd also overheard our confrontation with the man. He said, "You're going into it with your eyes wide open?"

"Maybe for the first time," I answered.

"Good luck, then. And if you ever want to talk, I may have some experience in the matter."

He left me alone after that, knowing that I wasn't ready to talk. Not yet. But it did get me thinking more. AJ had alluded to this guy and his wife—the stacked redhead. I'd never really considered other guys sharing my fantasy, although I knew that there were plenty out there. I'd just never met one. Maybe some advice would have kept us out of trouble. At the very least, we wouldn't have fumbled around in the dark for quite so long.

But that was done. Or would be tonight, anyway.

I finished up my drink, left a generous tip, and started on to beginning of the end.

OceanofPDF.com

FIFTEEN

"How do I look?" Erin said.

We were sitting in an espresso bar around the corner from Chic, late on a Friday night. I was already half-way through my second cappuccino. I thought I'd need the caffeine to stay awake. I hadn't counted on the adrenaline pouring through my bloodstream.

I glanced at Erin's mini-dress. She wore it well—so different from the last time she'd gone out to Chic all those months ago. She'd been awkward then. Now, her confidence glowed brighter than the shimmering turquoise mini. The party dress was tiny and tight, leaving nothing to the imagination: not her long legs, not her narrow waist, certainly not the way her perfectly formed breasts spilled out of the outrageous push-up bra that she wore. She had a killer body, and this dress did everything that it could to showcase it.

"You look like a tramp," I said with a smile.

"Perfect."

I said, "Nothing about this plan is perfect."

"It's your plan!" Erin retorted.

"Our plan, you mean?"

"Ours, yes. And it'll be fine." Her strappy heels gave her enough height that when she stepped close, she could almost look me in the eyes. The thought of her this close to that snake Lucas churned my stomach. "We talked about this. It's the only way."

"I still don't like it. I don't trust that guy."

"I don't trust him, either, but you need to trust me," Erin said.

"I do."

"You know I love you," Erin said.

"Of course I do. And I really do trust you. But Lucas is smart. What if he figures something's up?"

She was close enough that I could smell her perfume—perfume that would tantalize Lucas all night. I touched her face. She looked gorgeous. The thought of her dancing in his arms, of his hands wandering, was painful.

And intensely erotic.

Erin felt it, too, her hand brushing against the seat of my pants. She smiled knowingly. "Even with the betrayal, huh? You're a complicated man, Tommy."

"I can't help it, but—"

"Don't worry. I'm not going to make that mistake again." She wasn't going to fuck him. She wouldn't have, even if she didn't hate him just as much as I did. "But I may need to make him think that he has a chance."

I nodded. "Yes, we went over that." I steeled myself. "I'll be fine."

She studied me carefully under her smoky eyes and dark eyeliner. "By the end of the night, you're going to see me at my naughtiest. And I've already done some pretty naughty things. Think about that, rather than Lucas." She squeezed my cock, checking that I was hard—I was—and took a step back. "Time for me to get going. Wish me luck." She kissed me softly. "And good luck on your part."

I watched her wind her way through the espresso bar, her ass swaying in that short dress, headed off to entertain my arch nemesis. I finished my cappuccino, wondering if I'd be able to deal with tonight.

Jo and Aj would be at the hotel room that connected to the one where Erin would take Lucas. They were the safety net if I couldn't follow right behind my wife. We'd tried to convince Haley to wait there, too, but she insisted on staying with me at the club. Said that she needed to see this for herself.

We placed a lot of faith in our read. If Haley was working in concert with her husband to betray us, she had

everything that she needed to do so. On the other hand, if she wasn't, then she had just as much motivation for revenge as we did. I couldn't decide if I was jittery from what we were about to do, or the espressos. Probably a little of both.

I gave Erin a fifteen-minute head start, then followed her around the corner where the line waited.

The line took close to a half hour to get through—a nerve-racking half hour. Especially since I watched the bouncer walk the line and invite all the attractive women to the front. I did a quick scan and didn't see Erin anywhere. That meant that she had up to forty minutes of time alone in what amounted to a glossy meat market.

My gut was doing flips by the time I got up to the front and paid the exorbitant entrance fee. The wall of sound that enveloped me didn't help calm me.

I'd never been to Chic, but it lived up to my expectations. It reminded me of my early twenties, including the sheen that nostalgia would have put on it. Black lights and lasers filled the loud space as a sea of dancers undulated in the punctuated dark. It smelled of dry ice and perfume over a wash of sweat and spilled booze.

This wasn't a DC bar or club, but that was probably why it was so popular. This was a rave for the thirty-something crowd that used to go to raves and wanted to relive their past. I felt instantly old, even if I wasn't. Like an imposter. Only thing that kept me here was Erin, somewhere out there in the crowd.

The main room of the club filled more than two stories of warehouse space, the second story ringing the main floor where people could chill and people watch. I beelined for the stairs, stopping at the second floor bar to get a Jack and Coke. Then, I went to work searching for Erin.

In addition to the dance floor and long, brightly lit bar, Chic featured a row of booths along the back that could be curtained off for added privacy—booths you paid for by

ordering overpriced bottles of liquor, and were available only after a long wait. My stomach cratered at the thought of her already being back in one of those hidden places, even though I knew she'd not let herself be dragged back there.

I powered through my drink without even tasting it, and was about to go get another when I spotted Haley standing about twenty feet from me, also leaning on the rail and searching the crowd. As if sensing me, she turned and smiled.

I barely recognized her, and it wasn't just that she looked stunning in a way that I wasn't used to from the blonde. It was that she wasn't blonde anymore. Her tousled hair fell in loose ringlets of spun copper that complimented her orange and red cocktail dress. If she hadn't smiled at me, I wouldn't have recognized her.

When she pushed away from the rail and sauntered over to me, she moved with liquid grace. I stirred, and for entirely different reasons than anxiety. This was a different woman than the one who usually sported a cardigan and blouse combo, who knew how to make space-themed playdough and liked to serve her meals with place mats that matched her napkins.

She didn't stop beside me—we weren't supposed to be together—but she did run her fingers across my shoulders. "By the bar, close side," she said as she passed.

I watched her pass, lingering on her legs and ass, hugged tightly by that short dress. Then blinked and looked where she'd instructed me—and sure enough, there was Erin. My breath caught. She wasn't with Lucas, but she *was* chatting with a handsome guy who looked like he'd stepped off of the pages of GQ. They had to lean close to be heard, whispering into one another's ears. My chest tightened, and when she laughed at whatever he said, it tightened some more.

She leaned closer, resting her hand on his arm as she spoke. He grinned, nodded, and finished his drink in a hurry. She laughed at him, took him by the hand, and guided him onto the dance floor.

Fuck, I was hard.

-She's got so much confidence.

The text came from Haley, who'd made it all the way around to the other side of the balcony.

-I wish I could do that.

I texted back:

-You can

And then added:

-You are.

She looked up at me, meeting my eyes across the vast space, and smiled slightly. She could have anyone she wanted. It was hard to believe that she didn't know that already. I slipped my phone into my jeans and went to the bar to refresh my drink.

The crowd had built up here, and I nearly abandoned my pursuit of the drink. I didn't like being away from a clear view of Erin. Every second away felt like I was being stretched across a rack. When I did make it back, Erin was with a new guy—a tall black dude about a foot taller than her.

The guy leaned in and whispered something to her. She rolled her eyes, then reached out and squeezed his bicep, nodding. That made me laugh. This guy just lost his chance to make it onto the dance floor.

I pulled my phone out to share the moment with Haley when I found a text waiting for me. From Lucas.

-here

The tension sprung back. I found him below, standing near the entrance and searching the second floor. The crowd broke around him like waves against a jetty. When his eyes passed over the spot where Haley stood, I held my breath, and only released it when he'd passed right by her, finally settling on me. I nodded, playing it cool, then directed my head toward Erin.

Lucas grinned, nodded back, and made his way over to her. I watched it unfold with a helplessness that I hated. Part of me wanted to stop it—needed to stop it. But I couldn't. I shouldn't. I *wouldn't*. We were going to do this. It was the only way.

Lucas arrived at Erin and her current suitor. As soon as Erin spotted him, her face lit up with surprise so real that it churned my belly with jealousy. She turned away from Mr. Biceps, dismissing him as surely as a shutting door, and threw her arms around Lucas. This was worse than I'd anticipated.

When I thought back to the birthday night and the disaster that it had turned into, I always remembered the sex first, the way Lucas fucked my wife, the way Haley gave Erin her first bisexual experience, and the moment I'd stormed out when I couldn't take it anymore. Those were significant things because they marked a turning point.

But before all of that, there had been the birthday night itself. The way Lucas had charmed the group. The way he and Erin had danced at that basement club—a couple with a secret, and me watching it go down and being turned on by it.

Watching Lucas pull Erin onto the dance floor stirred up all those uncomfortable emotions. She seemed to feign reluctance, tipping her head down so her hair fell over her eyes. Her smile was small, playful. A smile like that only encourages a man like Lucas.

He pulled her to him with a firm hand on the small of her back, the other riding her hip. He said something, and

Erin looked up at him, shaking her hair from her face. Their eyes met, deep enough that I squirmed.

When I raised my drink to my lips, only ice rattled against my teeth. I frowned into it, glanced over at the bar, and saw that even more people had discovered it. In fact, the whole of the second story was filling up as dancers took their breaks and couples transitioned into the flirting and hooking up stages of the night.

No way was I taking my eyes off of Lucas down there. I tipped a couple cubes of ice into my mouth.

Lucas had both hands on Erin's hips, his fingers spreading out across her ass. Even I didn't know what kind of underwear she had on beneath, but now Lucas did.

I ground the ice cubes into water between my molars.

When he moved his hands over her ass, Erin smoothly turned away, pressing her shoulders into his chest and her ass against his crotch. She looked over her shoulder at him, mouthing, *Naughty boy*.

Whatever he whispered back to her caused her to gasp and smile. To the whole world down there, they were just another couple, getting close. She was just a hot chick in a tiny dress, and he was a guy looking to get lucky. To me, it was like dynamite.

I looked for Haley once again, wondering how she felt. She was still positioned where she had been before, although a guy was standing next to her now, chatting her up. The urge to help her out was nearly overwhelming. She lacked the confidence to dismiss him like the new Erin down there would, but she held her own. She'd been an attractive woman her whole life; she couldn't have been a stranger to some pickup lines.

Still, I sent her a short text:

-need help?

I watched as she felt the buzz of my text come in, glancing at the phone quickly before darkening it. She didn't

reply right away, but she did shake her head. *No, I'm fine*, she seemed to say. When she spoke to the guy again, she seemed more relaxed. She flirted more. And watching that set my own blood racing.

When I looked back down at the dance floor, though, all thought of Haley fled. Strobes lights turned the dance floor into a stop-motion film. The dancers undulated in jerky skips, like I was blinking my eyes too quickly. Erin and Lucas were facing one another again, dancing close, closer, and then...kissing. Deep, hard, passionate kissing.

I swooned on the railing. My stomach flipped and fizzed. I shut my eyes, but the image of Lucas's mouth covering Erin's remained. She's just playing with him. She's just reeling him in. This was a necessary evil.

I didn't think the mantra would help, but when I opened my eyes and found them still making out in the middle of all that humanity, the fog of jealousy and horror had lifted—if just a little. It was that moment in a nightmare when you realize it's all just a dream. The events still unfolded, but the impact of them was blunted.

No, that wasn't quite right. Knowing where I stood now, as opposed to all those months ago during Erin's 34th, let me do something I wasn't able to do back then: embrace it. Here was Erin, sheathed in a dress that belonged in the LA club scene, in the arms of a good looking asshole who'd do almost anything to fuck her, and she was mine. She'd always be mine, no matter what.

Breaking the kiss, it was Lucas who made the suggestion. *Let's get out of here*. It was unmistakable, especially since he had to shout it over the noise. Erin looked up at him, her eyes bright and full of lust. Things squirmed inside of me before I reminded myself that it was all a game. She wasn't really going to fuck him.

She nodded. I sucked down the last few ice cubes and grabbed my phone.

-Time to go

Haley checked her phone and turned to the guy who'd been trying so hard. I felt bad for the guy, but only for a second. Down in the main room, Lucas was pulling Erin through the crowd. She trailed long enough to look up at the second floor, find me, and mouth, *I love you*.

Watching her go was one of the hardest things I'd ever done. Every atom in my body seemed to urge me to follow, to throw myself in front of them and halt the charade. Somehow, I composed myself, clutching the railing like I was trying to splinter it between my fingers.

"You ready?" Haley asked, snapping me from my trance. Erin and Lucas were long gone.

"Yes."

She put her hand on mine. I relaxed my grip. "It's going to be okay," she said. "Your friends will be right next to them."

Jo and AJ—my friends. Jo was, certainly, but I wondered how AJ would feel about that assessment. She was right, though, they'd be there. Erin was safe.

"Where did you park?" I asked.

"Four blocks away. This place is crazy."

I nodded. Saturday nights in the city could get crazy. I was impressed that she'd found street parking at all. We walked out into the night, thankful that it was mild for April.

"You sober enough to drive?" I asked.

"Am. Although part of me wishes that I wasn't." She laughed ruefully. "How are you doing? That's not...easy to watch."

"No, it's not." We walked a few steps before I realized that that wasn't a great answer. "I'm okay."

Haley didn't contradict me, although I could almost hear the skepticism in her clicking heels along the pavement. It wasn't her way to call things out. She'd gone her whole

marriage without doing that, and Lucas certainly never encouraged it.

I sighed. "What? Go ahead and say it," I said.

"Nothing. Just..." She slipped her hand into mine, our fingers entwining. "You're not alone, you know. I feel the same way."

"And how's that?"

"Betrayed. Angry. Sick to my stomach." As she spoke, I felt both relief and anxiety. "Afraid," she added.

"You're afraid?" I asked.

"Yes. Not for the same reasons as you, but...I don't know what happens next. Where do I go from here? I have Andy. And I'm not letting that man raise Paige—not that I think that he wants to."

I stopped, feeling embarrassed by my own fears. What she was saying, without saying it—or even intending to suggest it—was that while I had Erin to work through this, she was alone. I pulled her into my arms and held her close. She felt tiny.

"You'll get through it," I said, stroking her hair. "We'll get through it. You're not alone. You've got me and Erin. We'll figure this out."

She pulled back, staring up at me. Her eyes shimmered under the yellow street lamps. Her bow-shaped lips, painted red, turned up with the hint of a smile—the first real, genuine smile that I'd seen from her in long time, I realized. Even when she'd been happy, had she really been happy?

"Get a room, you two," shouted someone from a passing car.

I'm not sure who started laughing first, but after the seriousness of the last few minutes, the laughter felt good.

"Shall we go get a room?" I asked, raising a brow.

Haley chuckled. "I think we have one already."

I pulled out my phone as we found her car at the end of the block. It chirped as she unlocked the car. I loaded the Find My Phone app, locating Erin's phone. I stared at the

GPS dot as it sailed out of the city—away from the hotel. I stopped breathing. The sounds of Saturday night faded until all I could hear was the muffled beat of my racing heart.

“They’re not going to the hotel,” I said. The fear felt like ice water slowly dripping down my spine. I looked up at Haley, who stood across the car on the driver’s side. “Where is Lucas’s office?”

“In Bethesda, why?”

“Bethesda, Maryland?”

Haley drew a breath that she didn’t release. “Why?”

I responded with the address where Lucas had brought the money. The place registered under Lucas Security. “Does that mean anything to you? Have you ever been there?”

“What? No. Why?”

“Has Lucas ever mentioned going out to Reston? For work?”

“Not that I can recall. Why, Tom? You’re scaring me.”

I tried to make sense of it. I couldn’t. “I’m scaring myself, but...” I looked at the app. The dot was further away, and definitely headed toward that building. “I think I know where they’re going, and it’s definitely not to a hotel.”

OceanofPDF.com

SIXTEEN

The blip that marked Erin's phone eventually stopped exactly where I thought it would stop: right over the location that the money had been taken. We were twenty minutes away, but in the moment, we may as well have been on the other side of the world. So much could happen before we got there. So many bad things. I pinched the bridge of my nose and tried not to think about it.

I texted Jo.

*-Change of plans. They're going somewhere else.
Will send you the address. Bring one of the cameras.*

I pressed *send*, then looked at Haley, who was tearing down I-66. She'd discarded her red wig and was back to her sweet, blond self. The thought did occur to me that she'd betrayed us. It was hard to believe, but my imagination was getting a lot of practice. Lucas could have gotten wind of the hotel sting, but then why engage with Erin at all? The man was a lot of things, but I was pretty sure he wasn't a murderer.

-What's going on?

Jo's text broke through my thoughts.

-Don't know. They're going somewhere else.

That, right there, was the truth.

-AJ wants to know if he'll get to punch something.

I laughed.

-long as it's not me

It felt good to laugh, even if it was just along the surface.

"They're coming?" Haley asked.

"On the way." I leaned back into the seat and stared up through the moonroof. The stars shone down through the light pollution of the city, barely moving. Even that made me impatient. I looked away.

"He's not going to...do anything," Haley said, her voice was small.

I looked at her suspiciously, then immediately felt guilty for it. "How do you know?"

"I've been with him for a long time. He's self-centered and an opportunist, but he's not cruel. Not the way you're thinking."

"And yet he had you fooled," I said with more bite than I'd intended.

"No, he didn't. Maybe about specifics, but none of what you've told me is a surprise. Not really. I just...wished that it wasn't true."

I checked my phone every five seconds, staring at that GPS dot. It had stopped moving, now that they were inside. I wondered what that meant. I wondered—

It buzzed. A text. With a photo. From *Lucas's* phone. Fear seized me. I opened it up.

-Sorry to report that your wife is a total whore

My gut churned. The image was of Erin standing in the doorway, the room behind her cast in shadows, wearing nothing but a black push-up bra and a tiny pair of panties. She smiled wryly into the camera, as if on the verge of rolling her eyes.

"What?" Haley asked. "What is it?"

I looked behind Erin's figure, into the room, and my breath caught.

"So you've never been out here?" I asked.

"Never. Why? What do you see?"

I pinched and zoomed in on those shadows. The walls hung with darkened instruments and a hulking frame

dangled with chains. “Looks like Lucas set up a sex dungeon.”

Haley opened her mouth, but no words came out. Instead, she pressed down on the accelerator and gunned it around the car in front of us.

As crazy as it sounded, part of me felt relief at the photo. It meant that Lucas was still clueless, and that Erin wasn’t being assaulted. Not yet, anyway. The restraints behind her added a sense of urgency to our trip.

“We need to get there now,” I said, feeling panic press in around me.

“Trying.”

The lot was empty except for Lucas’s SUV, looking as menacing as a loaded gun. We parked right next to it, not caring about discretion anymore. This wasn’t a game we were playing anymore. Suddenly, everything was very, soberingly real.

I looked wild-eyed at Haley as we raced out of the car and up to the metal doors. The two, windowless doors were closed, looking more like a back entrance to a club than the main ones. It occurred to me that the doors were probably locked, and if they were, I wasn’t sure what to do about that. And that got me thinking that I had no real plan any longer. I just wanted to get in there and save my wife, and I approached the problem with the single-mindedness of a caged animal throwing itself against the bars until it bled.

I reached for one of the doors, fully expecting it to hold firm. I nearly fell down when I yanked and it swung open silently. It was dark through the doors, and smaller than I’d expected. The building was two stories high, so I figured it would be open like a warehouse. Instead, it was closer to an extended, two car garage, minus the cars. Emergency lights hinted at the storage of things that went into the security business—wire barricades, large orange cones, silver crates covered in shipping labels. I could see all the way to the

back wall, bare cinder blocks covered in more stuff. No sign of Erin or Lucas or the room from the photo.

Haley pointed at a door off to the side. I nodded and we crept through, careful to knock anything loud on the way.

The door opened to a staircase, leading up to the second floor. As soon as we stepped into the well, we heard them, their voices distant, echoing in from above.

It was Lucas, his laughter haughty. I ground my teeth, realizing that I'd already curled my hands into fists. "That's good—"

His voice cut off in a groan. My gut tightened. My jealousy tasted like copper.

"You like that?" Erin's question was as silky as a caress. "You surprise me, Lucas."

His voice came tight. "I'm a man of surprises."

"You like a challenge, don't you?" I could feel Erin's confidence rise. "For a man who likes to be so in control, it turns you on to give up a little...control."

Lucas filled the gap between *little* and *control* with a sharp grunt.

"Don't you?" Erin sounded almost cruel, the question delivered like a lash.

"If you think you're going to turn me into some kind of wimp like your husband, think again—mmph."

"That's better."

We made it to the top of the stairwell. The second story door was open, and the hallway stretched to the left and right, down the length of the building. The clicking of Erin's heels came from the left, the back of the building, away from the parking lot. I recognized the blue-painted door frame at the end of the hall from the photo that Erin had sent me. We'd arrived.

"Now, I told you I had an extra naughty surprise for you tonight, didn't I?" Click, click, click. "Ta da. This is going to be fun."

I could hear his muffled protests. I waited to hear Erin cry out, ready to rush into the room and throw him off of her. I heard the groan of something bend but not give, a grunt from Lucas, and my own beating heart grow faster and louder, but no cry for help. So we kept on sneaking.

"That's it, it needs to be softer for this to get on. Yes, good." Erin was using her proud mom voice, distinct because it was so incongruous with what I imagined was happening in there. Lucas must have hated it.

"There. Good, *little* boy. You follow instructions so well."

I had no clue what I was about to walk in on. We were so wildly off script now.

"Let me just take a photo of this, to document..." More muffles. "Perfect. Very smoldery, Lucas."

A message buzzed in my palm, and when I glanced at it, it was a photo from inside the room. Lucas was strapped to something that I wasn't quite sure what to call. The metal frame forced him into a bent pose, his arms out wide and his neck cinched tight, and his legs spread wide beneath. A...stockade of some sort, only sexualized.

Lucas's brow hung low and heavy as he stared into the camera, eyes filled with rage—the look turned more submissive by the black gag tied around his mouth, and more vulnerable considering that he was naked.

On his cock was...another thing that I didn't recognize. It was a clear, plastic sleeve that was held in place by some straps around his thighs and waist.

Haley, looking over my shoulders, covered her mouth to stifle a laugh as soon as she saw it. Erin texted a moment later.

-Think he likes his cock cage?

I looked at the photo again, that plastic sleeve taking on an entirely new meaning. Haley whispered, "Guess she doesn't need saving. Should we join them?"

I took Haley's hand, and together, we stepped into the doorway.

Lucas saw us first. His eyes went wide, his brow went up, and when he sucked in a breath through his nose, he seemed to take the air from the room with it.

Erin turned, pleased to see us standing there. She was still wearing the bra and panties, still in her heels, but she'd tied her hair into a long, high ponytail that, in this setting, turned her into a dominatrix.

"So actually," Erin said, looking back at Lucas, "this was my surprise. Surprised?"

Lucas pulled against the restraints until his face turned red, but they held fast.

Erin strolled over to a rack on the wall, where a number of cruel looking instruments hung. She picked up a riding crop and flexed it between her hands, testing it out. Lucas barely noticed. He was looking at his wife, pleading with her to help him out. Erin ignored it. So did Haley.

"You see, Lucas, we know all about your manipulation...husband of mine." She circled around behind him. "At first, I was pretty upset. We all were. We wanted to hurt you."

With the flick of her wrist, she whipped the riding crop against Lucas's ass. His eyes went wide. He pulled harder at the restraints.

This time, Erin was gentler with the crop, tracing it over his body, around his nipples and down his flat stomach. "We learned all about it from your friend, AJ. How you like the idea of watching your wife with other men. Such a naughty, *naughty* man."

When Erin moved across the room to us, she exaggerated the swing of her hips, crossing one foot in front of the other. Her serpentine ponytail flicked from shoulder to shoulder. This woman was so achingly sexy.

When she reached us, she held her arms out to us and smiled. "And here we are, with your wife and another man."

I almost felt sorry for Lucas. He looked so miserable, chained up there, gagged and caged. It wasn't hard to remind myself how we arrived at this situation, though. Erin drew me against her, kissing me deeply. "You made it," she said when she pulled away.

"Of course. Nervous?"

She glanced back at Lucas. "For about a second. But I figured out how to get things under control."

"I see that."

Erin turned to Haley. "We have enough right now, I think. If you want to stop."

Haley looked at her, eyes wide and uncertain. She licked her lips nervously, glancing at me quickly before looking back at my wife. Erin interpreted Haley's unspoken statement and smiled brightly.

"You don't want to stop," she said.

Haley shook her head.

Erin reached out and touched Haley's cheek. Electricity hummed between them. I watched as, inches away, Erin leaned in and kissed the other woman. This wasn't the first time I'd witnessed these two kiss, but this time, everything was different. Back then, no matter how hot the situation was, it was weighed down by this sense of wrongness. We never should have been there in the first place.

I wanted to be here now. We all wanted to here.

Short of Lucas.

But fuck him.

I moved into position behind Haley, kissing her shoulders as Erin deepened the girl-on-girl makeout session. She smelled good. Felt so different than Erin. She was a slip of a woman, but still a *woman*, with womanly moans and womanly tastes, and when she broke her kiss with Erin and kissed me over her shoulder, womanly desires.

"There's a bed here," Erin said. She sounded like she was on the brink of a giggle.

I said, "How convenient. Should we thank Lucas?"

“Let’s thank his wife,” Erin said. “I like her so much better.”

She took Haley’s hand and we moved together to the bed, which I hadn’t noticed until now. It wasn’t positioned front-and-center to Lucas, but he didn’t have to turn his head much to see. Whether he was or not? Well, I didn’t care much about that, either.

Not when Erin turned to Haley and lifted her dress off. Not when she put a hand on the back of her neck and kissed her again. Certainly not when the two women tumbled to the bed, long limbs tangled, their lips never leaving one another for long. Erin wound up on top, her knee pressed in between Haley’s thighs as Haley’s fingers played across her shoulder blades.

Another difference from the last time they’d played—Erin was so much more comfortable with another woman. I took a seat on the edge of the bed as she kissed down Haley’s body, down between her legs, over the soft rise of another woman’s panty-clad pussy. She flashed a smile back at me, as if reading my thoughts, before pulling Haley’s thong off.

If Erin took her time, it wasn’t out of hesitation. She looked up at Haley as she drew tight circles across the other woman’s clit, drawing out the seduction. Haley tossed her hair back, moaning softly as she watched.

I watched, too, feeling something more than arousal. I was...impressed. Here was a woman who knew how to handle herself—and she seemed to enjoy that fact almost as much as the sex.

Erin lowered her head between Haley’s thighs and licked her pussy.

I stripped out of my shirt and pants, glancing across at Lucas only once. Murder burned in his eyes. I looked down at the cock cage, the hard plastic designed to direct any erection painfully downward. Again, I felt a moment of

compassion for the guy. Again, all it took was a reminder of what he'd done, and what he'd do to ruin us.

I tossed my jeans off the bed and crawled up to Haley. She looked from Erin to me. Her smile felt warm beneath her sultry eyes. She was the one who reached out and took my head in her hand. She was the one to smile at me in the final moment before our lips came together. She was the one to kiss me.

And what a kiss it was.

Felt like we'd been dancing around this moment for so long, the attraction building like a kettle set on a stove and forgotten. As soon as our lips met, all of that pressure came rushing out. The passion rose around us like steam, scalding and screaming and so fucking desperate to escape. She kissed differently than Erin or Jo, softer, more sensual, somehow both submissive and demanding.

Still working between her thighs, Erin reached up and pushed Haley's bra up over her tits. I broke our kiss, moving down to her left breast as Erin climbed up and attacked her right. Haley gasped, spurring us on.

When Erin spoke, her voice with thick and husky. "She's so wet. Feel."

My wife pulled my hand down between the other woman's thighs—which was almost as exciting as feeling Haley's sex for the first time. And Erin was right, she was so wet. I followed her narrow landing strip down to her pussy, and easily slid two fingers deep inside. Haley cried out at the penetration.

Erin lifted an eyebrow in pride. I kissed her, tasting another woman on her lips.

"I got her nice and ready for you," Erin said when we separated. "Ready to fuck our sweet neighbor?"

I tore my boxers off so fast that Erin giggled. It was Erin who placed me at the entrance of Haley's pussy. It was Erin who rubbed my cockhead along the blonde's shaven lips.

But it was me who thrust forward, burying myself to the root in one, wet drive.

Haley came alive beneath me. She wrapped her legs around my waist and dug her heels in. I felt her nails in my back, clawing and encouraging. Feeling Haley after all these years was exhilarating.

Erin watched for a couple moments, swinging her eyes up to Lucas. "How's it feel, Lucas? You're now a cuckold! A big, wimpy cuckold." She lifted her phone. "Say cheese!"

I didn't look over my shoulder, but I heard him moan in outrage through the gag. Erin slid back further on the bed so that she could capture me with Haley in the frame, with Lucas behind us.

Erin said, "How about some video? Now don't hold back, you two. We know how much Lucas enjoys this."

I hadn't been holding back. Not with the way Haley's body seemed to crave my thrusts. The line was more for the video. For the setup. But I took up the challenge anyway. Lifting Haley's knees up over my shoulders, I folded her into the bed and fucked her harder than I was normally comfortable with.

"Oh, so good, Tom!" Haley cried. "Your cock feels...so good."

"Better than your husband?" I spat.

"So much better. So much...ah...*bigger!*"

This wasn't true, I knew, but the video we were concocting was hardly truth. We needed to create an illusion that Lucas wouldn't be able to stomach if it ever got out. Attacking his ego was the surest way to do that.

I drew on the greatest inspiration that I had—AJ. What would AJ do? Pulling out of her, I sawed my shaft along her velvet lips. "Whose pussy is this?" I demanded. I didn't dare to look toward Erin. I wasn't sure I could have kept my composure.

"Yours...yours..." She moaned. "Please... don't stop."

I used the crown of my cock to rub her clit. She writhed beneath me. I said, “Don’t stop what?”

“Fucking me. Fucking my married pussy!”

It was an act, yes, but nevertheless I felt my chest swell and my veins fill with adrenaline. I set my cock against her, stared down into her eyes, and rammed home again. She rocked her head back, teeth clenched, nostrils flared, and screamed.

I didn’t hold back. Even if I wanted to, I couldn’t have. I pounded her pussy until my abs burned and my arms protested. I fucked her as my orgasm raged through me, throwing off the last traces of tenderness. We weren’t making love. We were *fucking*. And we were both going to lose our minds in it.

“I want your come,” Haley gasped. “I want to feel it inside me. I want it. Want. It!”

“You sure?”

“Fuck, yeah!” Haley shouted. “Watch me, Lucas! This is what you wanted, right? To watch me get fucked by another man? Is it everything you ever dreamed?”

I barely heard the taunts. I was so far gone. Each thrust pushed me closer to release, closer to the end of it all.

“Do it, Tom. Come. Come. Right. Now!”

I shut my eyes as everything blurred away—everything but the wet, shivering sensation of Haley’s pussy along my shaft. I sank as deep as I could go, grabbed her ankles, and exploded inside of her.

SEVENTEEN

At first, I thought the clapping was in my head—an imagined audience for one of the hottest performances of my life. But when I looked up, AJ was leaning against the doorframe, his meaty hands clapping together.

“That was hot, you two,” he said in that deep voice of his. He looked at Lucas, his smile twisting into something cruel. “You like that, bro?”

Lucas’s eyes went wide at the sight of AJ, a man he’d been deceiving for possibly over a year. AJ whipped his shirt off, baring his muscled torso, tattooed and mean. “You ain’t seen shit yet.”

He took a step toward Lucas, and incredibly, the big man shied away. AJ chuckled.

“Naw, man, I’m not going to hurt you. Not physically.” He paused, then added, “Probably won’t, anyway.”

AJ turned and walked to the corner, where a sex swing hung from the ceiling. “Interesting setup you have here. Mind if I try some of it out?” He laughed. “No, I didn’t think you would.”

I slipped out of Haley, the tension in the air shifting from sexual to something bordering on violent. I felt like I was holding my breath, even though I wasn’t. I looked at Erin, who smiled. She, at least, seemed okay with this.

“Hello, Haley. We met once before, but let me introduce myself. I’m AJ. And you’re... *Lucas’s* wife.”

Haley nodded, suddenly looking in over her head.

AJ tugged on the sex swing. “Ever been on one of these?”

She shook her head.

“Lukie there not share this side of himself with you? Such a shame. From what Erin tells me, you’re the kind of woman who likes being told what to do.” He smiled. “I just

happen to be the kind of guy who likes telling people what to do.”

I wasn't entirely convinced of Erin's assessment of Haley. Haley had married Lucas, and while she did possessive a submissive streak, she knew who Lucas was. It was so easy to think of her as wide-eyed and naive, but she was no more that than her husband was a saint.

So when AJ tightened one fist around the sex swing and held the other out to Haley, I knew exactly how this was about to play out.

AJ said, “Let's give it a try.”

Haley rose. She looked at Lucas, strapped to his stockade and looking outraged. Her jaw set. Her eyes hardened. “Let's,” she said. “I've always wondered what my husband did on those nights when he'd disappear.”

AJ grinned, his hands going to his jeans. He put his hands on his fly and opened his pants. “First things first, though...”

Haley went to him on her knees, freeing the monster of a cock from the tight confines of his boxers. I'd seen photos before, I'd watched video, but I'd never been so close. Haley's hand looked tiny as she wrapped it around his girth.

AJ placed a hand on Haley's head, guiding her as she began bobbing along his length. “That's it, babe. Show Lukie how you suck cock.”

AJ looked at ease being blown in a room filled with an audience. He looked around at us, smiling, relaxed. “Hey, babe, want to help her out?”

At first, I thought that he was talking to Erin. Then Jo stepped further into the room—Jo, who I'd completely forgotten about. Jo, who'd stripped down to a pair of metallic tipped heels. Jo, who approached AJ with a familiarity that was more than casual.

Haley took her mouth off AJ long enough to watch Jo sink down to her knees beside her. “Hello, again,” Jo whispered. “I'm Jo.”

And with that, she kissed the blonde swiftly, pulled back, and swallowed AJ's cock in one fluid motion. Haley watched, enraptured, as Jo's spit mixed with her own. Then the curly haired blonde released him, pointing his cock back at Haley. Haley didn't hesitate, taking him into her mouth with some of the enthusiasm that Jo demonstrated.

Jo kissed down the exposed length, her eyes following me the whole way, before eventually dropping low and swallowing his smoothly shaved balls.

"Fuck, that's good," AJ said. Any hesitation out of Haley was gone as she started enthusiastically working AJ. The women switched off, Haley going to work on AJ's sac as Jo took a shocking amount of cock down her throat.

"Pretty naughty, don't you think?" asked Erin. She was up again, this time armed with a camcorder on a tripod. She placed it behind Lucas, pointed to capture the action in the corner, by the swing. "You like to watch, right?"

Erin caressed Lucas's ass, and even though I knew it was all for show, jealousy rippled up my spine. She leaned close. "You're lucky. You get to watch all of us take turns with her. How special."

AJ stopped the two before he exploded. "Time to hop up in the swing," he said to Haley. "I've never used one of these. Should be fun."

AJ helped Haley into the swing, which was not much more than a couple straps that fit around her thighs, stirrups for her feet, and a couple bars to hold her up. The effect, though, left her exposed to all of us, her pretty pussy open wide. AJ stepped in, cock in hand, and grinned down at her.

"I'm going to have to get me one of these," he said. Then, without further ado, pressed his cock deep into Haley's cunt.

Erin, still next to Lucas, said, "That cock cage starting to hurt?"

It didn't look like he had an erection at all—and his face still burned with rage—but the camera wouldn't know. All

the camera saw was his naked ass and the awkwardness of his pose in the stockade.

"I'd help you out, but I'm going to go over there and fuck my husband. Sorry." She didn't even try to sound genuine.

Left alone, Lucas watched as Erin joined me on the bed. I collected her in my arms, feeling the same relief I did when I came home from an out-of-town trip. She fell into my arms, and for a moment, I forgot about everything around us—Lucas, AJ, the sex dungeon, the blackmail. All of it disappeared as we melted into one another.

"I was worried about you," I said at last.

"That's sweet, but I took care of things."

"You're very capable. First you get AJ tied up. Now you got Lucas. I'm going to keep my eye on you."

She circled a finger through my chest hair. "Well, if I recall, I actually got you tied up, too. Should I get you a collar?"

"How about you get me my wife, first?"

Erin's smile felt like sunshine. "I'm here." She settled over me, taking me into her with the practice of the man and woman we were. "I'll always be here."

We blinked at one another, then laughed.

"Too sappy?" she said.

"I love it."

I glanced at AJ, who powered without restraint into Haley as Jo stood behind him, feeling his muscles and kissing his neck. That's the kind of fuck that Erin wanted—not all the time, not right now, but sometimes. If this was going to work, I'd need to be able to provide that for her.

Erin watched, too, building up steam in her hips as Haley's shrill cries built and built. I wasn't sure if she was playing this up as a porn star, or if she really was like this in bed, but she was anything but quiet.

"That's so hot," Erin said to me, her own hand snaking down to play with her clit.

I took her hips in mine, encouraging her to match pace with Aj. Erin was happily up to the task.

"You like that, don't you?" Aj said. "You've got such a tight little cunt. Hubby over there not stretch you out? He have a tiny little dick?"

I didn't need to look at Lucas to know how angry that must have made him, so I didn't. Instead, I fucked my wife as Lucas's world burned around him.

Aj pulled free of Haley with a loud, "Fuck! Baby, I'm going to bust if I don't take it easy. Night's too young."

He looked at Erin and me, then tipped his head down to the blonde. *Your turn.*

I didn't want to leave the intimacy of Erin's arms, even for the tempting offer of Haley. It was a nice thought. One that would bring a smile when I thought back on this months from now. It also gave me the strength to kiss Erin softly and sit up. "Come on, let's double team the neighbor's wife."

I got behind Haley, wrapping my arms around her. Haley's skin was coated in sweat, pink and flushed and hot to the touch. "You okay?"

"So okay," she said, breathless.

"We're going to fuck you now," I said, leaning her forward in the swing. She shifted, her legs still splayed, her ass now pointed back at me.

Haley said, "Yes please."

I pressed into her from behind. She was looser than she'd been when we'd fucked on the bed, much wetter and much more well fucked. Erin took up position on the other side of her, leaning in to kiss her on the lips. I could feel my wife's fingers working Haley's clit just above my cock. She slipped them down to squeeze my balls every other thrust. I groaned, not sure how much longer I could last doing this.

Haley was closer. "Oh, my...goodness, you two."

It felt good to hear us referred to as a team. Erin flashed me a smile over Haley, then moved down to her knees between the blonde.

Haley swayed in the harness, The leather of the swing creaked as Heather leaned back, stretching the stirrups. Her legs split wider, giving Erin open access to her pussy and my driving cock.

I fucked her hard, using the pendulous motion of the swing to drive deep and hard into her from behind. She leaned back into me, touching my neck as though wanting me to kiss her, but forgetting halfway through the gesture.

“Oh! Yes. Yes, right...right there.”

I didn't know if she was talking to Erin or me. I didn't care. She was close, and I wanted to drive her over the edge.

I said, “Erin, you ready to make her scream?”

Erin looked up at me, her fingers a blur over Haley's clit. She almost looked as turned on as if she'd been in Haley's position. Working Haley with her hand, she moved up the other woman enough to run her tongue along Haley's nipples. A couple seconds of Erin's flickering tongue ended Haley. She seized in my arms, thrusting her chest up and her hips back. She lifted her head, opened her mouth, and went off, weightless and screaming.

Erin's mouth met mine over Haley's shuddering body, and I wondered if I'd ever kiss her in a more unusual position.

Before we'd ever broken the kiss, Jo re-inserted herself into the picture.

“Look what I found,” Jo said. She was standing behind Lucas now, closer to the camera, holding a harness of black leather. It took me a moment to realize what she had—a strapon dildo. “Lucas here has all kinds of kinky things, don't you?”

AJ, lounging on the bed, looked at the restrained man. “Bet you like getting fucked in the ass, don't you, you wimpy cuck.”

I wasn't sure if it really was a prop in Lucas's dungeon, or if Jo had brought it along to set him up. Didn't matter,

though. She played it up well with the camera. Gripping the dildo by the base, she stepped up to Lucas and ran it along the crack of his ass. He struggled against the stockade, but the struggle just presented his ass more obviously.

I slipped free of Haley, who sat in the swing as if it were the more traditional type. Along with Erin, the three of us watched the dismantling of Lucas Hughes.

Jo said, "What do you think? Think I should put this on and fuck you with it?"

Lucas's eyes went wide with rage, and, I realized, fear. Maybe for the first time, he realized the enormity of what was happening here.

Jo started to step into the strapon in full view of the camera. "Yes, yes, baby. You want me to fuck your ass as your wife gets hers, don't you?"

She made a show of the strapon, turning to the camera in profile as she rubbed lube along its length.

Jo sauntered up to Lucas, and slapped him on the ass, harder than what was playful. For a moment, I thought that she might actually do it. She squeezed his ass, digging her nails into it. "You've got a great ass, Lucas. I've never fucked a man back there."

Lucas thrashed in the stockade, a caged animal suddenly realizing he was being slaughtered.

Jo's laughter was cruel. She reached back and shut off the camera. "Don't worry, Lukie. I'm not going to ass fuck you...unless you really do want it. But anyone who watches that video will probably draw a very different conclusion."

I watched as the last bit of fight left Lucas. He still looked plenty angry. If looks could kill and all that. But the struggle was gone. His spirit had been broken.

Erin gave Jo a once over. "You know, you're the only one here who hasn't fucked Haley."

Jo looked down at her plastic phallus, and laughed as though she'd forgotten it was there. "Well, I did get all dressed up."

Erin made way for Jo, who looked like the obscene version of an Amazon princess in her strapon and bare breasts. I felt Haley tremble a little.

"Are you going to be okay?" I asked.

"Yeah. Just...my arms are getting a little tired," she said.

"Want to go to the bed?"

"No, she stays right there," Jo said. To Haley: "You've got a little bit more in you. And we've barely tapped the potential of this thing, don't you think?"

AJ chuckled from the bed. "I like this girl."

The man's voice, rough as a boot on gravel, reminded me that he was still there at all. I looked over at him, reclined in the center of the bed, arms thrown behind his head in a way that seemed designed to show off his biceps.

When I glanced at Erin beside me, I knew she'd be looking, too. There was a man who'd been her lover for half of a year, a man who'd revealed a side of her that neither of us knew she had, who'd gotten her to do things that neither of us ever thought that she would.

A man—we both agreed—who could not be a part of our future.

I sensed Jo stepping into place between Haley's legs more than I saw it, but I couldn't stop looking at Erin and the way she tried to mask her hunger. I saw it. She couldn't hide it. I caught it in the way her lips were barely parted and her tongue pressed against the backs of her teeth. I glimpsed it in her slow, controlled breaths, or the way she wasn't blinking, or the way she brushed her hair back when it fell over her face.

She looked at me, remembering that I was there, and blushed deeply. She knew that I knew, and looked ready to apologize.

I stopped her with the shake of my head. This was a finale of sorts. Not for us—that wasn't a danger anymore—but it was still the end of this phase in our lives. The AJ phase. And like all good endings, it needed a proper climax.

“Have fun,” I mouthed.

She kissed me deeply, with such an outpouring of love and gratitude and warmth that I actually felt my knees falter. Then she went to him—because I’d said that it was okay—and I watched her with a rising thrill that was as strong as it had ever been. It was a reminder that somehow, someday, we weren’t done with this fantasy, even if we were at the end of the line with AJ.

Something that Jo had said a long time ago returned: *You’re part of that, too. You let her be with him.*

The real Jo took her fake cock in her hand and set it against Haley’s pussy. Up close, I realized just how large the dildo was—at least as large as AJ, and possibly as thick as Lucas when he wasn’t in a cock cage.

“It’s a big one, isn’t it?” At first, I thought Jo was talking to me. Then I felt Haley nod her head. “Excited?”

Jo didn’t wait for an answer. She pressed the tip inside with a shift of her hips, sinking it a couple inches into the blonde.

“Yeah, you’re excited,” Jo laughed, “But it’s definitely a tight fit.”

She pulled back, found her footing with the swing, and pulled the blonde into her. This time, the dildo sank deeper. Haley stiffened, threw her head back, and shouted, “Fuck, it’s big!”

I was vaguely aware of Lucas’s grunt. The rest of me was captivated by Jo and Haley and the giant dildo.

Jo said, “This is fun!” Finding momentum with the swing, she repeated the motion, burying more and more of her plastic cock. “You ever thought you’d see your wife on this, Lukey?”

Lucas grunted around the ball gag. Jo laughed again. “Hey, Tom, want to help me with something?”

“What did you have in mind?”

“So the nice thing about a sex swing is how...acrobatic you can get,” Jo explained. “Haley, dear, I want you to lean

all the way back. That's it, hang your head just like that."

My sweet neighbor did as she was told until her head was upside down and her blond hair brushed the floor. I knew exactly what my role was, but actually waited on Jo's nod to do so.

Jo nodded. I stepped forward and fed my cock between Haley's lips. At this angle, I could practically slide right into Haley's throat, although out of respect I didn't. Jo saw me hold back and shook her head.

"Uh uh. We're in the process of corrupting her, Tom. Don't hold back. Fuck her face. Trust me, she wants it."

Erin's moan drew my attention away from the two women, if only for a moment. When I looked, my breath caught. Erin was lying on her back at the edge of the bed, her legs open. Aj stood between them, his feet planted on the floor, his cock buried to the root in her smooth, wet cunt.

I rocked my hips forward, lodging my cockhead into Haley's throat. It was more to mimic Aj than anything else, but Jo encouraged. "Yes, just like that." She pinched Haley's nipples. "You like that, slut?"

I yanked out of her throat so she could breathe. She sucked in air, although that quickly turned into a gasp as Jo kept fucking her.

"You're very flexible," Jo said. She spread the other woman's legs wider. "Yoga?"

"And Pilates."

"You'll have to introduce me to your instructor." Jo nodded at me. I stepped back, and once again buried myself down her throat. Jo thrust deeply into Haley, sawing the full length of the huge dildo in and out of her with the momentum of the swing. I felt Haley's moans trembled along my cock each time Jo entered her. It felt wrong and tight and so fucking amazing. And yet I could only keep half of my mind on it. The other—the rest of me—was fixated on

the bed. On Erin and AJ and the crazy sex that they were having.

The way AJ took Erin...I'd never seen anything like it before. He *fucked* her. He wasn't gentle. He didn't seem concerned with her comfort. He dug his toes into the floor and rammed her. The force juddered the bed against the wall, the slams timed with Erin's barking moans.

She arched her back, thrusting her tits forward. Like it was an offer, AJ sucked on her nipples. Her moans grew wilder—higher pitched and off kilter. She wrapped her legs around his back as he grabbed her hips and lifted her ass from the bed.

I'd watched Erin fuck Lucas. I'd watched her fuck AJ, but only at a distance, or separated by a device. This was the first time I'd witnessed them so close. If fucking were a sport, these two were at the top of their game. It was inspiring.

Inspiring enough that Haley didn't know what hit her. I used her mouth, her throat. I heard her gag. Felt froth drip down my shaft and across my balls. I yanked away from her before I choked her, stumbling back against the wall. Haley was lost in Jo's arms. Erin was lost in AJ's. And neither couple was ready to stop.

AJ folded Erin in half, her legs over his shoulders. He grabbed her wrists and held them above her head, pinning her in place as he took her, screaming and thrashing through the first of her orgasms.

Pulling free, he said, "That was just an appetizer."

AJ flipped her over before she'd fully recovered, spreading her legs wide on the edge of the mattress. Cock in hand, he entered her, giving me an unobstructed view of his large cock entering my wife's welcoming pussy. Damn, how he stretched her. I actually moaned before I could help it.

AJ grabbed Erin by her elbows and pulled her bodily off the bed. She thrust her chest forward, a human now being

pulled taut. AJ held her tightly, continuing to plug away at her from behind. It looked like a difficult position to maintain—all balance and raw physicality—but one that AJ pulled off with ease.

I could never do that, and it shamed me as much as it made me happy. Erin enjoyed it. I enjoyed watching. I remember thinking that the next man would have to be as strong as AJ. The thought lasted all of a second. Then AJ dispelled it.

“I know what you’re thinking,” he said to Erin. His voice was gruff. Hard. It demanded an answer, even though it wasn’t a question.

“My ass,” Erin said breathily.

My stomach fluttered. I knew it was coming, but still wasn’t prepared for it.

AJ yanked her back harder, pulling her tight to him and pinning her arms harder behind her back. “What about it?”

“I want it...in my ass.”

“It?”

“Your giant, fucking cock.”

I felt like I was watching myself watch them. Felt like I was five feet behind myself as I pushed away from the wall and floated over to the bed. Even with the emotional distance, I could feel the contradictory mess of them—jealousy fed arousal fed insecurity fed disbelief fed more jealousy and more excitement. This was my wife saying these things. Doing these things. I never thought she had it in her, yet she demonstrated that she did, again and again.

“Oh, my God. So big!”

On the bed, Erin had her head down, facing me with her eyes shut tight. Her ass up was up as AJ pushed his lubed up shaft into her lubed up asshole. Erin moaned and cried with every obscene inch.

“Oh, wow,” Jo said behind me. I barely heard her.

AJ said, “Feel it, slut. You like being stuffed, don’t you?”

Erin’s answer came tortured. “Yes.”

“You’re turning into a little anal queen.”

“Yes.”

“Talk dirty, baby. You know you want to. Don’t hold back just because your husband’s here. He likes it.”

Erin’s eyes opened, searching for me. I was right there, just a couple feet away, sitting at the edge of the bed. She smiled.

AJ put a hand on her neck. “Don’t look at him. This isn’t about him. This is about you. This is what you want, right?”

She didn’t shut her eyes again. She didn’t look away. And that smile never fled. When she answered him, she was answering for me, too. “Yes, this *is* what I want.”

“Louder, slut. We can’t hear you.”

“Yes! I want this.” I sensed AJ about to prompt her more, but she spoke first. “I want you to fuck me in the ass. I want it hard. I want to be used. Use me, AJ. Use. Me!”

It was exactly what he wanted to hear, and I realized that that’s why she was saying it. It was hot. It was dramatic. But it was also theatrics. Just as she played things up to me, she played things up to AJ. And the big man inside of her had no idea.

“Fuck yeah!” He rode her, sodomizing her almost as aggressively as he’d fucked her pussy. He drove into her ass, harder and still harder until she could do nothing but scream.

Over the last year, I’d always thought that the spotlight had been on Erin and AJ. Lucas was a distraction. Haley and Jo were fun diversions. But always, deep down, I thought that the real story was whatever was going on between Erin and AJ, no matter how manipulated that beginning had been.

But as I watched AJ take her in all its raunchy, wild glory, and shared in the insanity of the moment, I realized that it was AJ that had just a small part. In a month, he would be gone, but the new Erin would remain, and I would be the one at her side.

“Fuck, baby. You’re so tight.”

“That’s because I’ve got a coke bottle wedged up my ass! Are you close?!”

“Hell yeah, I am.”

“Do it. I want to feel it back there.”

“What do we say?” AJ asked gruffly.

“Please! Please come in my ass!”

AJ slapped her cheek, rammed down to the root, and roared.

Erin clutched the sheet beside her, burying her face in the mattress as she screamed. On the opposite side of me, Haley started crying out, too. I’d forgotten that they were there, and then they were, clinging to one another, Jo’s strapon still buried deep, as they came together.

I was thankful that we were out in the middle of nowhere, hidden away in an industrial park in the dead of night. If we’d been back at the hotel room, surely someone would have called security.

Dripping sweat and breathing hard, Erin collapsed in a crumpled mess where AJ left her.

OceanofPDF.com

EIGHTEEN

We pulled ourselves together like survivors of something destructive and world changing. I went to Erin, kissing her face and smoothing her hair back. "You okay?"

She looked up at me, long and languid, like she'd finally awoken from a long, deep sleep. "Yes."

My heart fluttered. I felt the way I had way back when I'd asked her out and she'd replied, *What time?*

Vaguely, I was aware of AJ rising off the bed and beating his chest. "Well that was fucking fun," he said to no one in particular. Then, he had someone in particular. "What do you think, *Lucas?* You enjoy the show...*Lucas?*"

AJ walked up to the bound man, buck naked and completely unashamed.

"Have nothing to say?" AJ taunted. "Let's revisit, so you're totally clear in what happens next. K?"

Lucas stared at AJ with raw hatred.

AJ went on as though he was talking over coffee. "It's pretty easy. You go away. We never see you again. And if we do..." His brows went up, like a father lecturing his son. "I'll have to make your life very unpleasant. Your cuck vids shared everywhere ain't half your problem, bro, you feel me?"

AJ dressed. The rest of us followed suit. We left Lucas there to stew.

As I pulled my shirt on, though, something occurred to me. On a hunch, I moved back out into the hall. At the front of the rented space was a little office, and in that office was a safe.

"Haley, if you were to guess a four-digit pin that Lucas would use, what would it be?"

I watched Lucas as I asked the question, and got exactly what I was expecting. His eyes went wide, alarmed. I smiled.

"1024, probably," Haley said. "His birthday."

Lucas looked no less freaked out. If she wasn't correct, she was close.

Turned out, she was correct. And inside that safe, neatly stacked bills that were wrapped in bands that I recognized. It looked lighter than the fifty grand that we'd taken, but it was still a welcome sight. I even found my duffel bag in his closet.

The real kicker, though, was the USB drive also in the safe. I plucked that out, thought briefly about checking to see what else was on the little stick, then used the heavy door of the safe to snap it in two. Smiling, I slipped the broken pieces into my pocket and went about splitting up the money between the duffel bag and Lucas's briefcase. When I returned to the room, everyone was dressed, aside from Lucas.

"You'll never guess what I found over there! It's a crazy coincidence." I handed AJ the briefcase. "Give this to Lamar. Hopefully it'll get you back into his good graces."

"Or I could just keep it and start over," AJ said. I couldn't tell by his grin whether he was joking or not.

I set the bag down by the door and crossed over to Lucas. "Now, you. We're going to take your clothes, but we'll leave your wallet and phone here. Feel free to get creative to get to wherever it is you're going—but that won't be home."

I unfastened the ball gag. Lucas spit it out and contorted his mouth and jaw to stretch it.

"That's my home, asshole." If it was meant to sound intimidating, the effect was ruined by his voice cracking mid sentence.

"It was," I said. "Now it's hers."

"Says you. This is none of your business. She's my wife."

I was working open the straps that held his wrists into the stockade. There were so many ways to answer that

statement. Before I could settle on one, Erin did.

“Just one of those statements is true. One.” Her voice shook with emotion. She held up a finger, approaching him slowly, the way a predator would its prey. “She is your wife. That is true...for now. The other? That this is none of our business?” She slapped him across the face, so swiftly that it surprised everyone in the room, Lucas included. “How dare you. You made this a part of our business from the very beginning. If I ever, *ever* hear that you were skulking around my family, my friends, the fucking barista where I get coffee, then you won’t have anything left to stuff into a cock cage.” She leaned close. “Do we have an understanding?”

“I understand what you’re saying,” he said, his smile smug as ever.

I frowned, but before I could say a thing, AJ came out of nowhere.

“Fuck this guy,” he said. He drove his fist into Lucas’s jaw, the impact wet and meaty. AJ stepped back, shaking out his fist. “You’re lucky these people are so fucking...*reasonable*. I would have solved this a much different way.” He made a menacing gesture toward Lucas. “That option can still be brought back to the table.”

AJ nodded to me. I finished loosening Lucas’s wrist bindings, but left his legs held tight. He could do that himself when we were gone.

Lucas watched us leave with silent fury, but it was all a show. I saw the despair hidden behind his rage—a despair that would cripple him once we were gone.

Erin held up the key to his cock cage. “This will be sitting on the curb, where you parked.”

“Have a nice life, Lucas,” I said. “Just stay out of mine.”

We filed down the stairs, through the side storage area, and out into the night again. It looked the same as it had when we entered. It was still night. Our cars were still there. The lot was still empty. Felt strange that so much could have happened and yet the world hadn’t changed with us.

We had three cars: Haley's sedan, AJ's Camaro, and Lucas's SUV. Haley pulled out her set of keys, and the SUV opened with a chirp.

Erin went to her, wrapping her up in a deep hug. "Are you going to be okay?"

The blonde nodded. "Yes, I think I will be." And then, with a smile, "More than okay. Thank you, Erin. For everything."

"I'll see you around then?"

"I'm going to need it. Andy will, and, if I can get custody, so will Paige."

What a mess. For a frightening moment, I wondered if that's where we could have been headed. It was easy to play and fantasize when you didn't think of the consequences.

Haley came to each of us, giving us a hug. Even AJ. "It was nice to meet you, *Arnold*."

"Nice to meet you, too. And if you ever use that name again, I'm going to have to punish you."

Haley's face lit up. "I'll keep that in mind."

To Jo, she said, "He's a keeper."

I looked at Erin, confused, but my wife just smiled knowingly.

Haley climbed into her car and rolled away. We watched her go, Erin finding my arms, and Jo finding AJ's. He said, "Ready to head out, babe?"

Babe? When I looked at them, they actually looked like a couple.

Jo said, "So ready. As fun as that was, I never got fucked!"

AJ chuckled. "Well, night's still young."

I glanced down at Erin, wondering how she felt about this. Her chapter with AJ seemed to be ending, but it appeared that maybe Jo's had just begun. What an interesting story that would make.

AJ stepped up to Erin, holding his hand out. "It's been a blast. You are an amazingly dirty slut."

Erin batted her lashes. "Such a way with words. So dreamy."

"I'm glad that I got to fuck your ass one last time."

She grabbed him by the shirt and pulled him close, kissing him long and hard. "Admit it, you're going to miss me."

AJ's stony face softened, if only for a moment. "I will. I've been with a lot of crazy chicks, but you're near the top, for sure." He hugged her tightly, then, to my surprise, he grabbed me and hugged me just as hard. I felt like I'd been dropped into a vice.

When he stepped back, he lifted the briefcase I'd given him, weighed down by all the cash.

He said, "Thanks for this. You turned out to be an okay guy, considering the fact that you pretended to be a stranger in order to get your rocks off."

"You turned out okay, too, despite conspiring with a man you thought was Erin's husband to get her into bed."

AJ's laugh came from his belly. "And this is why I'm done with the two of you. It was fun—hella fun. But *fucked up*." He started to turn away, then stopped. "Actually, you know something? I have the perfect couple for you to talk to. Some mentors, or whatever. You met the guy, actually. My old boss, Max."

"Married to the stacked redhead?" I said. Erin elbowed me in the ribs.

"Katie. Yeah. I'll give their info to Jo. Seriously, you need to talk to them."

Jo put her arm around AJ and smiled at the two of us. "See you guys around," she said. "And thanks for including me in your plans. I haven't had this much fun since...Well, at least since last week."

We watched them drive away. Erin said, "Those two are perfect for each other."

"Glad you said it, and not me."

"Why?" Erin asked.

"Didn't want to make you jealous."

"Of AJ?"

"Yeah, of AJ."

She cuddled close to me, but didn't deny it. "Thanks for that."

"Hey, we should probably get out of here before Lucas comes down. I don't think he'll do anything, but let's not test him."

Erin started to place the key to his cock cage in the parking lot, thought second of it, and hurled it into the night. She looked at me, shrugged, and got into the car.

Our car sang as it raced through the night. We were headed home. *Home*. It was a nice thought.

After about fifteen minutes of silence, I found my voice, but couldn't figure out what to use it for. I settled on a generic: "That was intense."

Erin had her chin resting on her hand as she stared out the window. I wasn't sure that she even saw the wooded darkness as it slid by. Apparently she did hear me, though. "Which part?"

When she turned to me, the distance fell away. Like she'd stepped across it all and was suddenly standing right by my side.

"Watching you with AJ was..." I searched for the right word.

Before I could find it, Erin said, "I'm sorry for that."

"Was going to say something like *inspiring*. *Intense* would have worked, too, but I just used it." Keeping my eyes on the road, I reached beside her and found her hand. "But nothing to apologize about. It may have been one of the hottest things I've ever seen. Ever."

"You've seen some pretty crazy stuff," Erin remarked.

"Never like that. And never in person."

"I'm—"

“Don’t,” I interrupted. “We’re long past the sorrys. I only want to hear it if you truly mean it.”

Erin was quiet for a long moment. “If I hurt you, I mean it.”

“And you didn’t hurt me. Made me jealous, sure. Turned me on? Absolutely. But you didn’t hurt me.” I risked taking my eyes off of the road to glance at her. Turned out, she was studying me, and when our eyes met, she nodded.

“Okay. And if it ever does...”

“I’ll tell you right away.”

I went back to the road. Erin snuggled as close to me as she could, considering the seatbelts.

After a stretch, she said, “I’m glad that you were there.”

“I’m glad I could watch.”

Erin shook her head. “Not just that. I’m glad you saw that side of me. And when I saw you looking, I felt like...like I could really let go.”

“I’m glad you did.”

We arrived at our exit, pulling off and slowing down. Like our lives, the world went from fast paced to sleepy and suburban in the matter of a turn.

“So do you think that’s it?” I said. “Think Lucas will try something?”

“I think Lucas is smart enough to know when to cut his losses. I worry a little about the kids, but he won’t be bothering us anymore.”

“And what about us? Still planning on saying goodbye to AJ?” I said.

“I think I just did.” She paused, then added, “And I’m only partially talking about the hug at the end.”

I laughed. “Then that was some goodbye.”

We pulled into our driveway. We were back home, ready to start things anew.

“I love you, you know that?” Erin said.

“I do. It’s pretty awesome, having a chick like you love me.”

“Ha. I think you’re supposed to say, *I love you, too.*”

I said, “Well, of course I do.”

Her laugh came out as a sob—joyous and emotional and pure. We kissed there in the car, and when she pulled away, I felt tears in my own eyes.

“I love you, Erin. And I can’t believe that I’m married to such a nymphomaniac.”

Erin laughed and blushed at the same time. “Kind of out of control.”

“Yeah, but so hot,” I said.

“Come on, let’s go inside,” she said. “Time to reclaim your wife.”

OceanofPDF.com

EPILOGUE

I was watching something mindless on TV as I thought about the last few months. Erin had been right, Lucas wasn't a problem for anyone. He moved out of the house, and then out of the city, leaving both kids with Haley without a fight. I was still wary for the day that he'd return, but as the weeks slipped by, that fear grew less and less.

Haley had logged into his personal laptop, deleting any files that he'd kept on there. She'd also done a sweep of his accounts, scrubbing anything incriminating from the cloud as best she could. Then, for good measure—with a side of vindictiveness—she'd burned the laptop. We'd all been there. It was somehow more cathartic than anything else we'd done.

Lucas's departure was only a small relief. He left behind a single mother of two. Erin and I had done what we could to support Haley, and while she never failed to impress me with her optimism and strength, we could still see the scars.

The scandal swept through our small neighborhood, although all that anyone really knew was that Lucas had been having affairs and Haley finally found out. There was some talk that Erin was involved, but Erin and Haley's continued friendship hurt that rumor's credibility.

AJ hadn't won Lamar back, but the repayment got him a decent referral from the track star. He'd moved out to LA full-time, and when we heard that he and Jo were actually a real couple, neither Erin nor I were surprised.

As for Erin and me, things were...good. Better than ever. We'd put the games on hold, focusing on one another. We felt like newlyweds, only without all the self-discovery. It was glorious.

We'd even met AJ's friends, Katie and Max, for drinks one night. They were an amazing couple, and even though

we spent most of the night talking about mundane things like jobs and hobbies, I already knew it was going to be the first of many nights.

The thing they emphasized most was the importance of communication. And to set rules. And to never, *ever* break them. We walked away with a feeling of excitement for our future, but also a reassurance that we'd already started doing the right things. It had taken a few stumbles along the way—and I imagined there would be more to come—but we weren't on the road to ruin.

And that brings us up to now...

Erin came back from the gym, slumping against the front door with a heavy sigh.

"Good work out?" I asked.

"Too good. I'm sore everywhere."

"It's definitely paying off."

She rolled her eyes, but I knew she appreciated it. It was mid-spring and she'd just pulled out the tight, cropped yoga pants and tank tops. Her skin still glistened with perspiration.

I shut the television off, whatever it was. "So does the new guy have potential?"

Erin's smile set my heart racing. After going through several new personal trainers, she'd finally found one that caught her eye. Manuel. Said he didn't speak great English, but she was fine with that.

Erin approached me, rolling her hips hypnotically. I pictured Manuel watching her do that in the gym, standing behind her as they moved from machine to machine. My mouth went dry.

"Well, he's a good kisser."

I stood to meet her, wrapping her up in my arms. When we kissed, I wondered if I was tasting him, too.

"Anything else?"

"I only brushed it, but he might have the biggest cock I've felt yet."

My chest tightened. "When do you confirm?"

Erin twirled away. "Haven't decided yet. I'm playing this one slow. I already told him that the kiss was a mistake. That I was *married*."

"Poor guy."

"Shower with me? I'm all dirty."

I laughed.

She said, "This one's going to be so fun to train."

OceanofPDF.com